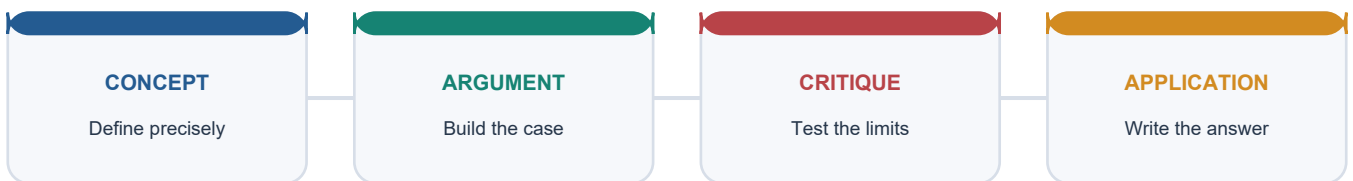


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Quine and Strawson - Complete Learning Session

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I, Section A | 18 teaching sessions, 32 diagnostics, 9 solved PYQs, 6 original Mains models and register notes

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Quine and Strawson - Complete Learning Session

Syllabus, verbatim: *Quine and Strawson : Critique of Empiricism; Theory of Basic Particulars and Persons* - UPSC Philosophy Paper I, Section A, item 11. Two printed thinkers and two printed limbs, and the limbs are **not** shared: the critique of empiricism is **Quine's** printed burden, and the theory of basic particulars and persons is **Strawson's**. □ The paper prints the item with a space before the colon; the spacing is preserved only inside a verbatim quotation of the syllabus. **Evidence discipline:** FACT: marks doctrine on which the standard sources converge, ANALYSIS: marks analytical reconstruction for exam use, and CAUTION: marks a live scholarly dispute or a contested attribution. Both philosophers wrote in English, so the discipline on this clause is not translation but **dating, attribution and formula-accuracy** - the commonest way to lose marks here is to misdate a paper, to merge two proposals into one, or to quote a slogan from the wrong book. Model answers below are independent learner practice and are **never** official UPSC keys: UPSC publishes no descriptive model answer for Philosophy Paper I. **Terminology rule:** the English concept leads and the technical term follows immediately in parentheses - *sameness of meaning (synonymy)*, *substitution preserving truth (interchangeability salva veritate)*, *stipulated rules of an artificial language (semantical rules)*, *confirmation holism (the web of belief)*, *the whole-system test (the Duhem-Quine thesis)*, *tidying a theory into quantificational logic (regimentation)*, *what a theory says there is (ontological commitment)*, *translation from scratch (radical translation)*, *undetermined reference (inscrutability of reference)*, *rival manuals that fit all behaviour (indeterminacy of translation)*, *reference relative to a background theory (ontological relativity)*, *mapping the scheme we actually use (descriptive metaphysics)*, *proposing a better scheme (revisionary metaphysics)*, *the things whose identification everything else depends on (basic particulars)*, *picking out and picking out again (identification and re-identification)*, *body-predicates (M-predicates)*, *consciousness-predicates (P-predicates)*, *experiences that belong to nobody (the no-ownership or no-subject theory)*, *a background condition for a true-or-false use (presupposition)*. A technical term may sharpen an English explanation; it may never replace one.

What this package contains

Component	Count
Progressive teaching sessions in the Basic block	18
Original diagnostic MCQs - 24 core plus 8 remedial drills	32
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Directly owned verified PYQs solved in full, 2018-2025	9
Original solved Mains models - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks	6
Consolidated register parts	18 (A-R)
ASCII master flow panels authored	42

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

CONCEPT SPINE - ENGLISH FIRST, TECHNICAL TERM IMMEDIATELY AFTER

THE ONE THING THIS CLAUSE IS ABOUT
 CLASSICAL AND LOGICAL EMPIRICISM MADE TWO PROMISES: THAT MEANING COULD BE
 SORTED INTO TRUE-BY-MEANING AND TRUE-BY-FACT, AND THAT THE WORLD COULD BE
 REBUILT OUT OF PRIVATE SENSORY GIVENS. QUINE BREAKS THE FIRST PROMISE FROM
 INSIDE EMPIRICISM. STRAWSON SHOWS THE SECOND CANNOT EVEN GET STARTED.

THE WARNING THAT MUST COME FIRST

THIS IS ONE PRINTED HEADING CARRYING TWO SEPARATE PROJECTS. THE TWO MEN
 ARE NOT ALLIES: GRICE AND STRAWSON DEFEND, IN 'IN DEFENCE OF A DOGMA'
 (1956), EXACTLY THE DISTINCTION QUINE ATTACKED IN 1951. NEVER WRITE
 'THE QUINE-STRAWSON CRITIQUE' AS THOUGH IT WERE ONE DOCTRINE.

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+-----+
| THE TWO PRINTED LIMBS |
| 1 CRITIQUE OF EMPIRICISM ... QUINE |
| 2 THEORY OF BASIC PARTICULARS |
| AND PERSONS ..... STRAWSON |
+-----+

```

QUINE 1908-2000	STRAWSON 1919-2006
'TWO DOGMAS OF EMPIRICISM'	'INDIVIDUALS: AN ESSAY IN
PHILOSOPHICAL REVIEW, JAN	DESCRIPTIVE METAPHYSICS' 1959
1951; REVISED IN 'FROM A	'ON REFERRING', MIND, 1950
LOGICAL POINT OF VIEW' 1953	
DOGMA 1 THE ANALYTIC/SYNTHETIC	DESCRIPTIVE METAPHYSICS =
DISTINCTION -> UNTENABLE	DESCRIBE THE SCHEME WE ACTUALLY
analytic -> meaning ->	USE. REVISIONARY = PROPOSE A
SYNONYMY -> definition	BETTER ONE.
(records synonymy) OR	descriptive: ARISTOTLE, KANT
INTERCHANGEABILITY salva	revisionary: DESCARTES,
veritate (needs NECESSITY)	LEIBNIZ, BERKELEY
OR SEMANTICAL RULES	
-> EVERY ROUTE CIRCLES BACK	BASIC PARTICULARS = MATERIAL
DOGMA 2 REDUCTIONISM -> EACH	BODIES (and PERSONS)
SENTENCE HAS ITS OWN CONFIRMING	IDENTIFICATION needs
EXPERIENCES -> UNTENABLE	RE-IDENTIFICATION needs ONE
POSITIVE DOCTRINE	PUBLIC SPATIO-TEMPORAL
CONFIRMATION HOLISM	FRAMEWORK
'statements ... face the	private + momentary +
tribunal of sense experience	non-spatial SENSE-DATA CANNOT
not individually but only as	SUPPLY ONE
a corporate body'	PERSON = A PRIMITIVE CONCEPT
THE WEB OF BELIEF	M-PREDICATES (weighs 70 kg)
'ANY STATEMENT CAN BE HELD TRUE	+ P-PREDICATES (is in pain)
COME WHAT MAY, IF WE MAKE	ascribed to ONE thing
DRASTIC ENOUGH ADJUSTMENTS	SELF-ASCRPTION REQUIRES
ELSEWHERE IN THE SYSTEM'	OTHER-ASCRPTION -> the concept
'NO STATEMENT IS IMMUNE TO	is NOT built from mind + body
REVISION'	UNDERCUTS BOTH CARTESIAN
RESULT: EMPIRICISM WITHOUT THE	DUALISM AND THE NO-OWNERSHIP
DOGMAS - STILL AN EMPIRICIST	THEORY
	RESULT: BODIES AND PERSONS ARE
	BASIC IN OUR SCHEME

THE ENGINE UNDER QUINE'S HOLISM: THE DUHEM-QUINE THESIS
 (H & A) -> 0 ; OBSERVE NOT-0 ; MODUS TOLLENS GIVES ONLY NOT-(H & A).
 LOGIC NEVER NAMES THE GUILTY CONJUNCT. SO REVISION IS CHOSEN, NOT DICTATED.

DUHEM 1906 ... PHYSICS ONLY; LOGIC AND MATHEMATICS EXEMPT

QUINE 1951 ... ALL OF KNOWLEDGE; 'THE UNIT OF EMPIRICAL SIGNIFICANCE IS
 THE WHOLE OF SCIENCE'; NOTHING EXEMPT

THE PAIR THAT PROVES THE POINT: URANUS -> REVISE THE AUXILIARY -> NEPTUNE
 FOUND 1846. MERCURY -> REVISE THE AUXILIARY -> 'VULCAN' DOES NOT EXIST;
 THE CORRECT REVISION WAS THE DEEP ONE, GENERAL RELATIVITY 1915.

THE SHAPE OF STRAWSON'S ARGUMENT: TRANSCENDENTAL IN FORM

- 1 TAKE AN UNDISPUTED FACT ABOUT OUR THOUGHT OR TALK
 - 2 ASK WHAT MUST BE SO FOR IT TO BE POSSIBLE
 - 3 SHOW THE EMPIRICIST'S MATERIALS CANNOT SATISFY THE CONDITION
 - 4 CONCLUDE THAT SOMETHING ELSE IS BASIC - CONCEPTUALLY, NOT CAUSALLY
- THE CONCLUSION IS ABOUT OUR CONCEPTUAL SCHEME, NOT ABOUT MIND-INDEPENDENT

REALITY. STRAWSON SAYS SO HIMSELF: HIS METAPHYSICS IS DESCRIPTIVE.

WHAT IS NOT OWNED HERE	
THE VERIFICATION PRINCIPLE, AYER, CARNAP AND THE VIENNA	
CIRCLE AS DOCTRINE	Topic 07, Logical Positivism
HUME'S IMPRESSIONS/IDEAS, BUNDLE SELF AND	
INDUCTION AS DOCTRINE	Topic 03, Empiricism
KANT'S SYNTHETIC A PRIORI AND THE	
TRANSCENDENTAL DEDUCTION AS DOCTRINE	Topic 04, Kant
RUSSELL'S THEORY OF DESCRIPTIONS AS	
DOCTRINE	Topic 06, Moore-Russell- Early Wittgenstein
MEANING AS USE, LANGUAGE-GAMES, THE PRIVATE	
LANGUAGE ARGUMENT AS DOCTRINE	Topic 08, Later Wittgenstein
STRAWSON ON FREEDOM, RESENTMENT AND THE	
REACTIVE ATTITUDES	bounded, cross-owned; NOT a printed limb and NOT PYQ-owned
STRAWSON ON INDUCTION AND ON KANT	bounded enrichment only
PERSONAL IDENTITY OVER TIME, THE SOUL,	
IMMORTALITY	Paper II

Concept spine: read it downward. One target, one warning, two printed limbs owned by one thinker each, the engine under Quine's holism, the shape of Strawson's argument - and a fence around what belongs to other clauses.

MEMORY: **Mnemonic - the whole clause in one line. "Quine kills TWO dogmas; Strawson saves TWO Ps."** Quine destroys the analytic/synthetic distinction and reductionism; Strawson makes **Particulars** (material bodies) and **Persons** the irreducible basics. If you can write that sentence and then expand each half accurately, you have the architecture of every question on this item. MEMORY: **Mnemonic - the circle of synonymy, "S-D-I-S".** Synonymy -> **Definition** (merely records a synonymy) -> **Interchangeability *salva veritate*** (needs necessity, and necessity needs analyticity) -> **Semantical rules** (classify a stipulated language without explaining the general notion). Four stations, every one of them returning to the platform it left. MEMORY: **Mnemonic - the two halves of the famous sentence, "COME WHAT MAY... IF".** FACT: "*Any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system.*" The conditional clause **is** the doctrine. A script that quotes only the first half has written relativism, not Quine. MEMORY: **Mnemonic - Duhem against Quine, "P-L-S".** Physics only (Duhem) against all knowledge; Logic and mathematics exempt (Duhem) against nothing exempt; **Scope** is therefore the difference, not the logic. The shared label "Duhem-Quine thesis" is later shorthand for two non-identical claims, and saying so is worth a mark. MEMORY: **Mnemonic - the person, "M and P on one thing".** A person is not a body **to which** a mind is attached. It is the one thing to which **both** body-predicates (M) and consciousness-predicates (P) are ascribed. Drop either half and you have restated materialism or dualism, which is precisely what the doctrine denies. MEMORY: **Mnemonic - the P-predicate's double life.** Ascribed to **others** on publicly available behavioural and situational criteria; ascribed to **oneself** without observing one's own behaviour. A concept with that double condition cannot be assembled from an independently identifiable body plus an independently identifiable consciousness - which is what "primitive" means here. MEMORY: **Mnemonic - the two failures of empiricism, "CONFIRM and REFER".** Empiricism failed twice: about how theories are **confirmed** (Quine) and about how we so much as **refer** to anything (Strawson). That single sentence is the only legitimate way to treat the pairing as a unity.

ANSWER-WORTHINESS - WHAT EARNS MARKS AND WHAT DOES NOT

Classification	Content
CORE MAINS	The two-project warning and the exact ownership of each printed limb; Dogma 1 with the complete chain of failed explications - meaning, synonymy, definition, interchangeability salva veritate with the <i>extensional counter-case</i> and the <i>necessity regress</i>, and Carnap's semantical rules; the <i>precise statement of what Quine does and does not conclude</i>; Dogma 2, reductionism, and why it is called reductionism; confirmation holism with both <i>canonical sentences</i> and the web / field of force metaphor, the <i>periphery</i>, the <i>interior</i>, the <i>three revision options</i> and the <i>pragmatic virtues</i>; the consequences - <i>no sharp analytic/synthetic line</i>, <i>no sharp a priori/a posteriori line</i>, <i>pressure on the positivist meaning-criterion</i>; the Duhem-Quine thesis with the <i>numbered modus tollens argument</i>, the <i>four-row Duhem-against-Quine table</i>, and the Neptune/Vulcan pair; the revisability of logic with Birkhoff and von Neumann (1936) kept separate from Putnam (1968), and Quine's own later retreat in <i>Philosophy of Logic (1970)</i> - "<i>change of logic, change of subject</i>" and the maxim of minimum mutilation; empiricism without the dogmas; Grice and Strawson, "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956) and Quine's rejoinder; the 2018 "metaphysical article of faith" framing correctly labelled as the paper's wording; ontological commitment and "to be is to be the value of a bound variable" with <i>regimentation</i> and the <i>parsimony caution</i>; radical translation, gavagai, stimulus meaning, occasion and standing sentences, observation sentences, analytical hypotheses, inscrutability of reference, indeterminacy of translation and ontological relativity, with the <i>identity-predicate move</i> and the Chomsky objection; naturalized epistemology with the <i>normativity objection</i> and Quine's engineering reply; Strawson's descriptive against revisionary metaphysics with his own examples; basic particulars with the argument from identification and re-identification, the <i>single spatio-temporal framework</i>, the no-space (purely auditory) world and the <i>analogue of space</i>, and feature-placing; the person as a primitive concept with M-predicates and P-predicates, the self-ascription requires other-ascription argument and the dual character of P-predicates; the demolition of Cartesian dualism's starting point and of the no-ownership (no-subject) theory; and all nine routed 2018-2025 question-parts
CORE SUPPORTING	The provenance rail, because this clause tests dating and attribution as directly as doctrine - 1948, 1950, 1951, 1953, 1956, 1959, 1960, 1966, 1968/69, 1970, and Duhem 1906; "On Referring" (1950) against Russell's "On Denoting" (1905), presupposition against assertion, and the <i>truth-value caution</i>; the five bounded connections between Strawson's positive doctrines and empiricist starting points; the transcendental argument-form in four steps; the criticism ledgers for both thinkers with replies and residues; the directive decoder; and the graded verdict bank at 10, 15 and 20 marks
SUPPORTING	<i>Word and Object (1960)</i> chapter 2 as the location of radical translation, and Neurath's boat as its epigraph; Duhem's own restriction of his thesis to physics; Popper's methodological reply and Lakatos's research programmes; Davidson on radical interpretation (1973) as the influential softening; Searle and Evans on the reflexive application of indeterminacy; the Quine and later Wittgenstein convergence and the decisive point where they part; <i>The Bounds of Sense (1966)</i> and <i>Introduction to Logical Theory (1952)</i> as the outer edge of Strawson's corpus
OPTIONAL ADVANCED	Whether indeterminacy of translation is a distinct metaphysical thesis or merely the ordinary underdetermination of theory by evidence applied to semantics; whether descriptive metaphysics is conservative common-sense mapping, a transcendental defence of the scheme within which all revision must begin, or a modest methodological programme; and whether "person is primitive" is an argued conclusion or a stipulation that ends analysis without explaining the psychophysical unity

Classification	Content
NOT OWNED HERE	The verification principle, Ayer, Carnap's <i>Aufbau</i> and the Vienna Circle as doctrine (Topic 07 - they enter here only as the position Quine dismantles); Hume's impressions and ideas, the bundle self and the problem of induction as doctrine (Topic 03); Kant's synthetic a priori, the transcendental deduction and the antinomies as doctrine (Topic 04 - Kant enters only through the 2018 question's framing and Strawson's affinity); Russell's theory of descriptions as doctrine (Topic 06 - it is the rival "On Referring" answers, not a topic to expound); meaning as use, language-games and the private-language argument as doctrine (Topic 08); Strawson on freedom, resentment and the reactive attitudes, which the owner records as bounded or cross-owned material and which owns no part of the 2018-2025 corpus - name it in one clause if a question invites it, and never let it displace basic particulars or persons; Strawson on induction and his Kant interpretation beyond one sentence each; personal identity over time, the soul and immortality (Paper II)

ANALYSIS: **Ownership boundary, stated once.** This clause owns **9 of 112** Western Philosophy question-parts in the 2018-2025 corpus. Four consequences follow, and all four are visible in the first paragraph of a script. First, **the two thinkers are almost never mixed in one part**: five parts are Quine's (2018 Q2(c), 2019 Q1(e), 2021 Q3(c), 2024 Q4(c), 2025 Q4(b)) and four are Strawson's (2018 Q1(e), 2020 Q3(b), 2021 Q3(b), 2023 Q4(a)), so the very first decision is which thinker the stem names. Second, **the distribution is uneven across years**: two parts each in 2018 and 2021, one each in 2019, 2020, 2023, 2024 and 2025, and **none at all in 2022** - the item is frequent but not guaranteed, so it must be prepared to answer rather than to recognise. Third, **the paper tests exact formulations**: 2025 Q4(b) hands you a sentence and requires the conditional clause to survive, and 2018 Q2(c) hands you a phrase - "a metaphysical article of faith" - that is **the paper's framing, not a verified verbatim Quine quotation**, so it must be handled without being placed in quotation marks as Quine's own formula. Fourth, **the Strawson parts escalate**: a 10-marker on the person concept in 2018, a 15-marker on spatio-temporal thinking in 2020, a 15-marker on both material bodies and persons in 2021, and a 20-marker in 2023 that adds the implication for mind-body dualism. The same doctrine is being asked at four depths, so the material must be prepared as one argument that can be told short or long.

HOW TO READ THIS SESSION

Every subtopic below runs in the same order, so the shape becomes automatic:

Step	What it gives you
DEFINITION	plain-language definition, then the technical one
ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING	a sentence you can adapt directly as an introduction or a conclusion
MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS	the terms that signal control of the topic
Plain-language visual	the idea before the vocabulary
VISUAL: VISUAL	the diagram that carries the argument
Numbered teaching	the doctrine, point by point, with work, section and date
HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH	claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification, written out for this subtopic
Exam link	which routed PYQ this subtopic answers, and how
UPSC traps	the specific ways candidates lose marks here
Revision notes	the compressed recall list
CLOSING RECALL FLOW	the subtopic reduced to one flow you can redraw from memory

Complete the Basic block first. Interpretive depth - whether indeterminacy is a distinct thesis or ordinary underdetermination, whether descriptive metaphysics is conservative or transcendental, and whether "primitive" is an argument or a stipulation - is deliberately withheld until the clearly labelled optional block after the practice sections. Nothing in that block is needed to write a complete answer to any of the nine routed questions.

ORIGIN AND CHRONOLOGY - THE MINIMUM NEEDED TO AVOID ANACHRONISM

ANALYSIS: This clause has an unusual hazard: **two philosophers, eight key texts, one famous slogan that comes from a different paper than the one candidates cite, one co-authored reply routinely credited to a single author, and one technical proposal that is regularly merged with the later claim made about it.** The rail below prevents the seven commonest errors - sourcing "to be is to be the value of a bound variable" to "Two Dogmas"; dating naturalized epistemology to 1951; attributing "In Defence of a Dogma" to Strawson alone; writing "Putnam/Birkhoff" as a joint proposal; treating Duhem's thesis and Quine's as the same claim; treating "On Referring" as an application of descriptive metaphysics rather than its precursor; and calling the 2018 phrase "a metaphysical article of faith" a verified Quine quotation.

- 1905 RUSSELL, 'On Denoting' - the theory of descriptions.
Topic 06's property; the position 'On Referring' answers.
- 1906 DUHEM, La Theorie physique: son objet, sa structure.
Eng. The Aim and Structure of Physical Theory, tr. Wiener, 1954.
PHYSICS ONLY. Logic and mathematics EXEMPT.
- 1928 CARNAP, Der logische Aufbau der Welt - the construction of the world
from private experience. Topic 07's property; the programme
Strawson's basic particulars argument makes unworkable.
- 1934 POPPER, Logik der Forschung. Eng. 1959. Accepts the logical point
of Duhem-Quine and answers it METHODOLOGICALLY, not by denying it.
- 1936 BIRKHOFF AND VON NEUMANN, 'The Logic of Quantum Mechanics',
Annals of Mathematics. The FORMAL proposal of a non-distributive
lattice. NOT yet the claim that logic is empirical.
- 1948 QUINE, 'On What There Is', Review of Metaphysics.
The criterion of ONTOLOGICAL COMMITMENT is developed HERE.
'To be is to be the value of a bound variable' is the standard
slogan for it. IT IS NOT FROM 'TWO DOGMAS'.
- 1950 STRAWSON, 'On Referring', Mind.
PRESUPPOSITION against Russell's ASSERTED existence-claim.
PREDATES Individuals by nine years - a PRECURSOR, not an
application of descriptive metaphysics.
- 1951 QUINE, 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism', The Philosophical Review,
JANUARY 1951. The web-of-belief passage is section 6,
'Empiricism without the Dogmas'. CITE THE SECTION.
- 1952 STRAWSON, Introduction to Logical Theory.
The dissolution of the problem of induction, ch. 9. Optional.
- 1953 QUINE, From a Logical Point of View - 'Two Dogmas' REVISED and
reprinted. Both dates are correct for different versions.
- 1956 GRICE AND STRAWSON, 'In Defence of a Dogma',
The Philosophical Review. CO-AUTHORED. Note the British
spelling 'Defence'. This is the direct clash inside the clause.
- 1959 STRAWSON, Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics.
Basic particulars: Part I. Persons: ch. 3.
The SUBTITLE contains the phrase - quote the subtitle, it is exact.
- 1960 QUINE, Word and Object. Radical translation, gavagai, stimulus
meaning, analytical hypotheses: CH. 2.
Epigraph: NEURATH'S BOAT.
- 1962 STRAWSON, 'Freedom and Resentment' - the reactive attitudes.
NOT a printed limb. NOT PYQ-owned. One clause maximum.
- 1966 STRAWSON, The Bounds of Sense. The Kant interpretation, including
the 'non-sequitur of numbing grossness' charge against the Second
Analogy. Bounded; belongs mainly to Topic 04.
- 1968 PUTNAM, 'Is Logic Empirical?' THE CLAIM that the distributive law
should be revised on EMPIRICAL grounds. Reprinted 1976 as
'The Logic of Quantum Mechanics'. PUTNAM LATER ABANDONED IT.
- 1968 QUINE, Dewey Lectures, 'Ontological Relativity'.
- 1969 Published in Ontological Relativity and Other Essays - the SAME
volume as 'Epistemology Naturalized'.
DO NOT DATE NATURALIZED EPISTEMOLOGY TO 1951.
- 1969 CHOMSKY, 'Quine's Empirical Assumptions', in Words and Objections.
The underdetermination objection. Attribute it to CHOMSKY.
- 1970 QUINE, Philosophy of Logic. 'Change of logic, change of subject'
and the MAXIM OF MINIMUM MUTILATION. The LATER Quine is a poor
witness for the EARLIER Quine's most radical claim.
- 1973 DAVIDSON, 'Radical Interpretation'. INTERPRETATION, not
translation - the change of word marks the change of doctrine.
- 1985 STRAWSON, Skepticism and Naturalism - transcendental arguments
limited to internal, descriptive work. Optional.

Chronology rail: read it as a ledger of what may be cited and how. The seven marked lines are the ones the paper has actually tested or that candidates routinely get wrong.

ONE-SCREEN ROUTE MAP

```

WHICH THINKER DOES THE STEM NAME?
=====
'two dogmas' / 'analytic' / 'synthetic' / 'reductionism' /
'web of belief' / 'affirm any sentence' / 'a priori ... article of
faith' / 'empiricism without the dogmas' -> QUINE
|
'basic particulars' / 'material bodies' / 'spatio-temporal' /
'person' / 'primitive concept' / 'mind-body dualism' /
'descriptive metaphysics' -> STRAWSON
|
'critique of empiricism' with NO further signal -> QUINE leads,
STRAWSON enters as ONE bounded paragraph, never as a co-author.
=====
|
IF QUINE: DOGMA 1 (circle) -> DOGMA 2 (reductionism) ->
HOLISM (web + both quotations) -> DUHEM-QUINE (modus tollens,
Neptune/Vulcan) -> LIMITS (minimum mutilation, 1970) ->
VERDICT (empiricism reformed, not abandoned)
|
IF STRAWSON: DESCRIPTIVE vs REVISIONARY -> IDENTIFICATION needs
RE-IDENTIFICATION needs ONE FRAMEWORK -> sense-data are
private, momentary, non-spatial -> MATERIAL BODIES BASIC ->
PERSONS: M + P predicates on ONE thing -> self-ascription
requires other-ascription -> DUALISM and NO-OWNERSHIP both
presuppose what they deny -> VERDICT (conceptual scheme,
descriptively established, not a proof of what exists)
=====
CLOSING QUALIFICATION THAT LIFTS EITHER ANSWER
QUINE: the result is the failure of an EXPLICATION, not the claim
that 'all bachelors are unmarried' is false.
STRAWSON: the result is about OUR CONCEPTUAL SCHEME; an empiricist can
accept the whole of Individuals as conceptual geography while
denying that it settles what exists. Conceding this STRENGTHENS
the answer.

```

Route map: decide the owner from the stem, then run that thinker's spine, then close on the qualification that shows you know the limits of the result you have just defended.

SESSION 1 - WHAT THE PRINTED CLAUSE ASKS, AND WHY "QUINE AND STRAWSON" IS ONE HEADING OVER TWO PROJECTS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The syllabus puts two mid-twentieth-century philosophers under one heading because both damaged empiricism, but they damaged different parts of it, for different reasons, and they publicly disagreed with each other.

Technical definition: Willard Van Orman Quine (1908-2000) mounts an **internal** critique of empiricism: in "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (*The Philosophical Review*, January **1951**) he argues that the analytic/synthetic distinction cannot be non-circularly explicated and that no statement is confirmed in isolation, and he replaces both with **confirmation holism**, retaining sensory evidence and scientific naturalism as "empiricism without the dogmas". Peter Frederick Strawson (1919-2006) mounts a **positive** programme: in *Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics* (1959) he argues that identifying and re-identifying any particular presupposes a single public spatio-temporal framework of enduring **material bodies**, and that the concept of a **person** is logically primitive - conclusions that make the empiricist's private momentary sense-datum unfit to be the basic particular.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The syllabus pairs two critics of empiricism who criticise it at different levels: Quine reforms its **theory of confirmation** from inside and remains an empiricist, while Strawson shows that its **starting point** - private, momentary sense-data - cannot support the identification and self-ascription our conceptual scheme actually performs.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- critique of empiricism · two dogmas · confirmation holism · empiricism without the dogmas
- descriptive metaphysics · basic particulars · person as primitive

- "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956) - the proof that they are not allies

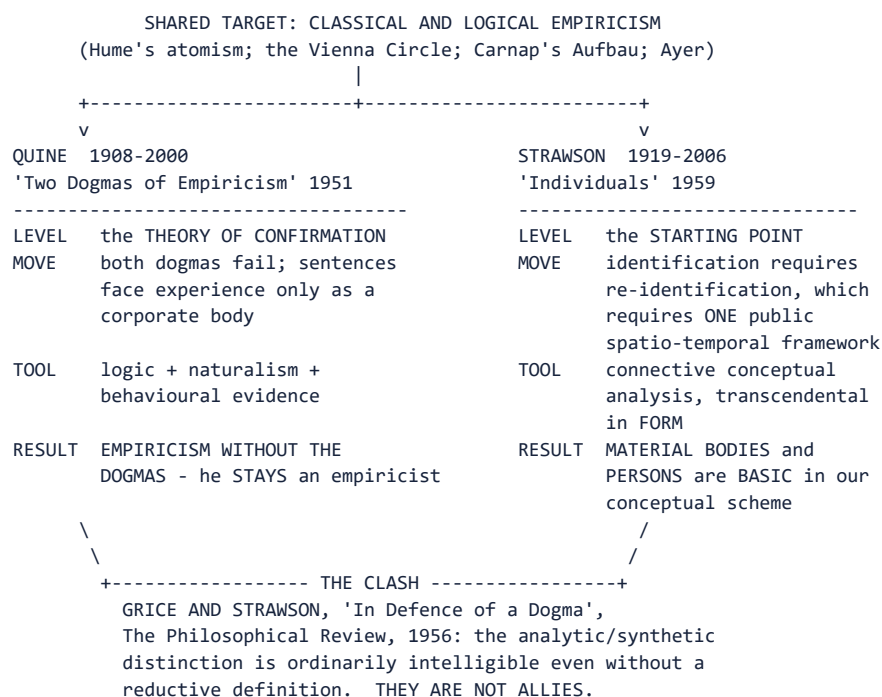
How to use them: state the shared target in one clause, split it into Quine's dogmas-and-holism and Strawson's particulars-and-persons, cite the 1956 paper to block the "united front" reading, and only then narrow to the thinker the stem names.

Plain-language visual - what each man is attacking

- THE EMPIRICIST'S TWO PROMISES
1. 'We can sort every meaningful sentence into TRUE BY MEANING and TRUE BY FACT, and check the second against experience one sentence at a time.' <-- QUINE BREAKS THIS
 2. 'We can rebuild the whole world - objects, other people, ourselves - out of private sensory givens.' <-- STRAWSON SHOWS THIS CANNOT EVEN START

Two promises, two demolitions, two entirely different tools.

VISUAL: VISUAL - one target, two non-identical critiques



Caption: one printed heading, two philosophers doing two different jobs, and a documented disagreement between them. The diagram is the answer-plan for any question that names both.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. **FACT: The printed clause divides cleanly.** The safest parse, and the one the verified papers use, assigns "**Critique of Empiricism**" to Quine and "**Theory of Basic Particulars and Persons**" to Strawson. Nine question-parts between 2018 and 2025 respect this division without a single exception: five name Quine's material, four name Strawson's, and none asks for a joint doctrine.
2. **FACT: Quine's burden, precisely.** Two dogmas, the failed explications of analyticity, reductionism, confirmation holism, revisability, and the retained empiricism that survives their removal.
3. **FACT: Strawson's burden, precisely.** Descriptive metaphysics, identification and re-identification, the public spatio-temporal framework, material bodies, and the person as a primitive concept with its two predicate-classes.
4. **ANALYSIS: The enrichment fence.** Quine's ontological commitment, naturalized epistemology, radical translation, inscrutability of reference and ontological relativity are **bounded system-enrichment**: fully available, taught in full below, but not independently printed or PYQ-owned in 2018-2025. They are used **after** the two-dogmas burden is discharged, never instead of it. Strawson's "On Referring", his Kant interpretation, his treatment of induction and his work on freedom and the reactive attitudes are **bounded or cross-owned**, and must not displace basic particulars and persons.

5. ANALYSIS: **What the pairing is, and is not.** It is a **problem-field**, not a thesis: both show that classical empiricism failed twice over, once about **confirmation** and once about **reference**. It is not an agreement about analyticity, meaning, method, or the revisability of the conceptual scheme - and the 1956 paper is the documentary proof.
6. FACT: **The corpus signal.** 9 of 112 Western Philosophy parts, 2018-2025; two each in 2018 and 2021; one each in 2019, 2020, 2023, 2024 and 2025; **none in 2022.**

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: The syllabus heading covers two distinct critiques rather than one. **Evidence:** Quine's "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951) attacks the analytic/synthetic distinction and reductionism and replaces them with confirmation holism, while Strawson's *Individuals* (1959) argues that identification and re-identification presuppose one public spatio-temporal framework of material bodies and that the concept of a person is primitive. **Analysis:** the two results converge only in their target: Quine removes empiricism's account of how theories meet evidence, Strawson removes its account of what the world is built out of, so the failure is shown at the level of confirmation and again at the level of reference. **Qualification:** the convergence is in target and temper only - Grice and Strawson's "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956) defends against Quine precisely the distinction he attacked, so no joint doctrine may be attributed to them.

EXAM LINK

- Every one of the nine routed parts begins here, because the first decision in the examination hall is **which thinker the stem names**. A script that opens with a two-project sentence has already shown the examiner that the field is understood.
- The two-project frame is directly answer-relevant in **2021 Q3(c)** ("empiricism without the dogmas") and **2021 Q3(b)** (basic particulars), which appeared in the **same paper** - the only year in which the examiner tested both halves of the clause at once.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
"The Quine-Strawson critique of empiricism" as a single doctrine	Two projects, two levels, one documented disagreement. Name the 1956 paper.
"Quine rejects empiricism"	He calls his own position empiricism without the dogmas . He removes two assumptions and keeps sensory evidence and naturalism.
"Strawson defends empiricism against Quine"	He defends a distinction - the analytic/synthetic one - with Grice. That is not a defence of empiricism, and his own positive doctrines pressure the empiricist starting point.
Reassigning the printed limb	The critique of empiricism is Quine's printed burden. Strawson enters it as a bounded connective paragraph, never as co-owner.
Opening a Strawson answer with Quine, or the reverse	Decide the owner from the stem before writing a line. Five parts are Quine's; four are Strawson's.

REVISION NOTES

- Two printed limbs: critique of empiricism = **Quine**; basic particulars and persons = **Strawson**.
- Quine: internal reform of confirmation. Strawson: rejection of the sense-datum starting point.
- The clash: **Grice and Strawson, "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956)** - co-authored, British spelling.
- 9 parts, 2018-2025; none in 2022; two each in 2018 and 2021.
- The one legitimate unity sentence: empiricism failed about **confirmation** and about **reference**.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

ONE HEADING -> TWO PROJECTS -> Quine: confirmation | Strawson: reference
-> Quine keeps empiricism, minus two dogmas
-> Strawson keeps our scheme, minus the private given
-> 1956 proves they are not allies
-> TRAP: 'the Quine-Strawson doctrine' does not exist
-> LINE: they criticise empiricism at different levels, not together.

SESSION 2 - QUINE, DOGMA ONE: THE ANALYTIC/SYNTHETIC DISTINCTION AND THE CIRCLE OF FAILED EXPLICATIONS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Empiricists assumed a clean line between sentences true just because of what the words mean and sentences true because of how the world is. Quine asks what "true just because of what the words mean" actually means - and finds that every explanation offered borrows a notion that itself needs analyticity to be understood.

Technical definition: The first dogma is belief in a principled, non-circular boundary between **analytic** statements, true by virtue of meaning alone, and **synthetic** statements, true by virtue of extra-linguistic fact. Quine tests each available explication in turn - meaning, **synonymy** (sameness of meaning), **definition**, **interchangeability salva veritate*** (substitution preserving truth-value) and Carnap's **semantical rules** - and argues that each either presupposes analyticity or fails to deliver the general explanatory notion that logical empiricism required.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Quine's argument is not that no sentence looks analytic; it is that every available explanation of "analytic" borrows a term from the same family, so the distinction cannot do the **foundational** work logical empiricism assigned to it.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **two classes of analytic truth** (logical truths; truths reducible to logical truths by substituting synonyms)
- **synonymy · definition · interchangeability salva veritate* · necessity · semantical rules**
- **the circle · explication · difference of degree, not of kind**

Plain-language visual - the four doors, all of which lead back

```
YOU ASK: what makes a sentence ANALYTIC?
|
v
'True by MEANING.' -> what is meaning? -> SAMENESS OF MEANING
|
+--> 'A DEFINITION fixes it.'          -> but a definition only WRITES
|                                     DOWN a sameness that was
|                                     already there. Back to start.
|
+--> 'They swap without changing      -> works only in a language that
|   truth-value.'                     can say NECESSARILY - and that
|                                     word needs ANALYTIC. Back.
|
+--> 'We just STIPULATE a list        -> tells you what counts as
|   for an artificial language.'      analytic IN THAT LANGUAGE.
|                                     Does not tell you what
|                                     ANALYTIC MEANS. Back.
```

Four doors, one room. That is what "circle" means here.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the circle of synonymy, drawn as Quine walks it

```
ANALYTIC = TRUE BY VIRTUE OF MEANING
=====
CLASS 1  LOGICALLY TRUE
        'No unmarried man is married.'
        True under every reinterpretation of the non-logical words.
        Quine grants this class; it is not where the trouble lies.
CLASS 2  TRUE BY SUBSTITUTING SYNONYMS FOR SYNONYMS
        'No bachelor is married.' -> put 'unmarried man' for
        'bachelor' -> becomes a Class 1 truth.
        THIS class is the one that needs SYNONYMY.
            |
            v
        WHAT IS SYNONYMY?  THREE ROUTES, THREE FAILURES
-----
ROUTE 1  DEFINITION
        'The lexicographer defines bachelor as unmarried man.'
        FAILURE: except for frankly stipulative definitions, a
        definition REPORTS a synonymy that already obtained. It
        presupposes what it was to explain.
-----
ROUTE 2  INTERCHANGEABILITY SALVA VERITATE
        'Two terms are synonymous if swapping them never changes a
        truth-value.'
        FAILURE (a): in a purely EXTENSIONAL language this
        over-generates. 'Creature with a heart' and 'creature with
        a kidney' are coextensive, so they interchange - yet they
        are not synonymous.
        FAILURE (b): repair it by demanding interchange inside
        'NECESSARILY ...' and the language must already contain a
        necessity operator whose intelligibility, for Quine, rests
        on analyticity. The repair presupposes the target.
-----
ROUTE 3  SEMANTICAL RULES (Carnap)
        'Analyticity is defined for an artificial language L by
        explicit semantical rules.'
        FAILURE: the rules can classify sentences as analytic-IN-L,
        but the general notion 'semantical rule' is no clearer than
        the notion it was called in to explain. We learn what is on
        the list; we do not learn what being on the list AMOUNTS TO.
=====
CONCLUSION, STATED EXACTLY
        The available explications fail to provide the clear,
        non-question-begging boundary logical empiricism required.
        NOT: 'analytic sentences are false.'
        NOT: 'the word analytic is meaningless in every use.'
```

Caption: Quine walks four routes and each returns to its starting point. Reproduce this diagram and a 10-mark answer on 2019 Q1(e) writes itself.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. FACT: **Start with the two classes.** Analytic truths were said to fall into (i) **logical truths**, true under every reinterpretation of their non-logical vocabulary - "No unmarried man is married" - and (ii) truths **convertible into** logical truths by putting **synonyms for synonyms** - "No bachelor is married". The second class is the load-bearing one, and it requires a workable notion of **synonymy**.
2. FACT: **Route one, definition, fails by reporting.** Outside frankly stipulative cases, a definition records a synonymy that the language already contained. It therefore presupposes exactly the relation it was summoned to explain.
3. FACT: **Route two, interchangeability salva veritate, fails twice.** In an **extensional** language, coextensive but non-synonymous terms interchange freely - the standard illustration is "creature with a heart" and "creature with a kidney". Strengthen the test by requiring interchange within necessity-contexts, and the language must already contain an intelligible **necessity**; for Quine, that intelligibility rests on the analyticity under examination. The repair is circular.
4. FACT: **Route three, semantical rules, fails by relativisation.** Carnap can stipulate, for an artificial language **L**, which sentences count as analytic. But "analytic-in-L" is defined only by a list, and the general explanatory notion **"semantical rule"** remains no clearer than "analytic". We learn the membership of a set; we do not learn what membership consists in.

5. ANALYSIS: **State the conclusion precisely - this is where marks are won and lost.** Quine argues that the available explications do not secure the **sharp, foundational** boundary. He does **not** argue that "All bachelors are unmarried" is false, nor that no use of "analytic" is intelligible, nor that a single missing dictionary entry proves unintelligibility.
6. ANALYSIS: **What replaces the distinction.** Holistic revisability replaces categorical immunity with **degrees of practical entrenchment**: central statements are revised rarely, peripheral ones easily. ANALYSIS: **Centrality caution**: entrenchment explains why logic and mathematics are normally protected; it is **not** a new definition of "analytic", and presenting it as one converts a strength into an error.
7. FACT: **The reply, and Quine's rejoinder.** Grice and Strawson, "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956): the distinction is pre-theoretically clear, competent speakers sort cases in agreement, and a distinction in good working order is not discredited merely because no reductive analysis is available. **Quine's rejoinder**: ordinary intelligibility is not theoretical legitimacy - the *philosophical work* the distinction was doing (the positivist meaning-criterion, the linguistic theory of necessity) collapses without a principled ground.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: The first dogma fails because analyticity admits no non-circular explication. **Evidence:** in "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951) Quine tests definition, which merely records an antecedent synonymy; interchangeability *salva veritate*, which over-generates extensionally - "creature with a heart" and "creature with a kidney" - and requires a necessity-operator to repair; and Carnap's semantical rules, which classify sentences as analytic-in-L without explaining the general notion. **Analysis:** because each route presupposes a member of the same family, the empiricist cannot ground the class of truths held immune from experience, and apparent analyticity reduces to greater centrality in the web of belief - a difference of degree. **Qualification:** the argument targets the explication, not ordinary usage; Grice and Strawson (1956) rightly note that competent speakers sort cases, and Quine's reply is that agreed sorting is not the principled boundary his opponents' epistemology required.

EXAM LINK

- **2019 Q1(e), 10 marks** - "Explain Quine's arguments against synthetic-analytic distinction." This session **is** the answer: two classes, three routes, the exact conclusion, one objection with a rejoinder.
- **2024 Q4(c), 15 marks** - "Explain the nature of the two dogmas" requires this chain as its first half.
- **2018 Q2(c), 15 marks** - the Kantian a priori question uses the collapse of this distinction as its first move.
- **2021 Q3(c), 15 marks** - "empiricism without the dogmas" presupposes an accurate statement of what the first dogma was.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
"Quine says analytic truths do not exist"	He attacks the explication , not ordinary classification. Say what he concludes, in his terms.
Listing the routes without showing the return	The point is the circle . Each route must be shown coming back to synonymy or necessity.
Treating web-centrality as a new definition of "analytic"	Entrenchment explains differential revisability; it is not a semantic replacement theory.
Omitting the extensional counter-case	"Creature with a heart / creature with a kidney" is the standard illustration and costs nothing to include.
Attributing "In Defence of a Dogma" to Strawson alone	It is co-authored with H. P. Grice (1956), and the British spelling is <i>Defence</i> .

REVISION NOTES

- Two classes: logical truths; truths reducible by **synonym-substitution**.
- Three failed routes: **definition** (reports), **interchangeability salva veritate*** (over-generates; needs necessity), **semantical rules** (analytic-in-L only).

- Conclusion: **no non-question-begging foundational boundary**; not "analytic sentences are false".
- Replacement: **degrees of entrenchment**, not a new definition.
- Objection: **Grice and Strawson 1956**; rejoinder: **usability ≠ theoretical legitimacy**.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

ANALYTIC -> MEANING -> SYNONYMY

- > DEFINITION (records it) CIRCLE
- > SALVA VERITATE (heart/kidney; needs NECESSITY) ... CIRCLE
- > SEMANTICAL RULES (analytic-in-L only) NO GENERAL NOTION
- > RESULT: no principled foundational boundary
- > REPLACEMENT: degrees of entrenchment (NOT a new definition)
- > OBJECTION: Grice and Strawson 1956 | REPLY: usability is not legitimacy.

SESSION 3 - QUINE, DOGMA TWO: REDUCTIONISM, AND WHY THE SECOND DOGMA IS THE ROOT OF THE FIRST

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The second assumption is that each meaningful sentence has its own private stock of experiences that would confirm or refute it, so that sentences can be checked one at a time. Quine denies it: sentences do not meet experience singly.

Technical definition: Reductionism is the doctrine that every meaningful statement is translatable into, or individually confirmable and disconfirmable by, a determinate range of sense-experience. In its radical form it demands term-by-term translation into a sense-datum language; in its attenuated form it assigns each statement its own set of confirming and disconfirming experiences. Quine rejects both: **no statement has its meaning, or its confirmation conditions, in isolation from the rest of the system.**

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The second dogma is the deeper one: once it is seen that no sentence carries its own private stock of confirming experiences, the first dogma loses its motive, because the class of sentences confirmed "no matter what experience" was defined by contrast with sentences confirmed individually.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **reductionism · verificationism · statement-by-statement confirmation**
- **the unit of empirical significance · corporate body**
- **"the two dogmas are at root identical"**

Plain-language visual - the bucket picture against the web picture

THE PICTURE THE EMPIRICIST HAD (the BUCKET)

```

sentence 1 -> its own bucket of experiences
sentence 2 -> its own bucket of experiences
sentence 3 -> its own bucket of experiences
Each sentence is checked alone. Verdict: true or false, one at a time.
```

THE PICTURE QUINE PUTS IN ITS PLACE (the WEB)

```

[ sentence 1 sentence 2 sentence 3 ... ] all tied together
  | experience arrives here |
The verdict falls on the SYSTEM. Which sentence is surrendered
is a further question that experience alone does not settle.
```

If the bucket picture goes, the idea of a sentence immune to every bucket goes with it.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the two forms of the dogma, and the single objection

DOGMA 2: REDUCTIONISM

=====

RADICAL FORM

Every meaningful statement is TRANSLATABLE into a language of immediate experience, term by term.
Historical exemplar: Carnap's Aufbau (1928) - the construction of the world from private experience. [Topic 07 owns the programme; it appears here only as the target.]

ATTENUATED FORM

Give up translation. Retain the claim that each statement, taken alone, has its OWN range of confirming and of disconfirming experiences.

WHY IT IS CALLED 'REDUCTIONISM'

It REDUCES the meaning of each sentence to a set of observation sentences. The name is not decorative; it states the operation.

THE OBJECTION - ONE SENTENCE

'Our statements about the external world face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body.'

THE UNIT OF EMPIRICAL SIGNIFICANCE

NOT the term (that failed already)
NOT the sentence (this is the dogma being removed)
BUT THE WHOLE OF SCIENCE

THE LINK BACK TO DOGMA 1

If no sentence has its own confirming experiences, then the class 'confirmed come what may' has no contrasting class to be defined against. Quine's own verdict: the two dogmas are AT ROOT IDENTICAL.

Caption: name both forms, name the operation the label describes, then produce the corporate-body sentence and the identification of the two dogmas.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. FACT: **Two forms.** The **radical** form demands term-by-term translation into a sense-datum language; the **attenuated** form abandons translation but keeps individual confirmation. Quine's objection defeats both, because both assume a sentence-sized parcel of evidence.
2. FACT: **Why the label fits.** The doctrine *reduces* the meaning of each sentence to a set of observation sentences. Explaining the label is a cheap mark that most scripts leave on the table.
3. FACT: **The canonical objection.** *"Our statements about the external world face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body."* Quote it exactly; it is the pivot of the paper.
4. FACT: **The unit of empirical significance is the whole of science.** Not the term - that programme had already collapsed. Not the sentence - that is the dogma being removed.
5. ANALYSIS: **The two dogmas are at root identical.** This is Quine's own judgement, and it earns marks because it shows the paper's architecture rather than its list of contents. The first dogma survives only if some statements are confirmed **independently of experience**; that contrast needs the second dogma's picture of statement-sized confirmation. Remove the second and the first has nothing to be a contrast to.
6. ANALYSIS: **What is not claimed.** Quine does not deny that experience bears on belief. He denies that it bears on beliefs **one at a time**. Sensory evidence is retained - which is exactly why the resulting position is still called **empiricism**.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: The second dogma, reductionism, fails because confirmation has no sentence-sized unit. **Evidence:** Quine distinguishes the radical demand for term-by-term translation into experience - the programme of Carnap's *Aufbau* (1928) - from the attenuated claim that each statement has its own confirming experiences, and rejects both with the thesis that statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body".

Analysis: if the unit of empirical significance is the whole of science, then no statement possesses a private evidential stock, and the contrast class needed to define statements "confirmed come what may" disappears - which is why Quine says the two dogmas are at root identical. **Qualification:** the thesis removes atomistic confirmation, not experience itself; sensory evidence and scientific naturalism are retained, which is why the resulting position is described as empiricism without the dogmas rather than as anti-empiricism.

EXAM LINK

- **2024 Q4(c), 15 marks** - "Explain the nature of the two dogmas": this session supplies the second half, and the "at root identical" line supplies the conclusion.
- **2021 Q3(c), 15 marks** - the dogma that has to be removed before "empiricism without the dogmas" can be stated.
- **2025 Q4(b), 15 marks** - the quotation only makes sense once statement-by-statement confirmation is gone.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
Defining reductionism as "reducing everything to matter"	It is the reduction of each sentence's meaning to a range of sense-experience.
Presenting the two dogmas as unrelated items on a list	Quine identifies them at root. Say so; it converts a list into an argument.
"Quine denies that experience tests belief"	He denies individual testing. The tribunal still sits; it hears the system.
Forgetting the radical/attenuated distinction	Naming both forms shows that the objection is aimed at the assumption they share.

REVISION NOTES

- Radical form = translation into a sense-datum language (*Aufbau*, 1928, as target). Attenuated form = individual confirmation.
- Label explained: it **reduces** sentence-meaning to observation sentences.
- Canonical sentence: "**not individually but only as a corporate body**".
- Unit of empirical significance = **the whole of science**.
- **The two dogmas are at root identical** - the architectural line.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

DOGMA 2 -> each sentence has its own confirming experiences
-> radical form: translate into sense-data | attenuated: individual confirmation
-> OBJECTION: statements face the tribunal only as a CORPORATE BODY
-> UNIT of empirical significance = THE WHOLE OF SCIENCE
-> therefore no contrast class for 'confirmed come what may'
-> QUINE'S OWN VERDICT: the two dogmas are AT ROOT IDENTICAL
-> LIMIT: experience is retained; only atomism is removed.

SESSION 4 - THE POSITIVE DOCTRINE: CONFIRMATION HOLISM AND THE WEB OF BELIEF

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Our beliefs form one connected fabric. Experience pushes on its edge. When something goes wrong we must change the fabric somewhere, but nothing tells us *where* - that is a decision, made on grounds of economy and habit rather than by the evidence alone.

Technical definition: **Confirmation holism** is the thesis that the total system of our beliefs faces sensory experience as a whole, so that no individual statement possesses its own confirmation conditions. Quine models the system as a **web** or **field of force** whose **boundary conditions** are experience: peripheral observation sentences lie near the edge, and increasingly theoretical statements - physics, mathematics, logic - lie in the interior. Conflict at the periphery requires revision **somewhere**, and the choice of location is governed by the pragmatic virtues of **simplicity**, **conservatism** and **fecundity**.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Holism is not scepticism about evidence but a correction about its address: experience delivers its verdict to the **system**, and the system, not the tribunal, decides which sentence pays.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

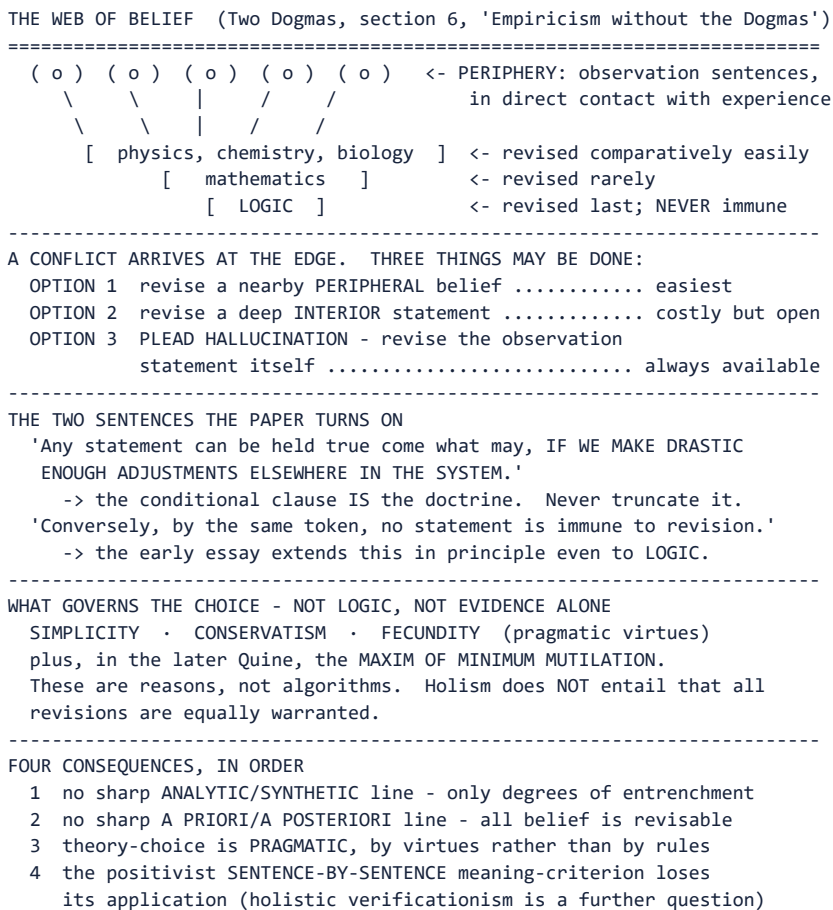
- web of belief · field of force · boundary conditions · periphery and interior
- "any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system"
- "no statement is immune to revision" · simplicity, conservatism, fecundity · minimum mutilation

Plain-language visual - where the push arrives and where the change happens

```
EXPERIENCE PUSHES HERE  -> | o o o o o | <- OBSERVATION
                             | \ | | | / |   SENTENCES
                             | [ physics ] |
                             | [  maths  ] |
                             | [  LOGIC  ] | <- deepest interior
...but the CHANGE may be made ANYWHERE inside the box.
Experience says 'something here is wrong'.
It never says 'THAT sentence is wrong'.
```

The gap between those two sentences is the whole doctrine.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the web, the three options and the two canonical sentences



Caption: the web, the three revision options, the two sentences and the four consequences. This single diagram answers 2025 Q4(b) and supplies the second half of 2021 Q3(c).

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. **FACT: The metaphor is precise.** Quine speaks of a **field of force** whose **boundary conditions** are experience. Only the edge touches experience; the interior is connected to it by inferential threads. A collision at the edge produces re-adjustment *inside*, and the interior is not directly hit.
2. **FACT: The three options.** Revise a peripheral belief; revise a deep interior law; or **plead hallucination** and revise the observation statement itself. The third option is what makes the first quotation literally true.
3. **FACT: Quotation one, with its conditional.** *"Any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system."* **WRONG:** Truncating it at "come what may" produces relativism, which is not the doctrine. The clause names the **cost**, and the cost is what disciplines the choice.
4. **FACT: Quotation two.** *"Conversely, by the same token, no statement is immune to revision."* The early essay extends revisability **in principle** to logic. **ANALYSIS:** It does not follow that every revision is equally rational, or that logic is casually abandoned.
5. **ANALYSIS: The four consequences.** No sharp analytic/synthetic line; no sharp a priori/a posteriori line; **pragmatism about theory-choice**; and the collapse of the sentence-by-sentence meaning-criterion. Take care with the fourth: what falls is *reductionist* verification, and whether a **holistic** verificationism survives is a further question, not something the paper settles.
6. **ANALYSIS: Centrality is not a definition.** Logic and mathematics are highly entrenched and normally protected, and that explains the *appearance* of analyticity. It does not restore analyticity under a new name.
7. **ANALYSIS: The constraint that blocks "anything goes".** Predictive success, conservatism, simplicity, fecundity and - in *Philosophy of Logic* (1970) - the **maxim of minimum mutilation**. Holism describes where revision *may* occur; it does not license arbitrary revision.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: Holism is the positive doctrine that replaces both dogmas. **Evidence:** in section 6 of "Two Dogmas" Quine models total science as a field of force whose boundary conditions are experience, and states that "any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system" and that "no statement is immune to revision". **Analysis:** because a recalcitrant experience convicts only the system, the location of revision is chosen on pragmatic grounds - simplicity, conservatism, fecundity - so the difference between the apparently analytic and the empirical becomes one of entrenchment rather than of kind. **Qualification:** the conditional clause carries the doctrine's discipline; with the later maxim of minimum mutilation it blocks the reading that any revision is as good as any other, so holism licenses re-allocation of blame, not indifference to evidence.

EXAM LINK

- **2025 Q4(b), 15 marks** - the quotation *is* this session. Preserve the conditional, run the web, name the constraints, refuse the relativist reading.
- **2021 Q3(c), 15 marks** - holism is the positive half of "empiricism without the dogmas".
- **2018 Q2(c), 15 marks** - holism is the second of the three moves against a certified a priori.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
Quoting "any statement can be held true come what may" and stopping	The conditional clause is the doctrine. Quote it whole.
"Web of belief = arbitrary revision"	Experience, predictive success, conservatism, simplicity and minimum mutilation constrain revision.
Treating the periphery as "sense-data"	The periphery is observation sentences , not private data. Quine is rejecting the sense-datum programme, not restating it.
Saying holism refutes verificationism outright	It removes sentence-by-sentence reductionist verification. Holistic verificationism is a further question.
Using "web of belief" without the field-of-force detail	The boundary-condition structure is what explains why the interior is revisable at all.

REVISION NOTES

- **Field of force**, boundary conditions = experience; periphery = observation sentences; interior = physics, mathematics, logic.
- Three options: peripheral revision · interior revision · **plead hallucination**.
- Two sentences, both **with** their qualifiers.
- Virtues: **simplicity, conservatism, fecundity**; later, **minimum mutilation**.
- Four consequences; the fourth stated carefully.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

EXPERIENCE hits the PERIPHERY -> conflict -> revise SOMEWHERE
-> option 1 peripheral | option 2 interior | option 3 plead hallucination
-> 'held true come what may, IF drastic adjustments elsewhere'
-> 'no statement is immune to revision'
-> CHOICE governed by simplicity, conservatism, fecundity, minimum mutilation
-> CONSEQUENCES: no a/s line; no a priori line; pragmatic theory-choice;
sentence-by-sentence verification loses application
-> TRAP: truncating the quotation turns Quine into a relativist.

SESSION 5 - THE DUHEM-QUINE THESIS: WHY NO SINGLE HYPOTHESIS EVER FACES EXPERIENCE ALONE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: A hypothesis never makes a prediction by itself. It needs background theory, instrument theory and assumptions about the set-up. So when the prediction fails, all we learn is that *something in the package* is wrong - and logic never tells us which part.

Technical definition: The **Duhem-Quine thesis** holds that a scientific hypothesis is confronted by experience only in conjunction with auxiliary hypotheses, background theory, instrument theory and initial conditions; therefore a failed prediction refutes only the **conjunction**, and no rule of logic identifies the guilty conjunct. It is the engine that drives confirmation holism, and the shared label covers **two non-identical claims** - Duhem's, restricted to physics, and Quine's, extended to the whole of knowledge.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Modus tollens is the whole argument: from "if H and A then O" and "not-O" it follows only that H or some member of A is false - and the choice between them is made by scientists, not by logic.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- auxiliary hypotheses · conjunction under test · modus tollens · no experimentum crucis
- Duhem 1906 - physics only; logic and mathematics exempt
- Quine 1951 - the whole of science; nothing exempt
- Neptune (1846) and "Vulcan" · Popper's methodological decision · Lakatos's hard core and protective belt

Plain-language visual - the courtroom with no named defendant

THE PREDICTION FAILED.
WHO IS GUILTY?

H the hypothesis you were testing
A1 the background theory
A2 the theory of how your instrument works
A3 the assumed initial conditions

THE VERDICT LOGIC DELIVERS: 'at least one of you did it.'
THE VERDICT LOGIC NEVER DELIVERS: a NAME.

Everything else in this session is what scientists do with an unnamed verdict.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the argument, the two authors and the decisive historical pair

THE ARGUMENT, NUMBERED

=====

- 1 The testable claim is (H & A) -> 0
H = hypothesis under test
A = auxiliaries: background theory, instrument theory,
initial conditions
- 2 Observation reports NOT-0
- 3 By MODUS TOLLENS all that follows is NOT (H & A)
i.e. H is false OR some element of A is false
- 4 Logic does not say WHICH conjunct to reject. Evidence, background
knowledge and methodological virtues can still make some revisions
far more reasonable than others.
- 5 Therefore refutation is never conclusive against a SINGLE statement -
and, symmetrically, 'any statement can be held true come what may,
if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system'
- 6 Therefore a reductionist criterion assigning each statement its own
confirming experiences HAS NO APPLICATION. This attacks DOGMA 2
directly; it PRESSURES, but does not by itself refute, every
possible holistic verificationism.

=====

TWO AUTHORS, TWO NON-IDENTICAL CLAIMS - DO NOT MERGE THEM

	DUHEM (1906)	QUINE (1951)
SCOPE	PHYSICS ONLY. Physiology and some other sciences can test more nearly in isolation	ALL OF KNOWLEDGE. 'The unit of empirical significance is THE WHOLE OF SCIENCE.'
LOGIC/MATHS	EXEMPT - not put at risk	INCLUDED - 'no statement is immune to revision'
COROLLARY	no automatic EXPERIMENTUM CRUCIS against an isolated hypothesis	confirmation holism and underdetermination pressure
MOTIVE	philosophy of physics; the actual practice of physicists	the demolition of the SECOND DOGMA, reductionism

THE PAIR THAT PROVES THE POINT - DEPLOY BOTH, NOT JUST NEPTUNE

URANUS orbit conflicts with Newtonian prediction
-> astronomers DO NOT abandon Newton's laws
-> they revise the AUXILIARY 'we know all the planets'
-> NEPTUNE is found. Le Verrier and Adams, 1846. CORRECT.

MERCURY perihelion conflicts with Newtonian prediction
-> the SAME strategy posits the planet 'VULCAN'
-> VULCAN DOES NOT EXIST. The correct revision was the DEEP
one: general relativity, 1915.

SAME LOGICAL SITUATION. OPPOSITE CORRECT RESPONSES. NO RULE SAYS IN
ADVANCE WHICH TO CHOOSE. That is the thesis, historically demonstrated.

THE REPLY THAT DOES NOT DENY THE LOGIC

POPPER accepts the logical point ENTIRELY and denies its sceptical
use. Falsification is a METHODOLOGICAL DECISION: scientists
agree by convention to treat certain basic statements as
unproblematic for a test, and to forbid AD HOC rescues that
reduce testability. Rationality is preserved by RULES OF
METHOD, not by logic alone.

LAKATOS turns this into research programmes with a protected HARD
CORE and a revisable PROTECTIVE BELT - Duhem-Quine converted
into a CRITERION OF PROGRESS.

Caption: six numbered steps, a four-row table that keeps the two authors apart, and the Neptune/Vulcan pair that turns an abstract point into evidence. This is the single most examinable precision on the sub-topic.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. FACT: **Run the argument as six steps**, not as an assertion. The logical form is what carries the conclusion, and the fourth step - that evidence and method still discriminate - is what keeps Quine out of irrationalism.
2. ANALYSIS: **Keep Duhem and Quine apart**. Duhem restricted the thesis to **theoretical physics** and held that physiology and some other sciences can test hypotheses more nearly in isolation; he **exempted logic and mathematics**. Quine extended it to **all knowledge** and exempted nothing. The label "Duhem-Quine thesis" is later shorthand for two non-identical claims - say so, and a routine answer becomes a researched one.
3. FACT: **Duhem's chief corollary** is the denial of an automatic **experimentum crucis*** against an isolated hypothesis; Quine's is confirmation holism together with underdetermination pressure.

4. **FACT: Deploy the pair, not the single case.** Uranus: revise the auxiliary, find **Neptune** (Le Verrier and Adams, **1846**) - the shallow revision was right. Mercury: revise the same auxiliary, posit "**Vulcan**" - which does not exist, and the correct revision proved to be the deep one, **general relativity (1915)**. Identical logical situation, opposite correct responses, and no advance rule.
5. **ANALYSIS: State the presuppositions**, because every objection enters through them: hypotheses generate predictions only with auxiliaries; no fixed decomposition uniquely assigns a recalcitrant experience to one sentence; and theory-choice employs pragmatic virtues alongside evidence. Holism does **not** entail that all revisions are equally warranted.
6. **CAUTION: Popper's reply is not a denial.** He accepts the logical point and answers it methodologically - falsification as a **decision** governed by conventions about basic statements and by a prohibition on testability-reducing *ad hoc* rescues. **Lakatos** systematises this into the **hard core** and the **protective belt**. Presenting Popper as denying Duhem-Quine is a factual error.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: No hypothesis meets experience alone, so refutation never convicts a single statement. **Evidence:** the testable claim is $(H \& A) \rightarrow O$; observation yields not-O; *modus tollens* delivers only not- $(H \& A)$ - and the history bears this out, since the anomaly in Uranus's orbit was correctly resolved by revising the auxiliary assumption and finding Neptune in 1846, while the identical strategy applied to Mercury produced the non-existent "Vulcan" and the correct revision turned out to be general relativity in 1915. **Analysis:** because logic never names the guilty conjunct, the reductionist criterion assigning each statement its own confirming experiences has no application, and the choice of revision falls to evidence weighed by simplicity, conservatism and minimum mutilation. **Qualification:** Duhem confined the thesis to physics and exempted logic and mathematics, so the extension to all knowledge is Quine's own and controversial step; and Popper accepts the logical point while answering it by methodological convention rather than denying it.

EXAM LINK

- **2025 Q4(b), 15 marks** - the directive decoder for this question requires the *modus tollens* explanation, then the Neptune/Vulcan pair. It is the difference between paraphrasing a quotation and explaining it.
- **2024 Q4(c)** and **2021 Q3(c)** - the mechanism behind the rejection of the second dogma.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
"Duhem and Quine hold the same thesis"	Scope and exemptions differ. Give the four-row contrast.
Citing only Neptune	The Vulcan half is what shows there is no advance rule. Both, or neither.
"Popper refutes Duhem-Quine"	He accepts the logic and answers methodologically; Lakatos formalises the answer.
Dating Duhem's book to the English translation	French 1906 ; Wiener's English translation 1954 .
Turning holism into "no theory can ever be refuted"	Refutation of a conjunction is decisive; only the distribution of blame is open.

REVISION NOTES

- $(H \& A) \rightarrow O$; not-O; therefore not- $(H \& A)$. Logic stops there.
- **Duhem 1906:** physics only; logic and mathematics exempt; no *experimentum crucis*.
- **Quine 1951:** all knowledge; nothing exempt; the whole of science is the unit.
- **Neptune 1846** (shallow revision right) against "**Vulcan**" and **general relativity 1915** (deep revision right).
- **Popper:** methodological decision, no *ad hoc* rescues. **Lakatos:** hard core and protective belt.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

(H & A) -> 0 ; observe NOT-0 ; modus tollens -> NOT (H & A)
-> logic never names the conjunct -> revision is CHOSEN
-> DUHEM 1906 physics only, logic/math's exempt
-> QUINE 1951 all knowledge, nothing exempt
-> NEPTUNE 1846 shallow revision right | VULCAN -> GR 1915 deep revision right
-> POPPER: methodological decision | LAKATOS: hard core + protective belt
-> RESULT: dogma 2 has no application; dogma 1 loses its contrast.

SESSION 6 - THE REVISABILITY OF LOGIC: QUANTUM LOGIC, AND WHY THE LATER QUINE IS A POOR WITNESS FOR THE EARLIER

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: If nothing is immune to revision, could we ever really give up a law of logic? There is one serious candidate - the proposal to change logic because of quantum mechanics - and Quine himself became much more cautious about it later in life.

Technical definition: The claim at issue is that **no statement is immune to revision, not even a law of logic**. The strongest historical candidate is the **non-distributive lattice** of propositions proposed by **Birkhoff and von Neumann** in "The Logic of Quantum Mechanics" (*Annals of Mathematics*, 1936), and the claim that this shows **logic is empirical** - that the **distributive law** should be revised on empirical grounds - is **Putnam's**, in "Is Logic Empirical?" (1968; reprinted as "The Logic of Quantum Mechanics", 1976). Quine's own *Philosophy of Logic* (1970) resists such revision through the slogan "**change of logic, change of subject**" and the **maxim of minimum mutilation**.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The strongest textual support for revising a law of logic comes from Putnam, not from Quine; and the later Quine - with minimum mutilation and "change of logic, change of subject" - is a poor witness for the earlier Quine's most radical claim.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Birkhoff and von Neumann, 1936** - the **formal proposal** (a non-distributive lattice)
- **Putnam, 1968** - the **claim** that logic is empirically revisable; **the distributive law**
- "**change of logic, change of subject**" · **maxim of minimum mutilation** · **Philosophy of Logic, 1970**

Plain-language visual - two different acts, thirty-two years apart

1936 BIRKHOFF AND VON NEUMANN
'Here is a formal structure - a non-distributive lattice -
that models quantum propositions.'
THIS IS A MATHEMATICAL PROPOSAL.

1968 PUTNAM
'Therefore LOGIC IS EMPIRICAL: we should give up the
DISTRIBUTIVE LAW because of physics.'
THIS IS A PHILOSOPHICAL CLAIM ABOUT THE FIRST.

Writing 'Putnam/Birkhoff' as one proposal merges an act of
mathematics with a philosophical thesis made a generation later.

Two acts, two dates, two authors. Keep them apart and the point becomes evidence rather than name-dropping.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the case for revising logic, and the case against, on one screen

THE EARLY QUINE'S CLAIM (1951)

'No statement is immune to revision.' Applied even to the law of excluded middle, whose revision was proposed 'as a means of simplifying quantum mechanics'.

THE STRONGEST CANDIDATE

1936 BIRKHOFF AND VON NEUMANN, 'The Logic of Quantum Mechanics', *Annals of Mathematics*. A NON-DISTRIBUTIVE LATTICE of propositions. A FORMAL PROPOSAL.

1968 PUTNAM, 'Is Logic Empirical?' THE CLAIM that the DISTRIBUTIVE LAW should be revised on EMPIRICAL grounds. Reprinted 1976. PUTNAM LATER ABANDONED THE POSITION.

THE STRONGEST RESISTANCE

1970 QUINE, *PHILOSOPHY OF LOGIC* 'CHANGE OF LOGIC, CHANGE OF SUBJECT' - anyone who 'denies' a law of logic has merely changed the meaning of the connectives, so no genuine disagreement has occurred.

THE MAXIM OF MINIMUM MUTILATION revise as little as possible; deep revisions carry costs that the system will normally refuse to pay.

CONSEQUENCE: the LATE Quine protects logic in practice while conceding revisability in principle.

THE HONEST VERDICT TO WRITE

Holism is right about CONFIRMATION and overstated about REVISABILITY. The defensible position is Duhem's thesis with Quine's motivation: testing is holistic, the choice of revision is pragmatic, and logic is revisable in a sense so attenuated that little follows from it.

Caption: the two-column layout separates the case for revising logic from Quine's own later resistance to it, and the closing verdict is the line to write at 20 marks.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. **FACT: Get the history right, because the paper rewards it.** The **formal proposal** is Birkhoff and von Neumann's (1936). The **philosophical claim** that logic is therefore empirically revisable is Putnam's (1968). **WRONG:** Never write "Putnam/Birkhoff" as a joint proposal, and never merge the dates.
2. **CAUTION: Two further nuances, one clause each. Putnam later abandoned** the quantum-logic realism of that paper. And **Quine himself grew conservative:** in *Philosophy of Logic* (1970) he argues that anyone who "denies" a law of logic has merely changed the subject, and he invokes the **maxim of minimum mutilation**.
3. **ANALYSIS: What follows for the doctrine.** Revisability survives **in principle**; what is withdrawn is the suggestion that revising logic is a live and ordinary option. Logic is protected in practice by entrenchment and by the cost of mutilation - not by an analytic immunity certificate.
4. **ANALYSIS: The objection this answers.** "If everything is revisable, science has no fixed point and rational belief has no constraint." The reply is that no statement is revisable **by nature**; revision is a matter of **choice**, and choice is disciplined by pragmatic conservatism.
5. **ANALYSIS: Why this belongs in a 15- or 20-mark answer.** It converts an abstract slogan into a documented episode with a proposal, a claim, a retraction and a counter-move - exactly the "value addition" that separates a prepared script from a paraphrase.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: The revisability of logic is defensible only in an attenuated sense. **Evidence:** Birkhoff and von Neumann proposed a non-distributive lattice for quantum propositions in 1936, and Putnam argued in "Is Logic Empirical?" (1968) that the distributive law should therefore be revised on empirical grounds; Quine's own *Philosophy of Logic* (1970) resists this with "change of logic, change of subject" and the maxim of minimum mutilation. **Analysis:** the episode shows that revision of logic is conceivable and has been seriously proposed, but also that the cost of paying for it is normally prohibitive, so entrenchment rather than analyticity explains logic's stability. **Qualification:** Putnam later abandoned the position and the later Quine is a poor witness for the earlier Quine's boldest claim, so the honest verdict is that holism is right about confirmation and overstated about revisability.

EXAM LINK

- **2025 Q4(b)** and **2021 Q3(c)** - the strongest available assessment paragraph. It shows the doctrine tested against a real case rather than restated.
- **2018 Q2(c)** - the qualification that prevents the answer from claiming more than Quine can deliver against the a priori.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
"Putnam/Birkhoff proposed quantum logic in 1936/1968"	Two acts, two authors, two dates. Separate them.
"Quine revised logic"	Quine allowed revisability in principle ; in 1970 he resisted it in practice.
Presenting minimum mutilation as an early-Quine doctrine	It belongs to <i>Philosophy of Logic</i> (1970), and citing the later work is the point.
Claiming logic has actually been abandoned	The proposal was made and contested; Putnam himself later withdrew.

REVISION NOTES

- **1936 Birkhoff and von Neumann** - non-distributive lattice, a **formal** proposal.
- **1968 Putnam** - "Is Logic Empirical?", the **claim**; reprinted 1976; **later abandoned**.
- **1970 Quine**, *Philosophy of Logic* - "**change of logic, change of subject**"; **minimum mutilation**.
- Verdict line: holism right about **confirmation**, overstated about **revisability**.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

'NO STATEMENT IS IMMUNE' -> is logic revisable?
-> 1936 Birkhoff and von Neumann: NON-DISTRIBUTIVE LATTICE (formal proposal)
-> 1968 Putnam: LOGIC IS EMPIRICAL, revise the DISTRIBUTIVE LAW (the claim)
-> Putnam later abandons it
-> 1970 Quine: 'change of logic, change of subject' + MINIMUM MUTILATION
-> RESULT: revisable in principle, protected in practice by entrenchment
-> VERDICT: right about confirmation, overstated about revisability.

SESSION 7 - EMPIRICISM WITHOUT THE DOGMAS, THE GRICE-STRAWSON REPLY, AND THE 2018 "ARTICLE OF FAITH" FRAMING

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: After both assumptions are removed, what is left is still empiricism - evidence still comes through the senses and philosophy is still continuous with science - but it is empiricism with a different shape: holistic, revisable and without a privileged class of truths.

Technical definition: **Empiricism without the dogmas** is the residual position of section 6 of "Two Dogmas": sensory evidence and scientific naturalism are retained; **sentence-by-sentence reduction** and a **foundational analytic/synthetic boundary** are abandoned; the boundary between speculative metaphysics and natural science becomes one of **degree**, and ontological questions are decided, like scientific ones, by the pragmatic virtues of the total system.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Quine is not an opponent of empiricism but its most damaging internal critic: he removes the two assumptions that made empiricism foundationalist and keeps everything that made it empiricist.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **empiricism without the dogmas** · **internal critic** · **no first philosophy**
- **degree, not kind** (metaphysics and natural science) · **pragmatic ontology**

- Grice and Strawson, "In Defence of a Dogma", 1956 · "a metaphysical article of faith" - the paper's framing

Plain-language visual - what is kept and what is thrown away

THROWN AWAY	KEPT
the analytic / synthetic boundary as a FOUNDATION	SENSORY EVIDENCE as the check on the system
confirmation of sentences ONE AT A TIME	NATURALISM: philosophy is continuous with science
a privileged class of truths IMMUNE to experience	the demand that ontology be answerable to the best theory
RESULT: still EMPIRICISM. Not positivism, not rationalism, not scepticism. A reformed empiricism.	

The word "without" in the title is doing all the work: subtraction, not replacement.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the position, the objection and the rejoinder

EMPIRICISM WITHOUT THE DOGMAS (Two Dogmas, section 6)

=====

WHAT SURVIVES

- experience remains the tribunal, addressed to the SYSTEM
- science is the best available account of what there is
- there is NO FIRST PHILOSOPHY standing outside science to certify its foundations
- the line between speculative metaphysics and natural science becomes a matter of DEGREE
- ontology is settled by the SAME pragmatic virtues that settle theory-choice: simplicity, conservatism, fecundity

THE DIRECT OBJECTION - FROM INSIDE THIS CLAUSE

GRICE AND STRAWSON, 'In Defence of a Dogma',
The Philosophical Review, 1956. CO-AUTHORED.

- 1 The distinction is ORDINARILY INTELLIGIBLE: competent speakers agree on cases without theory.
- 2 A distinction in good working order is not discredited merely because no REDUCTIVE ANALYSIS of it is available.
- 3 Quine sets the bar too high - he demands a non-circular DEFINITION where what we have is a usable DISTINCTION.

QUINE'S REJOINDER

Ordinary intelligibility is not THEORETICAL LEGITIMACY.
Agreement in classification does not supply the principled ground that the positivist meaning-criterion and the linguistic theory of necessity were resting on.
Compare: speakers once agreed in applying 'witch' / 'non-witch'; agreement in use settles nothing about whether the distinction can carry a philosophical theory.

THE STANDING DISPUTE - NAME IT AND TAKE A SIDE

The quarrel is about STANDARDS OF EXPLICATION. Quine strongly pressures the distinction's FOUNDATIONAL use while leaving room for more modest semantic or ordinary classifications. That is the defensible verdict.

Caption: the residual position, the only objection the syllabus itself supplies, and the rejoinder - with the standing dispute named rather than concealed.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. FACT: **What survives.** Sensory evidence, scientific naturalism, and the refusal of a first-philosophy standpoint.
ANALYSIS: Calling this an **internal reform** is safer than calling Quine either a logical positivist or "the uniquely purified empiricist".
2. FACT: **What changes.** Metaphysics and natural science differ in **degree**, not in kind; ontological questions are settled by the same pragmatic virtues as theory-choice; and no class of statements is insulated from revision.
3. FACT: **The objection.** Grice and Strawson (1956) argue that a distinction with agreed application is in good working order even without a reductive analysis, and that Quine's demand for a non-circular definition sets the bar impossibly high.

4. ANALYSIS: **The rejoinder.** Ordinary intelligibility is not theoretical legitimacy. Whether that reply succeeds is a live dispute - it turns on **standards of explication** - and an answer that names the dispute and takes a graded side outperforms one that reports a knock-out.
5. ANALYSIS: **The 2018 framing, handled correctly.** "Metaphysical article of faith" is **the 2018 question's framing**, not a verified verbatim Quine quotation. WRONG: Do not place it in quotation marks as Quine's own formula. FACT: What Quine does supply is three connected moves: the analytic/synthetic explication fails; holism makes revisability a matter of degree, so nothing is a priori **by nature**; and naturalism denies any external standpoint from which a priori knowledge could be certified. On that reading, a Kantian a priori is asserted rather than shown - which is what the paper's phrase captures.
6. CAUTION: **The residue on the 2018 question.** Kant can reply that transcendental conditions of experience are not empirical hypotheses inside the web, so holistic revisability does not touch them - a reply for which Strawson's own descriptive reading of Kant gives some support. Quine's rejoinder is that this reasserts precisely the privileged non-empirical status in question. Report the exchange; do not pretend it is closed.
7. ANALYSIS: **Where the boundary lies.** Kant's own positive doctrine belongs to Topic 04; here only what Quine's three moves require may be stated.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: Removing the dogmas reforms empiricism rather than refuting it. **Evidence:** section 6 of "Two Dogmas" retains sensory evidence and scientific naturalism while abandoning sentence-by-sentence reduction and the foundational analytic/synthetic boundary, and Grice and Strawson's "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956) responds that a distinction with agreed application does not require a reductive analysis. **Analysis:** the exchange shows that the disagreement is about standards of explication rather than about the data, since Quine concedes that speakers classify cases while denying that classification supplies the principled ground the positivist meaning-criterion needed. **Qualification:** on this reading Quine succeeds against the distinction's foundational employment and leaves more modest semantic or ordinary uses standing, which is why he describes his own position as empiricism without the dogmas rather than as a rejection of empiricism.

EXAM LINK

- **2021 Q3(c), 15 marks** - "Critically examine Quine's postulate of empiricism without the dogmas with reference to his 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'." This session is the answer's second half and its verdict.
- **2018 Q2(c), 15 marks** - the "article of faith" question: three moves, the Kantian reply, and the graded verdict.
- **2024 Q4(c)** - the closing paragraph, showing what the removal of the dogmas leaves standing.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
"Quine rejects empiricism"	Empiricism without the dogmas. He is its internal critic, not its opponent.
"Quine is a logical positivist"	He is the positivists' most damaging internal critic, and he removes both pillars they stood on.
Quoting "a metaphysical article of faith" as Quine's words	It is the 2018 paper's framing . Report the sense; do not fabricate a quotation.
Turning the 2018 question into a Kant exposition	The question is about Quine's argument. Kant enters as the target and as one reply.
Treating Grice-Strawson as a decisive refutation	It is a live objection about standards of explication. Take a graded side.

REVISION NOTES

- Kept: **sensory evidence, naturalism, no first philosophy**. Dropped: **reduction, foundational a/s boundary**.
- Metaphysics against natural science: a difference of **degree**.
- **Grice and Strawson 1956** - co-authored, *Defence*; the reply is about standards of explication.

- **2018 phrase** = the paper's framing, not a Quine quotation.
- Three moves against the certified a priori: **explication failure** -> **holism** -> **naturalism**.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

REMOVE DOGMA 1 + DOGMA 2 -> what is left?

- > sensory evidence KEPT | naturalism KEPT | first philosophy REFUSED
- > metaphysics vs science = DIFFERENCE OF DEGREE
- > OBJECTION: Grice and Strawson 1956, usable distinction needs no definition
- > REJOINER: usability is not theoretical legitimacy
- > 2018 FRAMING: 'metaphysical article of faith' = the PAPER's words
- > THREE MOVES: explication fails -> holism -> naturalism
- > VERDICT: empiricism reformed, not abandoned.

SESSION 8 - ONTOLOGICAL COMMITMENT: "TO BE IS TO BE THE VALUE OF A BOUND VARIABLE"

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: How do you find out what a theory says exists? Not by counting its nouns. You tidy it into logical form and look at what its quantifiers have to range over for the theory to come out true.

Technical definition: Quine's **criterion of ontological commitment**, developed in "On What There Is" (*Review of Metaphysics*, 1948) and summarised by the standard slogan "**to be is to be the value of a bound variable**", holds that a theory is ontologically committed to those entities that must lie within the ranges of its **bound variables** for the theory to be true. It applies **after** a theory has been **regimented** into perspicuous quantificational form, and it audits commitments rather than choosing an ontology.

ANALYSIS: Bounded status. This doctrine is system-enrichment: it is not independently printed in the clause and owns no part of the 2018-2025 corpus. Use it **after** the two-dogmas burden is complete - typically as one paragraph in a 15- or 20-mark answer on Quine's naturalism or on what survives the dogmas.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The bound-variable criterion is an **audit**, not an election: it tells you what a regimented theory has committed itself to, and says nothing about which theory you ought to accept.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **regimentation** · **quantificational form** · **bound variable** · **range of the variable**
- **criterion of commitment, not a rule of choice** · **paraphrase** · **"taste for desert landscapes"**
- **"On What There Is", 1948** - not **"Two Dogmas"**

Plain-language visual - nouns against quantifiers

THE WRONG TEST

'Your theory says PEGASUS,
so you believe in Pegasus.'

'There are prime numbers
greater than a million'

'Pegasus does not exist'

THE RIGHT TEST

'Tidy the theory into logic.
Then ask: for this to be TRUE,
what must the variables RANGE OVER?'

-> the quantifier ranges over NUMBERS
-> COMMITMENT to numbers

-> paraphrase away the NAME
-> NO commitment to Pegasus

Names can be paraphrased away; quantifiers cannot be talked away.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the criterion in four steps, with its four cautions

THE CRITERION, STEP BY STEP

=====

- 1 REGIMENT the accepted theory into perspicuous quantificational form - first-order logic with quantifiers and variables.
- 2 READ OFF the entities that must lie in the RANGES OF THE BOUND VARIABLES for the theory to be true.
- 3 THOSE are the theory's ontological commitments.
- 4 'To be is to be the value of a bound variable' is the standard SLOGAN for this criterion. Treat it as a canonical summary, not as a verbatim sentence from any one paper, and NEVER source it to 'Two Dogmas'. The criterion is developed in 'ON WHAT THERE IS', Review of Metaphysics, 1948.

=====

FOUR CAUTIONS - EACH IS A MARK

- CAUTION 1 It is a criterion of COMMITMENT, not a mechanical rule for choosing which total theory or ontology to accept. Theory-choice still invokes empirical adequacy, simplicity, conservatism and explanatory power.
- CAUTION 2 Commitment is NOT surface word-counting. Names can be PARAPHRASED AWAY; and apparently name-free quantification can carry heavy commitment.
- CAUTION 3 'Taste for desert landscapes' expresses PARSIMONY, not nominalism at any cost. Quine accepts abstract entities where the best regimented science indispensably quantifies over them.
- CAUTION 4 The broader INDISPENSABILITY ARGUMENT for mathematical objects is commonly associated with QUINE AND PUTNAM together; it must not be attributed to the slogan alone.

=====

THE STANDING OBJECTION, AND THE HONEST REPLY

- OBJECTION rival paraphrases of the same theory can display different commitments, so the criterion's verdict depends on a prior choice of regimentation.
- REPLY correct, and Quine says so: the formula is applied AFTER theory and regimentation have been chosen. It is an audit of a chosen theory, not an algorithm that uniquely selects an ontology.

Caption: four steps, four cautions, one objection with a conceded reply. The conceded point is not a weakness in the answer; stating it is what shows the criterion has been understood.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. FACT: **Regiment first.** The criterion has no application to unregimented prose. This is why "count the nouns" is not merely a crude version of the test but a different test altogether.
2. FACT: **Read the commitments off the bound variables**, not off names or predicates. What matters is what the quantifiers must range over for the theory to be **true**.
3. ANALYSIS: **Provenance.** The criterion belongs to "**On What There Is**" (1948). Sourcing the slogan to "Two Dogmas" (1951) is one of the commonest datable errors on this clause.
4. ANALYSIS: **Parsimony, not nominalism.** "A taste for desert landscapes" expresses a preference for economy. Quine accepts abstract entities where the best regimented science indispensably quantifies over them.
5. ANALYSIS: **Do not over-attribute the indispensability argument.** It is standardly associated with **Quine and Putnam**; the slogan alone does not carry it.
6. CAUTION: **The regimentation objection, conceded.** Rival paraphrases display different commitments, so the criterion presupposes a choice. Quine's position is precisely that the criterion audits a theory already chosen - which fits the naturalism, since theory-choice is scientific business, not a matter for first philosophy.
7. ANALYSIS: **The relation to ontological relativity.** The **criterion** audits what a regimented theory quantifies over. **Ontological relativity** (Session 10) is a different and later thesis about how reference is fixed relative to a background theory. Merging them is a doctrinal error, not a shorthand.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: Quine's criterion tells us what a theory says there is without telling us what to believe. **Evidence:** in "On What There Is" (1948) he holds that a theory is committed to whatever must lie in the ranges of its bound variables for it to be true, a criterion applied only after regimentation into quantificational form and summarised in the slogan "to be is to be the value of a bound variable". **Analysis:** the criterion therefore separates two questions that ordinary ontological disputes conflate - what a theory commits us to, and which theory to hold - and it explains why names such as "Pegasus" can be paraphrased away while quantification over numbers cannot. **Qualification:** because rival regimentations display different commitments, the formula presupposes a prior choice of theory and paraphrase, so it is an audit rather than an algorithm, and Quine's "taste for desert landscapes" expresses parsimony rather than nominalism at any cost.

EXAM LINK

- **2021 Q3(c)** and **2018 Q2(c)** - one paragraph each, showing what naturalism puts in place of first philosophy. It is enrichment, not the spine.
- ANALYSIS: No routed part asks about ontological commitment directly. Never let it displace the two dogmas.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
"Ontological commitment = count the nouns"	Commitment is read from bound variables after regimentation .
Sourcing the slogan to "Two Dogmas"	It belongs to "On What There Is" (1948) .
"Quine is a nominalist"	Parsimony, yes; nominalism at any cost, no. He accepts what indispensable quantification requires.
Merging the criterion with ontological relativity	Two theses, two jobs, two dates (1948 against 1968/69).
Presenting the criterion as choosing an ontology	It audits a chosen theory; choice is made on scientific and pragmatic grounds.

REVISION NOTES

- **"On What There Is" (1948)**; slogan is a canonical summary, not a sourced sentence from "Two Dogmas".
- Steps: **regiment -> read the bound variables -> those are the commitments**.
- Cautions: criterion not rule · paraphrase, not word-counting · parsimony not nominalism · indispensability is Quine and Putnam.
- Objection conceded: **regimentation-dependence**.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

WHAT DOES A THEORY SAY EXISTS?

- > REGIMENT into quantificational logic
- > ask what the BOUND VARIABLES must range over for it to be TRUE
- > those are the COMMITMENTS ('to be is to be the value of a bound variable')
- > SOURCE: 'On What There Is' 1948, NOT 'Two Dogmas' 1951
- > CAUTIONS: audit not algorithm | paraphrase | parsimony | Quine AND Putnam
- > OBJECTION: rival regimentations differ -> CONCEDED, by design.

SESSION 9 - RADICAL TRANSLATION AND GAVAGAI: INSCRUTABILITY OF REFERENCE AND INDETERMINACY OF TRANSLATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Imagine a linguist landing among speakers of a wholly unknown language with no dictionary and no interpreter. All he can observe is what people are exposed to and what they assent to. Quine argues that even perfect evidence of this kind cannot fix what their words refer to.

Technical definition: Radical translation is translation of a hitherto untouched language on the sole evidence of observable behaviour. From it Quine derives **inscrutability of reference** - behavioural evidence does not uniquely determine what a term refers to - and **indeterminacy of translation** - rival **analytical hypotheses** can generate manuals agreeing on all observation sentences while translating theoretical sentences into non-equivalent English. The material is developed in *Word and Object* (1960), **chapter 2**.

ANALYSIS: **Bounded status**. Fully available and taught here in full, but not independently printed or PYQ-owned in 2018-2025. It is the **constructive completion** of "Two Dogmas" and is used after that burden is discharged.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Gavagai is not a curiosity but the constructive half of Quine's critique: "Two Dogmas" showed that analyticity could not be defined, and radical translation shows **why** - there are no determinate meanings for a definition to capture.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- stimulus meaning · occasion sentence and standing sentence · observation sentence
- analytical hypotheses · inscrutability of reference · indeterminacy of translation
- the apparatus of individuation · undetached rabbit-parts · rabbit stages · rabbithood

Plain-language visual - why you cannot simply ask

A rabbit runs past. The native says 'GAVAGAI'.
You write: gavagai = RABBIT.
|
BUT the same scene is equally consistent with
gavagai = UNDETACHED RABBIT-PARTS
gavagai = A TEMPORAL STAGE OF A RABBIT
gavagai = RABBITHOOD (an instance of the universal)
gavagai = 'IT'S RABBITING' (no object at all)
|
'Then ASK: is THIS gavagai the SAME as THAT one?'
|
To ask that you must already have translated
IS ... THE SAME AS ... the plural the articles
the quantifiers - i.e. THE WHOLE APPARATUS
OF INDIVIDUATION - which is EXACTLY what is in dispute.

The question that would settle the matter cannot be asked until the matter is settled.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the nine-step argument and the taxonomy that keeps four doctrines apart

THE EVIDENCE THE LINGUIST HAS - EXACT TERMS
=====

STIMULUS MEANING	the class of stimulations that would prompt ASSENT to a sentence, paired with the class that would prompt DISSENT
OCCASION SENTENCE	assent commanded only when freshly prompted ('Gavagai', 'It's raining')
STANDING SENTENCE	assent persists without fresh prompting ('Copper conducts electricity')
OBSERVATION SENTENCE	an occasion sentence whose stimulus meaning is CONSTANT ACROSS SPEAKERS - the only place translation is secure
ANALYTICAL HYPOTHESES	the linguist's posited segmentation of native sentences into words and grammatical apparatus, projected beyond the observational base. THESE ARE NOT DETERMINED BY ANY EVIDENCE.

=====

THE ARGUMENT, NUMBERED

- 1 Rabbit runs past; native utters 'Gavagai'; linguist records assent under rabbit-stimulation and writes 'Rabbit'.
- 2 The SAME stimulus meaning is equally compatible with 'undetached rabbit-parts', 'a temporal stage of a rabbit', 'rabbithood', and the feature-placing 'it's rabbiting'.
- 3 Could he simply ASK 'is this gavagai the same as that one?'
NO - that requires the IDENTITY PREDICATE, articles, plurals and quantifiers already translated: the whole APPARATUS OF INDIVIDUATION, which differs across languages and is exactly what is in dispute.
- 4 Any further evidence can be ACCOMMODATED by compensating adjustments: a different translation of 'gavagai' offset by a different translation of 'same' - and the two manuals predict IDENTICAL behaviour throughout.
- 5 THEREFORE INSCRUTABILITY OF REFERENCE: behavioural evidence does not uniquely determine whether a term refers to rabbits, undetached rabbit parts or rabbit stages.
- 6 Extending upward from terms to sentences, rival ANALYTICAL HYPOTHESES generate manuals agreeing on all observation sentences yet translating theoretical sentences into NON-EQUIVALENT English.
- 7 THEREFORE INDETERMINACY OF TRANSLATION: on Quine's naturalistic account, incompatible manuals can fit the total behavioural evidence without a further meaning-fact selecting one of them.
- 8 THEREFORE there are no determinate MEANINGS as entities; synonymy has no behavioural anchor; and the first dogma's key notion is left without a foundation.
- 9 ONTOLOGICAL RELATIVITY is the broader thesis that reference is specified only RELATIVE TO A BACKGROUND THEORY or manual. Keep it distinct from the 1948 criterion of commitment.

=====

TAXONOMY CONTROL - FOUR DOCTRINES, FOUR UNITS

RADICAL TRANSLATION		method/situation: build a manual from public evidence with no prior dictionary
INDETERMINACY		sentences/manuals: incompatible manuals preserve the total evidence
INSCRUTABILITY		sub-sentential terms: reference varies under compensating changes of apparatus
ONTOLOGICAL RELATIVITY		frameworks: reference is fixed only relative to a background theory

Caption: five exact technical terms, nine numbered steps and a four-row taxonomy. Confusing indeterminacy with inscrutability is the single commonest error here, and the taxonomy prevents it.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. FACT: **Set the scene exactly.** No dictionary, no bilingual informant, no shared script. The only evidence is what speakers are exposed to and what they assent to or dissent from.
2. FACT: **Use the five technical terms.** Each is a distinct device, and using them is what distinguishes an exposition from a retelling of the rabbit story.
3. FACT: **Run the nine steps.** The pivot is step 3: the disambiguating question presupposes the very apparatus under dispute.

4. ANALYSIS: **State the presuppositions, because every objection enters through them. P1 - behaviourism about the evidence:** Quine's own formulation is that in psychology one may or may not be a behaviourist, but in linguistics one has no choice, since language is learned wholly from publicly observable behaviour. **P2 - the evidential step:** the move from total behavioural equivalence to "no further fact" is a substantive Quinean commitment, not a neutral consequence every holist accepts. **P3 - naturalism:** there is no first-philosophy standpoint from which to certify meanings.
5. CAUTION: **Objection one - Chomsky.** Indeterminacy is nothing but the ordinary **underdetermination of theory by evidence**, which afflicts physics too; if Quine is a realist about physics despite underdetermination, he must be a realist about meaning. **Quine's reply:** the cases differ - in physics there *is* a fact of the matter our theories imperfectly track, whereas in translation there is **nothing beyond dispositions to verbal behaviour** for a manual to be right about. **Residual:** whether this asymmetry can be defended without begging the question is the central dispute. **Name it and take a side.**
6. CAUTION: **Objection two - Searle and Evans.** Applied reflexively the argument entails that **I do not determinately know what I mean by my own words. Quine accepts a version of this:** at home we simply **acquiesce in our mother tongue**; the first-person case has no privileged status, only a default one. **Residual:** many find the bullet too large to bite.
7. CAUTION: **Objection three - Chomsky again, on innateness.** Innate constraints on possible grammars would cut down the space of admissible manuals. **Reply:** the residual manuals would still be behaviourally equivalent; innateness restricts candidates without creating a fact of the matter. Genuinely open.
8. ANALYSIS: **Objection four - Davidson.** Radical **interpretation (1973)** shows more determinacy once charity and a truth-theory are built in; Davidson accepts indeterminacy but confines it to something like the choice of **measurement scale** - Fahrenheit against Celsius - real but harmless. The most influential softening; worth one sentence. WRONG: Note the word: **interpretation**, not translation.
9. ANALYSIS: **The executable verdict.** The argument's force is exactly proportional to its behaviourist premise, and Chomsky's objection identifies the pressure point precisely. What survives even if one rejects the premise is the **negative** result: nothing in observable use fixes reference uniquely, so any theory of meaning owing everything to use owes an account of individuation it has not given.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: Radical translation shows that reference is not fixed by behavioural evidence. **Evidence:** in *Word and Object* (1960, ch. 2) the linguist who records assent to "Gavagai" under rabbit-stimulation cannot discriminate "rabbit" from "undetached rabbit-parts", "a temporal stage of a rabbit" or "rabbithood", because the disambiguating question presupposes a translated identity predicate and the whole apparatus of individuation. **Analysis:** since compensating adjustments preserve all behavioural predictions, rival analytical hypotheses yield manuals that agree on every observation sentence yet diverge elsewhere, so there are no determinate meanings for synonymy - and hence for analyticity - to rest on. **Qualification:** the argument's force is proportional to its behaviourist premise about evidence, and Chomsky's objection that this is merely ordinary underdetermination identifies the pressure point, so what survives independently is the negative result that use alone does not fix reference.

EXAM LINK

- ANALYSIS: **No routed part asks for gavagai.** It is used as **one paragraph** in a 15- or 20-mark Quine answer - most naturally in **2019 Q1(e)** or **2024 Q4(c)** as the constructive explanation of *why* synonymy has no anchor.
- The taxonomy table is what protects the answer from the commonest confusion when the enrichment is deployed.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
Asserting "meanings are indeterminate" without the construction	Give the gavagai steps and the identity-predicate move, or omit the doctrine.
Confusing inscrutability with indeterminacy	Terms against manuals. Use the four-row taxonomy.
Treating ontological relativity as the 1948 criterion	Two theses, two dates, two jobs.
Attributing the underdetermination objection to "critics"	It is Chomsky's , in "Quine's Empirical Assumptions" (1969).
Writing "Davidson's radical translation"	Radical interpretation (1973) . The change of word marks the change of doctrine.
Letting the enrichment displace the two dogmas	It is bounded material. Discharge the printed burden first.

REVISION NOTES

- Five terms: **stimulus meaning**, **occasion/standing sentence**, **observation sentence**, **analytical hypotheses**.
- Nine steps; the pivot is the **identity predicate** and the **apparatus of individuation**.
- Four rival readings of *gavagai*, including the feature-placing "it's rabbiting".
- Presuppositions **P1-P3**; objections: **Chomsky**, **Searle/Evans**, **innateness**, **Davidson 1973**.
- Verdict: the negative result survives even if the behaviourist premise is rejected.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

NO DICTIONARY -> only assent/dissent under stimulation
 -> 'GAVAGAI' -> rabbit? parts? stage? rabbithood? 'it's rabbiting'?
 -> CANNOT ASK: the question needs the APPARATUS OF INDIVIDUATION
 -> compensating adjustments -> behaviourally identical manuals
 -> INSCRUTABILITY (terms) -> INDETERMINACY (manuals) -> no determinate MEANINGS
 -> so SYNONYMY has no anchor -> DOGMA 1 loses its key notion
 -> OBJECTIONS: Chomsky | Searle/Evans | innateness | Davidson 1973
 -> VERDICT: force = the behaviourist premise; the negative result survives.

SESSION 10 - ONTOLOGICAL RELATIVITY AND NATURALIZED EPISTEMOLOGY: PHILOSOPHY INSIDE THE WEB

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Two late doctrines. First: asking what a word refers to only makes sense against a background theory - there is no view from nowhere. Second: epistemology should stop trying to justify science from outside and instead study, scientifically, how we get from sensory input to theoretical output.

Technical definition: **Ontological relativity** is the thesis that reference is specified only relative to a background theory or translation manual, so that questions of what a term refers to are answerable only within an interpreted framework. **Naturalized epistemology** relocates the theory of knowledge inside empirical science: philosophy is not an external *a priori* foundation of science but proceeds from within the revisable scientific web, and the study of how sensory input produces theoretical output becomes a chapter of psychology. Both are stated in the **1968 Dewey Lectures**, published in *Ontological Relativity and Other Essays* (1969) - the same volume as "Epistemology Naturalized".

ANALYSIS: Bounded status. Neither doctrine is independently printed or PYQ-owned in 2018-2025. Each is worth one disciplined paragraph after the printed burden.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Naturalism is the consequence of holism, not a separate enthusiasm: if no statement is immune to revision, there is no vantage point outside the web from which philosophy could certify the web.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **ontological relativity** · **background theory** · **regress of manuals** · **acquiescence in the mother tongue**

- naturalized epistemology · no first philosophy · Neurath's boat · the normativity objection
- 1968 Dewey Lectures; 1969 volume - never 1951

Plain-language visual - rebuilding the ship at sea

THE FOUNDATIONALIST PICTURE	THE NATURALIST PICTURE
-----	-----
Take the ship into DRY DOCK. Inspect the hull from OUTSIDE. Certify the foundations. THEN sail.	NEURATH'S BOAT: we are sailors who must rebuild the ship ON THE OPEN SEA, plank by plank, never able to put in to dry dock. (The epigraph of Word and Object.)
There is NO DRY DOCK. That single image is the whole of Quine's anti-foundationalism, and it is the reason epistemology must be conducted from INSIDE science.	

One image, one doctrine: no external standpoint, therefore no first philosophy.

VISUAL: VISUAL - two doctrines, their arguments and the objection each attracts

ONTOLOGICAL RELATIVITY (Dewey Lectures 1968; volume 1969)

=====

THESIS what a term refers to is settled only RELATIVE TO a
background theory or translation manual.

ROUTE inscrutability of reference generalised: to specify the
reference of a term you must use ANOTHER language or
theory - and its reference is fixed only relative to a
further background, and so on.

STOPPING POINT in practice we ACQUIESCE IN OUR MOTHER TONGUE and
take its reference at face value - a default, not a
privilege.

KEEP APART 1948 CRITERION: what does a regimented theory quantify
over? 1968/69 RELATIVITY: relative to what is
reference itself fixed? Different questions.

=====

NATURALIZED EPISTEMOLOGY ('Epistemology Naturalized', 1969)

=====

THESIS epistemology becomes a chapter of empirical psychology:
the scientific study of how meagre sensory input yields
torrential theoretical output.

MOTIVE the collapse of the Cartesian and Carnapian foundational
projects. If the world cannot be RATIONALLY RECONSTRUCTED
from experience, the remaining question is how the
construction is in fact achieved.

IMAGE NEURATH'S BOAT - rebuild at sea; there is no dry dock.
(The epigraph of Word and Object, 1960.)

THE OBJECTION THAT MUST BE STATED - NORMATIVITY

A causal story about how belief is ACQUIRED appears to replace
the question 'What OUGHT one to believe?' with 'How is belief
PRODUCED?' Epistemology is thereby not naturalised but
ABANDONED.

QUINE'S REPLY

Prediction, truth-seeking and method-selection can themselves be
studied and improved FROM WITHIN science; later formulations
allow a naturalized normative 'ENGINEERING' of inquiry - the
technology of truth-seeking.

THE RESIDUAL - CONCEDE IT

Continuity with science blocks first philosophy, but does not by
itself DERIVE epistemic norms from causal facts. Saying this is
what makes the paragraph an assessment rather than a report.

*Caption: two doctrines kept apart from the 1948 criterion, each with its argument, its image and the objection it attracts
- with the residual conceded rather than concealed.*

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. ANALYSIS: **Date them correctly.** Dewey Lectures **1968**; the volume **1969**, which also contains "Epistemology Naturalized". WRONG: Do not date naturalized epistemology to 1951.
2. FACT: **Ontological relativity is a generalisation of inscrutability.** Specifying reference requires another language, whose reference is in turn relative - hence the regress, and hence the practical stopping point of **acquiescing in the mother tongue.**

3. ANALYSIS: **Keep the two ontological doctrines apart.** The **1948 criterion** audits what a regimented theory quantifies over. **Relativity** concerns how reference is fixed at all. One is bookkeeping; the other is about the currency.
4. FACT: **Naturalized epistemology follows from the collapse of reconstruction.** If the *Aufbau* programme cannot rationally reconstruct the world from experience, the remaining question is the empirical one: how does the construction actually happen?
5. FACT: **Neurath's boat** is the governing image and the **epigraph of Word and Object (1960)**. Citing the epigraph is a cheap, checkable mark.
6. CAUTION: **The normativity objection and the reply.** Objection: a causal account of belief-acquisition abandons the question of justification. Reply: norms of prediction and method can be studied and improved from within science - naturalized normative "engineering". Residual: continuity with science blocks first philosophy but does not by itself derive epistemic norms from causal facts. **Concede the residual.**
7. ANALYSIS: **Boundary.** This is where Quine's clause touches Topic 07: the positivists' reconstruction programme is theirs to expound; here it appears only as the project whose failure motivates naturalisation.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: Quine's late doctrines are the disciplined consequence of holism rather than additions to it. **Evidence:** the Dewey Lectures of 1968, published in *Ontological Relativity and Other Essays* (1969) alongside "Epistemology Naturalized", argue that reference is fixed only relative to a background theory and that epistemology becomes the scientific study of how sensory input yields theoretical output, under the governing image of Neurath's boat used as the epigraph of *Word and Object* (1960). **Analysis:** both follow from the denial of an external standpoint - if no statement is immune to revision, no statement can serve as the dry dock from which the rest is certified - so questions of reference and of justification must be answered from inside a going theory. **Qualification:** the normativity objection is not fully answered, since studying method scientifically explains how inquiry is improved without deriving epistemic norms from causal facts, and the honest verdict concedes that residual.

EXAM LINK

- **2018 Q2(c), 15 marks** - naturalism is the **third** of the three moves against a certified Kantian a priori, and this session supplies it with dates and an image.
- **2021 Q3(c)** - one paragraph on what replaces foundationalism after the dogmas are removed.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
Dating naturalized epistemology to 1951	1968 lectures, 1969 volume.
"Quine reduces epistemology to psychology and nothing else"	He relocates it inside science and allows a normative engineering of inquiry; the residual is still conceded.
Merging relativity with the 1948 criterion	Different questions: what a theory quantifies over, against how reference is fixed.
Using Neurath's boat without attributing it	It is Neurath's , and it is the epigraph of Word and Object (1960) .
Expounding Carnap's <i>Aufbau</i> here	Topic 07 owns it. One clause, as the failed programme.

REVISION NOTES

- **1968** Dewey Lectures; **1969** volume with "Epistemology Naturalized".
- Relativity = reference relative to a **background theory**; stopping point = **acquiescence in the mother tongue**.
- Naturalized epistemology = the scientific study of input-to-output; motive = the failure of rational reconstruction.
- **Neurath's boat**, epigraph of *Word and Object* (1960).
- **Normativity objection** -> engineering reply -> conceded residual.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

NO STATEMENT IMMUNE -> no standpoint outside the web -> NO FIRST PHILOSOPHY
-> ONTOLOGICAL RELATIVITY: reference only relative to a background theory
(regress -> acquiesce in the mother tongue)
-> NATURALIZED EPISTEMOLOGY: study how input yields output, inside science
-> IMAGE: NEURATH'S BOAT, epigraph of Word and Object 1960
-> OBJECTION: normativity | REPLY: engineering | RESIDUAL: conceded
-> DATES: 1968 lectures, 1969 volume - never 1951.

SESSION 11 - THE QUINE LEDGER: THE CRITICISMS, THE REPLIES, AND THE BOUNDED COMPARISON WITH LATER WITTGENSTEIN

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Everything Quine says attracts a standard objection, and each objection has a standard reply and a residue that survives it. This session collects them so that an "examine" or "critically discuss" directive can be answered rather than acknowledged.

Technical definition: The **criticism ledger** for Quine records, for each doctrine, the strongest published objection, Quine's available reply and the **residual** - what remains unsettled after the exchange. It is completed by a **bounded comparison** with the later Wittgenstein, whose independent route to the rejection of private meaning-fixers converges with Quine's, and whose decisive divergence is that Quine **reforms** language by regimentation while Wittgenstein **describes** it and forbids theory-construction.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The standard objections to Quine do not overturn the two dogmas argument; they narrow its conclusion - from "there is no analytic/synthetic distinction" to "the distinction cannot bear the foundational weight empiricism placed on it".

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **residual** · **graded verdict** · **pre-theoretical sorting against principled ground**
- **Neurath's boat** against "**my spade is turned**" · **museum myth of meaning** against the **Augustinian picture**
- **reform against description**

Plain-language visual - how to score an objection

OBJECTION -> REPLY -> RESIDUAL

The RESIDUAL is what you write in the last sentence.

An answer that stops at OBJECTION looks unprepared.

An answer that stops at REPLY looks partisan.

An answer that names the RESIDUAL looks examined.

Three columns, and the third is where the marks are.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the seven-row Quine ledger

OBJECTION	REPLY	RESIDUAL
GRICE AND STRAWSON 1956: the distinction is pre-theoretically clear; we CAN sort cases; Quine demands too much	the PHILOSOPHICAL WORK done by the distinction (positivist meaning- criterion) collapses without a principled ground	a live debate about standards of EXPLICATION - name it and take a graded side
ANALYTICITY SEEMS REAL: 'bachelors are unmarried' differs in KIND from 'all swans are white'	he challenges its foundational EXPLICATION; differential revisability is explained by centrality	web-centrality is not a full semantic REPLACEMENT theory
REVISING LOGIC IS EXTREME: has anyone ever done it?	quantum logic: Birkhoff-von Neumann 1936 formal proposal; Putnam 1968 empirical claim (later abandoned)	the LATER Quine (1970) is a poor witness for the EARLIER Quine's boldest claim
HOLISM IS TOO EXTREME: if EVERYTHING is revisable, science has no fixed point	logic and mathematics are revisable IN PRINCIPLE, held fixed in practice by pragmatic conservatism	'no statement is revisable BY NATURE, only by CHOICE' - the exact formula
NATURALIZATION LOSES NORMATIVITY: causal psychology explains belief but does not JUSTIFY it	method-selection and prediction can be engineered from WITHIN science	whether truth-conducive norms are EXPLAINED or merely ASSUMED
COMMITMENT DEPENDS ON REGIMENTATION: rival paraphrases display different commitments	correct - the formula is applied AFTER theory and regimentation are chosen	the criterion audits; it does not CHOOSE
INDETERMINACY COLLAPSES INTO ORDINARY UNDERDETERMINATION (CHOMSKY)	translation differs: there is nothing beyond behavioural dispositions for a manual to be right about	the asymmetry PRESUPPOSES the naturalism it is supposed to support

Caption: seven objections, seven replies, seven residuals. Any "critically examine" directive on Quine is answered by selecting two rows and writing the third column properly.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. ANALYSIS: **Use the ledger selectively.** A 10-marker takes one row; a 15-marker two; a 20-marker three at most, chosen to match the stem. Listing all seven is a symptom of an unplanned answer.
2. FACT: **The bounded comparison with later Wittgenstein.** Two traditions, no direct influence, and a striking convergence:

Axis	Quine	Later Wittgenstein
Target	the museum myth of meaning - words as labels on determinate mental objects	the Augustinian picture - words as names of objects
Positive account	stimulus meaning is behaviourally specified for suitable occasion sentences; theoretical language is holistic	meaning is use within a language-game and a form of life
Holism	the unit of empirical significance is the whole of science ; sentences do not face experience singly	a word has meaning only within the practice ; to understand a sentence is to understand a language
Anti-foundationalism	Neurath's boat - rebuild at sea, no dry dock	bedrock is reached where " my spade is turned " (<i>Philosophical Investigations</i> Section 217): explanation ends in what we do

Axis	Quine	Later Wittgenstein
Rejection of the private	the indeterminacy argument permits nothing beyond public behaviour to fix meaning	the private-language argument shows nothing private <i>can</i> fix meaning
Method	epistemology naturalised - continuous with science	philosophy as therapy - description, not theory
Where they part	ANALYSIS: decisively : Quine wants a <i>scientific</i> account of language and accepts regimentation into canonical notation - he reforms language	Wittgenstein forbids theory-construction and holds that ordinary language "is in order as it is" (<i>PI</i> Section 98) - he describes it

3. ANALYSIS: **Use the comparison cautiously**. Quine's scientific naturalism and Wittgenstein's grammatical therapy have different aims. Their overlap pressures **private or mentalistic fixers of meaning**; it does not establish one shared positive theory. ANALYSIS: Wittgenstein's own doctrines belong to **Topic 08**; only the comparison belongs here.
4. FACT: **Quine's relation to empiricism, stated once for the ledger**. ANALYSIS: He does **not** simply reject empiricism. **Empiricism without the dogmas** retains sensory evidence and scientific naturalism while rejecting sentence-by-sentence reduction and a foundational analytic/synthetic boundary. Calling it an internal reform is safer than calling him either a logical positivist or the uniquely purified empiricist.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: The standard objections narrow Quine's conclusion rather than defeating it. **Evidence:** Grice and Strawson (1956) show that competent speakers sort analytic cases without theory; the quantum-logic episode shows that revising logic has been proposed by Putnam (1968) on the basis of Birkhoff and von Neumann's 1936 formalism but resisted by Quine's own *Philosophy of Logic* (1970); and Chomsky (1969) argues that indeterminacy is only ordinary underdetermination. **Analysis:** in each case Quine has a reply that preserves the negative result - no principled foundational boundary, no sentence-sized confirmation, no behavioural fact fixing reference - while conceding that the positive replacements are weaker than the slogans suggest. **Qualification:** the residuals are real, and the defensible verdict is that holism is right about confirmation and overstated about revisability, so the two dogmas argument survives in its narrowed form.

EXAM LINK

- Any stem containing "**critically**", "**evaluate**" or "**examine**" - **2021 Q3(c)**, **2019 Q1(e)**, **2018 Q2(c)** - requires the third column of this ledger.
- The Wittgenstein comparison is a **one-sentence** value addition in a 15- or 20-marker; it is never a section.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
Reporting an objection without a reply	Objection -> reply -> residual. Three moves or none.
Expounding Wittgenstein's positive doctrines here	Topic 08 owns them; only the comparison belongs in this clause.
Claiming Quine and Wittgenstein share one theory of meaning	They converge in rejecting private fixers and diverge decisively on reform against description.
Presenting the residuals as fatal	They narrow the conclusion; the negative results stand.

REVISION NOTES

- Seven ledger rows; the **residual** column is the mark-earning one.
- Convergence with later Wittgenstein: museum myth / Augustinian picture; holism; **Neurath's boat** against "**my spade is turned**" (*PI* Section 217); rejection of the private.
- Divergence: **reform** (regimentation) against **description** ("in order as it is", *PI* Section 98).
- Quine's own label: **empiricism without the dogmas**.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

OBJECTION -> REPLY -> RESIDUAL (write the third column)

- > Grice-Strawson | analyticity seems real | revising logic | holism too extreme
- > normativity | regimentation-dependence | Chomsky's underdetermination
- > COMPARISON: Quine and later Wittgenstein converge against PRIVATE meaning
- > DIVERGE: Quine REFORMS by regimentation; Wittgenstein DESCRIBES
- > VERDICT: the negative results stand; the positive replacements are weaker than the slogans suggest.

SESSION 12 - STRAWSON: DESCRIPTIVE AGAINST REVISIONARY METAPHYSICS, AND WHAT INDIVIDUALS IS FOR

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: There are two ways to do metaphysics. You can try to describe the structure of the way we actually think about the world, or you can try to replace it with a better structure. Strawson does the first, and says the second is only useful in the service of the first.

Technical definition: **Descriptive metaphysics** is "content to describe the actual structure of our thought about the world"; **revisionary metaphysics** is "concerned to produce a better structure". Strawson's programme in *Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics* (1959) is to map the conceptual scheme we already employ in identifying, referring to and predicating of particulars - not to build a new ontology. His stated historical affinities are **Aristotle** and **Kant**; his standard contrasts are **Descartes**, **Leibniz** and **Berkeley**.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Strawson's metaphysics is descriptive by design: its conclusions are about the structure of **our conceptual scheme**, and it is precisely this modesty that makes its transcendental arguments work.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **descriptive metaphysics** · **revisionary metaphysics** · **conceptual scheme** · **connective analysis**
- **Aristotle and Kant** (descriptive) · **Descartes, Leibniz and Berkeley** (revisionary)
- **Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics, 1959** - quote the subtitle

Plain-language visual - mapping against rebuilding

DESCRIPTIVE	REVISIONARY
-----	-----
'Here is the map of the city you already live in.'	'Here is a better city. Move.'
Job: make explicit the structure we ALREADY use to identify, refer and predicate.	Job: replace the structure with one that is simpler, tidier or metaphysically purer.
AFFINITY: Aristotle, Kant	CONTRAST: Descartes, Leibniz, Berkeley
Strawson's claim: revisionary metaphysics is at its best when it is IN THE SERVICE OF the descriptive - it shows what happens when a piece of the actual structure is removed.	

A map is not a lesser thing than a blueprint when the question is where you already are.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the distinction, its examples, and what it commits Strawson to

TWO KINDS OF METAPHYSICS (Individuals, 1959, Introduction)	
DESCRIPTIVE	REVISIONARY
DEFINITION describes the ACTUAL structure of our thought about the world	DEFINITION proposes a BETTER structure to replace the actual one
METHOD connective analysis: show how concepts hang together; no concept is analysed away into a privileged base	METHOD reconstruction: begin from a preferred set of simples and rebuild
STRAWSON'S OWN EXAMPLES ARISTOTLE KANT	STRAWSON'S OWN EXAMPLES DESCARTES LEIBNIZ BERKELEY
RELATION revisionary metaphysics is IN THE SERVICE OF descriptive: it is instructive precisely because it shows what is lost when a feature of the actual scheme is dropped.	
WHAT THE PROGRAMME COMMITS STRAWSON TO	
(a) the conclusions concern OUR CONCEPTUAL SCHEME, not a theory-free proof of mind-independent reality (b) the arguments are TRANSCENDENTAL IN FORM: from an undisputed fact about our thought to its conditions (c) an empiricist may ACCEPT the whole of Individuals as excellent conceptual geography while DENYING that it settles what exists. This is the strongest reply available to the empiricist, and CONCEDED IT STRENGTHENS an answer	
THE STANDING OBJECTION	
Descriptive metaphysics is CIRCULAR or CONSERVATIVE: it protects the very scheme used to state its own conditions, and it can freeze current common sense against philosophical innovation.	
STRAWSON'S REPLY	
The task is avowedly INTERNAL. Radical revision and scepticism must themselves BEGIN within some functioning scheme of identification, predication and reference.	
THE COST, STATED HONESTLY	
Description alone cannot prove the scheme uniquely correct or unrevisable.	

Caption: definition, method, Strawson's own examples on both sides, the three commitments the programme carries, and the objection with its reply and its cost.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. **FACT: Give the definitions in his terms**, and then give **his own examples** on both sides. A script with two definitions and no examples has stated the distinction without showing it was read.
2. **FACT: Aristotle and Kant** are the descriptive affinities. **Descartes, Leibniz and Berkeley** are the revisionary contrasts - each of them proposes a structure meant to be better than the one we use.
3. **ANALYSIS: State the relation, not just the contrast.** Revisionary metaphysics is at its most valuable **in the service of** the descriptive: dismantling part of the actual scheme is how we discover what that part was doing.
4. **FACT: The method is connective, not reductive.** Strawson maps how concepts hang together; he does not analyse them away into a privileged base of simples. This is exactly why his programme is incompatible with the empiricist reconstruction it displaces.
5. **ANALYSIS: The three commitments.** Conclusions about **our scheme**; arguments **transcendental in form**; and the concession that an empiricist may accept the geography while denying the ontology. **FACT: The third is not a weakness to be hidden - conceding it strengthens the answer**, because it shows the reader knows what descriptive metaphysics claims.
6. **CAUTION: The circularity/conservatism objection and the reply.** Objection: the programme protects the scheme it uses. Reply: the task is internal, and even radical revision must begin inside some functioning scheme of identification and reference. Cost: description cannot prove the scheme uniquely correct or unrevisable.

7. ANALYSIS: **Provenance.** *Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics* (1959) - the phrase is in the **subtitle**, so quoting the subtitle is exact and checkable. "On Referring" (1950) **predates** it by nine years and is therefore a **precursor**, not an application of the programme.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: Strawson's project is to describe the conceptual scheme we actually use, not to propose a better one.

Evidence: *Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics* (1959) distinguishes descriptive metaphysics, content to describe the actual structure of our thought about the world, from revisionary metaphysics, concerned to produce a better structure, aligning himself with Aristotle and Kant and contrasting Descartes, Leibniz and Berkeley.

Analysis: the choice fixes both the method and the reach of his arguments: connective analysis maps how concepts depend on one another rather than reducing them to a preferred base, and the conclusions are therefore claims about conditions internal to our scheme. **Qualification:** this makes the results modest by design - an empiricist may accept the whole analysis as conceptual geography while denying that it settles what exists - and conceding that limit is what shows the programme has been understood rather than inflated.

EXAM LINK

- **2021 Q3(b), 15 marks** - descriptive metaphysics is the frame that makes "why are these *basic*?" a well-formed question.
- **2020 Q3(b), 15 marks** - the internal/transcendental limitation is the closing qualification.
- **2023 Q4(a), 20 marks** - the person argument is descriptive metaphysics executed; the frame must be stated in one sentence before the argument begins.
- ANALYSIS: The dossier records that this module is promoted to core only if a future paper asks directly what descriptive metaphysics is. Until then it frames answers rather than filling them.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
Two definitions with no examples	Give Aristotle and Kant against Descartes, Leibniz and Berkeley .
"Descriptive metaphysics proves that material bodies exist"	It establishes what our scheme requires, not what exists independently of it.
Treating "On Referring" as an application of the programme	It is 1950 , nine years earlier - a precursor.
Hiding the modesty of the conclusion	Conceding it is a mark-earning move, not a concession of defeat.
Calling the method reductive analysis	It is connective analysis.

REVISION NOTES

- **Descriptive** = describe the actual structure; **revisionary** = produce a better one; the latter serves the former.
- Examples: **Aristotle, Kant / Descartes, Leibniz, Berkeley**.
- Method: **connective**, not reductive.
- Commitments: our scheme · transcendental **in form** · empiricist may accept the geography.
- **1959**, subtitle exact; "**On Referring**" **1950** is a precursor.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

TWO KINDS OF METAPHYSICS -> DESCRIBE the actual scheme | REPLACE it
 -> Strawson DESCRIBES: Aristotle, Kant | contrast Descartes, Leibniz, Berkeley
 -> revisionary is IN THE SERVICE OF descriptive
 -> method: CONNECTIVE analysis, not reduction to simples
 -> commitments: our scheme | transcendental in FORM | empiricist may accept it
 -> objection: circular/conservative | reply: the task is INTERNAL
 -> SOURCE: *Individuals* 1959, phrase in the SUBTITLE.

SESSION 13 - STRAWSON: BASIC PARTICULARS, AND THE ARGUMENT FROM IDENTIFICATION AND RE-IDENTIFICATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Of all the particular things we can pick out - tables, people, events, sounds, sensations, numbers - which ones does the possibility of picking anything out depend on? Strawson answers: enduring public bodies, and persons.

Technical definition: **Basic particulars** are those particulars on which the possibility of **identification** and **reference in general** depends: they can be identified without identifying anything more basic first, while other particulars are identified only through their relations to them. Strawson's answer is that **material bodies** - and **persons** - are basic in our conceptual scheme, because identification requires **re-identification** across time, and re-identification requires a **single unified spatio-temporal framework** whose enduring, publicly observable occupants supply the anchors for demonstrative identification.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Material bodies are basic not because they are metaphysically grander than experiences, but because identification requires **re-identification**, re-identification requires a **single public spatio-temporal framework**, and private, momentary, non-spatial items cannot constitute one.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **identification** · **re-identification** · **demonstrative identification** · **the single spatio-temporal framework**
- **enduring, publicly observable occupants** · **dependent particulars** · **basic particulars**
- **private** · **momentary** · **non-spatial** - the three defects of sense-data

Plain-language visual - the three questions in order

1. Can I PICK THIS OUT and distinguish it from everything else?
needs
 2. Can I PICK IT OUT AGAIN, later, and know it is the same one?
needs
 3. IS THERE ONE SPACE AND ONE TIME in which everything has a place?
needs
 4. ARE THERE THINGS THAT LAST AND THAT ANYONE CAN OBSERVE, to be
the landmarks of that single space and time?
-> MATERIAL BODIES.
- Remove step 4 and step 1 becomes impossible. That is the argument.

Four questions, each one the condition of the one above it.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the five-step argument, and why sense-data fail it

THE ARGUMENT FROM RE-IDENTIFICATION (Individuals, 1959, Part I)

- =====
- 1 To IDENTIFY a particular - pick it out, refer to it - we must be able to DISTINGUISH it from other particulars and RE-IDENTIFY it across time.
 - 2 Re-identification requires a SINGLE, UNIFIED SPATIO-TEMPORAL FRAMEWORK - one space and one time in which all particulars have locations.
 - 3 MATERIAL BODIES are ENDURING, PUBLICLY OBSERVABLE occupants of that framework and provide the standard anchors for DEMONSTRATIVE identification and re-identification.
CAUTION: the framework must NOT be described as a psychological image BUILT OUT OF bodies. It is a condition of our scheme.
 - 4 Many DEPENDENT particulars - experiences, events, sounds - are identified THROUGH their relations to persons, bodies, places and times.
 - 5 THEREFORE material bodies are BASIC: presupposed by the identification of everything else, and not themselves identifiable only by reference to something more basic.
- =====

WHY THE EMPIRICIST'S CANDIDATE FAILS - THREE DEFECTS

SENSE-DATA proposed as the basic particulars
(Russell's logical constructions; Carnap's Aufbau 1928;
phenomenalism generally)

- DEFECT 1 PRIVATE -> cannot ground PUBLIC identification;
no shared framework can be built from
items only one person can have
- DEFECT 2 MOMENTARY -> cannot be RE-IDENTIFIED; there is no
later occasion on which to meet the
same one again
- DEFECT 3 NON-SPATIAL -> lack the spatial relations needed to
CONSTITUTE a framework at all

THEREFORE material bodies are basic - NOT as a metaphysical
preference but as a CONDITION OF THE POSSIBILITY OF REFERENCE.

=====

WHAT KIND OF ARGUMENT THIS IS - SAY IT EXPLICITLY

NOT a proof of the external world (contrast: Moore's 'here is one
hand') - it is not arguing THAT bodies exist
NOT a causal or scientific claim about perception
BUT TRANSCENDENTAL IN FORM, in a Kantian spirit: from our
practice of objective identification to the CONDITIONS of
that practice
CONCLUSION about the STRUCTURE OF OUR CONCEPTUAL SCHEME

Caption: five numbered steps, the three defects that disqualify sense-data, and an explicit statement of what kind of argument it is. The third block is where 2020 Q3(b) is won.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. FACT: **Ask the question properly first.** Not "what exists?" but: of all the particulars we can identify and refer to - tables, persons, events, sounds, sense-data, numbers - which are **ontologically basic in our conceptual scheme**, in the sense that the possibility of identification and reference in general depends on them?
2. FACT: **Run the five steps.** Identification requires re-identification; re-identification requires one framework; material bodies are its enduring public occupants; dependent particulars are identified through relations to them; therefore bodies are basic.
3. ANALYSIS: **Guard step 3 carefully.** The framework is **not** a psychological image built out of bodies. It is a structural condition of the scheme in which identification is possible. Describing it psychologically converts a transcendental argument into empirical speculation and loses the question's point.
4. FACT: **Name the dependent particulars.** Experiences, events and sounds are identified through their relations to **persons, bodies, places and times** - a flash of pain is *this* person's, at *this* time; a sound is the one heard *here, then*.
5. FACT: **Deploy the three defects as a unit.** Sense-data are **private, momentary** and **non-spatial**; each defect independently disqualifies them, and together they show that the failure is structural, not accidental.
6. ANALYSIS: **Say what kind of argument it is.** Not Moore's proof of the external world; not a causal claim about perception; but transcendental **in form**, moving from a practice to its conditions, with a conclusion about the structure of our scheme.

7. ANALYSIS: **Persons are basic too.** *Individuals* argues for **two** kinds of basic particular - material bodies and persons - and the 2021 question names both. An answer that gives only bodies has answered half the question.
8. FACT: **Reference and predication.** Basic particulars are basic **objects of reference**: the subject-predicate structure of ordinary discourse depends on identifying something and then predicating something of it. **Feature-placing** expressions such as "It is raining here" need not identify a particular in full subject-predicate form, but they do not replace the framework through which particular-reference becomes possible. ANALYSIS: This is answer-worthy support, not a separate printed doctrine.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: Material bodies are basic particulars because they are the condition of identifying anything at all. **Evidence:** Part I of *Individuals* (1959) argues that identification requires re-identification, that re-identification requires a single unified spatio-temporal framework, and that enduring, publicly observable material bodies are the occupants that anchor demonstrative identification within it, while experiences, events and sounds are identified only through their relations to persons, bodies, places and times. **Analysis:** the empiricist's proposed basic particulars fail all three requirements at once - sense-data are private and so cannot ground public identification, momentary and so cannot be re-identified, and non-spatial and so cannot constitute a framework - which is why the failure is structural rather than a defect of detail. **Qualification:** the argument is transcendental in form rather than a proof of the external world, so its conclusion concerns the structure of our conceptual scheme, and Strawson's descriptive programme claims nothing more.

EXAM LINK

- **2021 Q3(b), 15 marks** - "What according to Strawson are basic particulars? What reasons does Strawson offer to believe that 'material bodies' and 'persons' are basic particulars? Critically discuss." This session is the first half; Session 15 supplies the second.
- **2020 Q3(b), 15 marks** - "Evaluate the role of spatio-temporal thinking in objective thinking with reference to Strawson's theory of basic particulars." Steps 1-3 are the spine; the internal limitation is the verdict.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
"Basic particulars = atoms or ultimate simples"	They are macroscopic bodies and persons - the things we actually identify and re-identify. Not microphysical.
Listing what a basic particular is, without an argument	The directive requires why they are basic - an argument from identification.
Giving only material bodies in the 2021 question	It names material bodies and persons . Answer both.
Describing the framework as a mental image	It is a condition of the scheme, not a psychological construct.
Treating the argument as a proof that bodies exist	Its conclusion is about our conceptual scheme.

REVISION NOTES

- Five steps: identify -> re-identify -> one framework -> dependent particulars -> bodies basic.
- Three defects of sense-data: **private · momentary · non-spatial**.
- Dependent particulars: experiences, events, sounds - identified via persons, bodies, places, times.
- Argument type: **transcendental in form**; conclusion about **our scheme**.
- **Two** kinds of basic particular: **material bodies and persons**.
- Support: reference and predication; **feature-placing** does not replace the framework.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

IDENTIFY -> requires RE-IDENTIFY -> requires ONE SPATIO-TEMPORAL FRAMEWORK
-> occupants must be ENDURING and PUBLICLY OBSERVABLE -> MATERIAL BODIES
-> dependent particulars (experiences, events, sounds) identified THROUGH them
-> sense-data fail: PRIVATE | MOMENTARY | NON-SPATIAL
-> so bodies (and persons) are BASIC in our scheme
-> ARGUMENT TYPE: transcendental in form, not a proof of the external world.

SESSION 14 - THE PURELY AUDITORY WORLD, AND WHAT THE THOUGHT-EXPERIMENT ACTUALLY SHOWS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Strawson asks whether a creature whose entire experience was sound - no sight, no touch, no space - could still think about objective particulars. The answer is not a flat "no"; it is that such a world would need something doing the job space does for us.

Technical definition: The **no-space world** is a thought-experiment testing whether a conceptual scheme containing only **sounds** - pitch, timbre and temporal succession - can support **objective re-identification**. Strawson's conclusion is that such a scheme requires an **analogue of space**, often reconstructed through a continuously available **master-sound** whose variation supplies a dimension along which auditory particulars can be located and re-encountered. The experiment therefore supports the need for a framework performing the **individuating role** that space performs in our scheme; it does **not** prove that every conceivable scheme must contain visual and tactile bodies like ours.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The auditory world does not show that a sound-only scheme is impossible; it shows what such a scheme would have to acquire - an **analogue of space** - and thereby isolates the exact job that space does in ours.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- purely auditory world · pitch and temporal succession · analogue of space · master-sound
- objective re-identification · individuating role · anthropocentrism objection

Plain-language visual - what a sound-only world lacks

YOU HEAR A NOTE. LATER YOU HEAR A NOTE JUST LIKE IT.
Is it THE SAME PARTICULAR SOUND come back, or a NEW one exactly resembling it?
|
In OUR world you answer by LOCATION: the same bell, in the same tower, in the same street.
|
In a world with only PITCH and BEFORE/AFTER there is no location to appeal to - so there is nothing to make the question objective.
|
THE REPAIR: give the world a MASTER-SOUND that is always audible and varies continuously. Position along that variation now works like a PLACE. Objective re-identification becomes possible.

The repair is the result. What the experiment isolates is the job, not the sense-organ.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the experiment, its conclusion and the objection it answers

THE PURELY AUDITORY WORLD
=====

THE SET-UP
A conceptual scheme containing ONLY sounds: pitch, timbre, loudness and TEMPORAL SUCCESSION. No space. No bodies. No sight or touch.

THE PROBLEM
Objective re-identification needs a way to distinguish 'the SAME particular encountered again' from 'a NEW particular exactly resembling the first'. Qualitative similarity alone cannot do this.

THE RESULT - STATE IT CAREFULLY
A world of pitch and succession alone does NOT YET support robust objective re-identification. Strawson's discussion does NOT simply prove an auditory scheme IMPOSSIBLE. Objective reference would require an ANALOGUE OF SPACE - often reconstructed through a continuously available MASTER-SOUND - that can organise sounds into a PUBLIC-LIKE framework.

WHAT IT THEREFORE SUPPORTS
The need for a framework performing the INDIVIDUATING ROLE that space performs in OUR scheme.

WHAT IT DOES NOT PROVE
That every conceivable scheme must contain visual and tactile material bodies EXACTLY LIKE OURS.

=====

THE OBJECTION IT IS DESIGNED TO MEET
ANTHROPOCENTRISM: 'maybe OUR scheme needs bodies, but a radically alien scheme might not.'

STRAWSON'S ANSWER
The conclusion was always about OUR scheme; and the auditory discussion CONCEDES that an analogue of space - rather than our exact sensory organisation - could perform the needed individuating role. The concession is part of the doctrine, not a retreat from it.

Caption: set-up, problem, carefully stated result, and the objection the experiment exists to answer. The distinction between "impossible" and "would need an analogue of space" is the examinable point.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. **FACT: State the set-up exactly.** Only sounds: pitch, timbre, loudness, and succession in time. No space, no bodies, no visual or tactile modality.
2. **FACT: State the problem exactly.** Objective re-identification requires distinguishing *the same particular again* from *a new particular exactly like it*. Qualitative resemblance cannot make that distinction; a **location** in a framework can.
3. **ANALYSIS: State the result exactly - this is the trap.** Strawson does **not** simply prove the auditory scheme impossible. He argues that objective reference in it would require an **analogue of space**, commonly reconstructed through a continuously available **master-sound** whose variation supplies a locating dimension.
4. **FACT: Draw the right conclusion.** The experiment supports the need for a framework performing the **individuating role** space performs in our scheme. It does not establish that any possible scheme must contain bodies just like ours.
5. **ANALYSIS: Use it where it belongs.** It is the answer to the **anthropocentrism objection**, and it is what makes the basic-particulars argument honest rather than parochial. In a 15-marker it is two sentences; in a 20-marker it is a short paragraph with the master-sound named.
6. **ANALYSIS: Significance, stated precisely.** Strawson provides an argument for the basic status of the physical world that is neither a **proof of the external world** in Moore's manner - it is not arguing *that* bodies exist - nor a causal or scientific claim. It is transcendental in form, and its conclusion concerns the structure of our conceptual scheme.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: The auditory thought-experiment isolates the function of space rather than proving that only our sensory world can be objective. **Evidence:** Strawson imagines a scheme containing only pitch, timbre and temporal succession, and finds that it cannot distinguish the same particular re-encountered from a new one exactly resembling it, so objective reference would require an analogue of space - reconstructed through a continuously available master-sound whose variation supplies a locating dimension. **Analysis:** the experiment therefore identifies the *individuating role* a framework must play, which is why the basic-particulars argument is about the conditions of identification rather than about the privileges of vision and touch. **Qualification:** it does not prove that every conceivable scheme must contain material bodies like ours, and this concession is precisely what answers the charge that descriptive metaphysics is merely anthropocentric.

EXAM LINK

- **2020 Q3(b), 15 marks** - "Evaluate the role of spatio-temporal thinking in objective thinking": the auditory world is the evaluative core, because it shows *what* spatio-temporal thinking contributes by removing it.
- **2021 Q3(b), 15 marks** - the "critically discuss" element: the alien-scheme objection with Strawson's measured concession.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
"A sound-only world is simply impossible"	Strawson asks what analogue of space would be required for objective identification in such a scheme.
Omitting the master-sound	It is the mechanism that makes the analogue concrete; naming it shows the passage was read.
Treating the experiment as decoration	It is the answer to the anthropocentrism objection and the evaluative core of 2020 Q3(b).
Reading it as a proof of the external world	Neither Moore's proof nor a causal claim; transcendental in form.

REVISION NOTES

- Set-up: pitch, timbre, loudness, **succession**; no space.
- Problem: same particular again against a new exactly-similar one.
- Result: **not impossible** - needs an **analogue of space**, e.g. a **master-sound**.
- Supports: the need for a framework with the **individuating role**.
- Answers: the **anthropocentrism** objection.
- Significance: neither Moore's proof nor a causal claim; **transcendental in form**.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

ONLY SOUNDS: pitch + succession, no space

- > can objective RE-IDENTIFICATION occur? -> not yet
- > same particular again OR new exactly-similar one? undecidable
- > REPAIR: an ANALOGUE OF SPACE - a continuously available MASTER-SOUND
- > SO: a framework with the INDIVIDUATING ROLE is required
- > NOT: that every scheme must have bodies exactly like ours
- > USE: the reply to the ANTHROPOCENTRISM objection; the core of 2020 Q3(b).

SESSION 15 - STRAWSON: THE PERSON AS A PRIMITIVE CONCEPT, AND THE ARGUMENT FROM SELF- AND OTHER-AScription

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: A person is not a body with a mind bolted on. It is one thing to which we ascribe *both* weights and heights *and* thoughts and pains - and Strawson argues that this single concept has to come first, because neither "pure mind" nor "pure body" can be understood before it.

Technical definition: The concept of a **person** is **logically primitive**: it is the concept of a type of entity such that **both** predicates ascribing states of consciousness - **P-predicates** - **and** predicates ascribing corporeal characteristics - **M-predicates** - are equally applicable to a single individual of that type. It is not analysable into an independently identifiable body plus an independently identifiable consciousness, and it is, in Strawson's formulation, **"logically prior to that of an individual consciousness"**.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

"Primitive" here means **conceptually prior**, not mysterious: the concept of a person cannot be assembled out of the concepts of a mind and a body, because both of those concepts are already parasitic on it.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **person as a logically primitive concept** · **"logically prior to that of an individual consciousness"**
- **M-predicates** (material) · **P-predicates** (personal/psychological)
- **self-ascription requires other-ascription** · **the dual character of P-predicates** · **without observation**

Plain-language visual - one thing, two kinds of predicate

A P E R S O N (ONE single subject)	
M-PREDICATES also true of MERE BODIES 'weighs 70 kg' 'is in the kitchen' 'has brown hair'	P-PREDICATES ascribe STATES OF CONSCIOUSNESS 'is in pain' 'is thinking of Vienna' 'believes it will rain' 'intends to leave'

BOTH are ascribed to THE SAME THING.

NOT: a body, to which a mind is attached.

NOT: a mind, which happens to have a body.

BUT: one concept of an entity that is **EQUALLY** the subject of both.

Delete either column and the concept collapses into materialism or dualism - the two positions the doctrine exists to displace.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the six-step argument and what "primitive" licenses

THE ARGUMENT: SELF-ASCRPTION REQUIRES OTHER-ASCRPTION

- =====
- 1 I ascribe experiences to MYSELF - self-ascription of P-predicates: 'I am in pain.'
 - 2 A NECESSARY CONDITION of this practice is that I can also ascribe predicates of the same general kinds to OTHERS.
 - 3 Others are identified as EMBODIED SUBJECTS, and psychological predicates are other-ascribed on PUBLICLY AVAILABLE BEHAVIOURAL AND SITUATIONAL CRITERIA.
CAUTION: this is NOT a simple inference from bodily movements to a hidden Cartesian mind.
 - 4 But P-predicates must ALSO be self-ascribable WITHOUT OBSERVATION - I know I am in pain without checking my own behaviour.
 - 5 This DUAL CHARACTER - other-ascribable on public criteria AND self-ascribable without behavioural observation - belongs to PREDICATES OF PERSONS.
 - 6 THEREFORE the concept of a person is LOGICALLY PRIMITIVE within the scheme: it is not analysed as an independently identifiable body PLUS an independently identifiable consciousness.
This is CONCEPTUAL PRIORITY, not the postulation of a third Cartesian substance.
- =====

WHAT 'PRIMITIVE' DOES AND DOES NOT MEAN

- DOES MEAN the concept cannot be CONSTRUCTED from either half; analysis STOPS here because the demand for analysis presupposes the dualism being rejected
- DOES NOT MEAN a mysterious third substance
- DOES NOT MEAN that persons are unanalysable IN EVERY RESPECT
- DOES NOT MEAN materialism: a person has BOTH predicate-classes, so identifying persons with bodies alone LOSES the P-predicates
- =====

WHY A CONCEPT WITH THAT DUAL CONDITION CANNOT BE BUILT FROM EITHER HALF

- From a PURE CONSCIOUSNESS you never reach public criteria, so other-ascription is impossible and the predicates lose their general kind.
- From a PURE BODY you never reach ascription without observation, so self-ascription has no distinctive first-person character.
- Only a subject that is ALREADY BOTH satisfies both conditions - and that subject is the PERSON.

Caption: six numbered steps, an explicit account of what "primitive" licenses, and the two-way impossibility proof that is the heart of the doctrine.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. FACT: **Set the problem before the answer.** Three options were on the table: **Cartesian dualism** (two substances, experiences belonging to an immaterial soul); the **no-ownership or no-subject theory** (experiences causally dependent on a body but not literally possessed by anyone); and Strawson's own - the person as primitive. Naming all three first makes the argument look like a solution rather than an assertion.
2. FACT: **Define the two predicate-classes with examples.** **M-predicates:** "weighs 70 kg", "is in the kitchen", "has brown hair" - predicates also applicable to mere bodies. **P-predicates:** "is in pain", "is thinking of Vienna", "believes it will rain", "intends to leave" - predicates ascribing states of consciousness.
3. FACT: **Insist on the single subject.** Both classes are ascribed to **the same thing**. A person is not a body to *which* a mind is attached; it is a single concept of an entity that is **equally** the subject of physical and mental predicates.
4. FACT: **Run the six steps.** Self-ascription -> the requirement of other-ascription -> identification of others as embodied subjects on public criteria -> self-ascription **without observation** -> the dual character -> conceptual primitiveness.
5. ANALYSIS: **Guard step 3.** Other-ascription proceeds on **publicly available behavioural and situational criteria** - not by inference from movements to a hidden Cartesian mind. Strawson is not offering an improved argument from analogy; he is denying that the problem of other minds is set up correctly.
6. ANALYSIS: **Guard step 6.** "Primitive" is **conceptual priority**, not a third substance and not a claim that persons are unanalysable in every respect. FACT: The canonical formulation is *"The concept of a person is logically prior"*

to that of an individual consciousness."

7. ANALYSIS: **Show the two-way impossibility.** From a pure consciousness you cannot reach public other-ascription; from a pure body you cannot reach unobserved self-ascription. Only a subject that is **already both** satisfies both conditions. This is what makes the conclusion an argument rather than a stipulation.
8. ANALYSIS: **Persons are basic particulars too.** The person concept is not an appendix to Part I of *Individuals*; persons join material bodies as the **second** kind of basic particular, which is why the 2021 question names both.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: The concept of a person is logically primitive rather than compounded from mind and body. **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959, ch. 3) holds that a person is a single entity to which both M-predicates such as "weighs 70 kg" and P-predicates such as "is in pain" are ascribed, and argues that self-ascription of P-predicates is possible only if the same predicates are other-ascribable on publicly available behavioural and situational criteria, while remaining self-ascribable without observation. **Analysis:** a predicate with that dual condition cannot be constructed from either half - a pure consciousness never reaches public criteria and a pure body never reaches unobserved self-ascription - so the subject of such predicates must already be both, and the concept of that subject is prior to the concepts of mind and body. **Qualification:** primitiveness is conceptual priority within our scheme, not the postulation of a third substance, and Strawson's formulation is precisely that the concept of a person is logically prior to that of an individual consciousness.

EXAM LINK

- **2018 Q1(e), 10 marks** - "How does Strawson explain the concept of person in his philosophy? Discuss." The predicate matrix, the argument and the two rejected rivals, in that order.
- **2023 Q4(a), 20 marks** - the same argument, then the implication for mind-body dualism, which is Session 16.
- **2021 Q3(b), 15 marks** - the second half of the basic-particulars question.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
"Person is primitive = dualism"	Primitive is conceptual priority , not a third substance; it undercuts the Cartesian starting point.
"Person is primitive = materialism"	A person bears both predicate-classes; identifying persons with bodies alone loses the P-predicates.
Presenting other-ascription as inference from behaviour to a hidden mind	Public criteria , not analogical inference.
Omitting "without observation" from step 4	The asymmetry is the whole argument; without it the conclusion does not follow.
Giving the matrix without the argument	2018 asks "how does Strawson explain "; the six steps are the explanation.

REVISION NOTES

- Three positions: **dualism, no-ownership, person as primitive.**
- **M-predicates** and **P-predicates**, both on **one** subject; give two examples of each.
- Six steps; guard step 3 (public criteria) and step 6 (conceptual priority).
- Canonical line: **"logically prior to that of an individual consciousness"**.
- Two-way impossibility: pure consciousness fails other-ascription; pure body fails unobserved self-ascription.
- Persons are the **second** kind of basic particular.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

PERSON = ONE subject bearing M-PREDICATES and P-PREDICATES

- > I self-ascribe 'I am in pain'
- > only possible if the same predicates are OTHER-ascribable
- > others identified as EMBODIED SUBJECTS on PUBLIC CRITERIA
- > yet self-ascription proceeds WITHOUT OBSERVATION
- > DUAL CHARACTER -> cannot be built from pure mind OR pure body
- > so PERSON is LOGICALLY PRIMITIVE ('prior to individual consciousness')
- > TRAP: primitive = conceptual priority, NOT a third substance.

SESSION 16 - HOW THE PERSON ARGUMENT UNDERCUTS CARTESIAN DUALISM AND DESTROYS THE NO-OWNERSHIP THEORY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Two rival accounts of the mind are cleared away by the same argument. Dualism starts by splitting the person into two independently identifiable things; the no-ownership theory starts by denying that experiences belong to anyone. Strawson shows that each presupposes the very concept it was trying to do without.

Technical definition: The **no-ownership (no-subject) theory** - a view Strawson reconstructs and criticises, tracing it through Schlick and Wittgenstein-influenced writers - holds that experiences are **causally dependent on a particular body** but are not literally **possessed** by a person. Strawson argues that the theory cannot state its own thesis without covertly reintroducing possession, and that **Cartesian dualism**, by treating an independently identifiable mind and body as conceptually prior, cannot supply the single subject that our practice of predicate-ascription requires.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Strawson defeats Cartesianism more economically than any argument from interaction: he does not ask how mind and body can interact, but shows that the question presupposes a prior unity which neither term can supply.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- no-ownership theory · "all the experiences that are had by this body" · the self-refutation move
- uniquely relevant body · interaction problem · re-identification of an immaterial soul
- dissolution rather than solution · conceptual priority

Plain-language visual - how each rival destroys itself

DUALISM SAYS

- 'First a MIND, first a BODY. Then join them.'
- > But how do you IDENTIFY or RE-IDENTIFY an immaterial soul?
You cannot locate it in space.
- > And once separated, how do they INTERACT?
- > The problem was created by the separation.

NO-OWNERSHIP SAYS

- 'Experiences are not OWNED. There is no subject.'
- > But to state the thesis you must say WHICH experiences:
'all the experiences THAT ARE HAD BY THIS BODY'.
- > 'Had by' is a POSSESSIVE relation.
- > You cannot deny what you need in order to state the denial.

Both rivals fail at the point where they have to say what they are talking about.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the two rivals, their failures, and the exact verdict

THE THREE POSITIONS ON THE TABLE (Individuals, 1959, ch. 3)

POSITION	CLAIM	FAILURE (per Strawson)
CARTESIAN DUALISM	Two substances: mind (res cogitans) and body (res extensa); experiences belong to an immaterial soul	How do we ever IDENTIFY or RE-IDENTIFY an immaterial soul? We cannot locate it in space. And how does INTERACTION work?
NO-OWNERSHIP / NO-SUBJECT (reconstructed and criticised by Strawson; traced through Schlick and Wittgenstein-influenced writers)	Experiences are causally dependent on a body but are NOT literally possessed by a person	The theory cannot explain the UNIQUELY IDENTIFYING ROLE of the body without REINTRODUCING the person whose ownership it sought to eliminate
PERSON AS PRIMITIVE	The concept of a person is logically primitive - not analysable into body plus mind	-- the position that survives

THE SELF-REFUTATION OF NO-OWNERSHIP, IN ONE MOVE

To state the thesis at all the theorist must specify WHICH experiences he is talking about. He says:

'all the experiences THAT ARE HAD BY THIS BODY'

'HAD BY' is a POSSESSIVE relation. The contingent causal dependence he offers cannot replace it, because it does not single out experiences as THESE ONES rather than any others. He therefore reconstructs the personal framework he set out to avoid. P-PREDICATES must be ascribable to others ON THE STRENGTH OF BEHAVIOUR and to oneself NOT on that strength - so the concept of a PERSON is LOGICALLY PRIMITIVE, prior to both mind and body.

THE EXACT VERDICT - WRITE THIS, NOT MORE

DUALISM	treats independently identifiable mind and body as conceptually prior. Strawson's analysis UNDERCUTS THAT STARTING POINT; it does not by itself prove every metaphysical dualist thesis false.
NO-OWNERSHIP	eliminates the person while relying on a uniquely relevant body and a class of experiences; Strawson argues that this RECONSTRUCTS the personal framework it tried to avoid.
OVERALL	the mind-body problem is DISSOLVED rather than solved: the decomposition that generates it is illicit.
THE COST	'primitive' marks the END OF ANALYSIS rather than an EXPLANATION of the psychophysical unity - a legitimate result for descriptive metaphysics, and an unsatisfying one for anybody who wanted the mind-body problem SOLVED.

Caption: three positions, two failures, the self-refutation of no-ownership stated as a single move, and a verdict that says exactly how much has been proved. The last block is what converts a 15-mark answer into a 20-mark one.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. FACT: **Refute two rivals, not one.** The directive decoder for this clause is explicit: the fatal error on a persons question is refuting only dualism. The no-ownership theory is the second target and the more interesting one.
2. FACT: **State dualism's ~~any~~ failures.** Identification and re-identification: an immaterial soul has no spatial location, so it cannot be picked out or picked out again in the single framework identification requires. Interaction: once the two substances are separated, their commerce becomes unintelligible.
3. FACT: **State the no-ownership theory fairly before demolishing it.** It is not a straw man: it takes seriously the fact that experiences are **causally dependent** on a particular body, and it denies only that this dependence amounts to **possession**.
4. FACT: **Deliver the self-refutation in one move.** To say which experiences are in question, the theorist must say "all the experiences **that are had by** this body" - and "had by" is possessive. Causal dependence alone does not

- single out *these* experiences; only ownership does. The thesis cannot be stated without the concept it denies.
5. ANALYSIS: **State the verdict with the right strength.** Strawson **undercuts the starting point** of dualism; he does not mechanically disprove every metaphysical dualist thesis. Overclaiming here is a common and avoidable error.
 6. ANALYSIS: **Name the result: dissolution, not solution.** The demand to explain how mind and body are joined presupposes that they were separately given. Refusing the analysis **is** the solution - the question is shown to be ill-formed.
 7. CAUTION: **Concede the cost.** "How does the person *really* unify the mental and the physical?" is a genuine limitation: Strawson explains that our concept of a person is not *derivable* from separate concepts of mind and body, not the *mechanism* of the unity. ANALYSIS: Strawson's defenders reply that the demand for analysis into mind plus body already presupposes dualism, so refusing it is the point rather than an evasion.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: The primitiveness of the person concept clears away both rival accounts of the mind-body relation.

Evidence: *Individuals* (1959, ch. 3) argues that Cartesian dualism cannot say how an immaterial soul is identified or re-identified within the single spatio-temporal framework that identification requires, and that the no-ownership theorist cannot state his thesis without saying "all the experiences that are had by this body", a formulation whose possessive reintroduces the ownership he denies. **Analysis:** both failures have the same shape - each rival helps itself to the unified subject it claims to dispense with - so the mind-body problem is dissolved rather than solved, since the decomposition that generates it is illicit. **Qualification:** the result is exactly that dualism's starting point is undercut rather than that every dualist thesis is refuted, and "primitive" marks the end of analysis rather than an explanation of psychophysical unity - a legitimate outcome for descriptive metaphysics and an unsatisfying one for anyone who wanted the problem solved.

EXAM LINK

- **2023 Q4(a), 20 marks** - "Why does Strawson consider person to be a primitive concept? What implication does it have for the mind-body dualism? Discuss." Session 15 answers the first question; this session answers the second and supplies the graded verdict.
- **2018 Q1(e), 10 marks** - the two rivals in one compressed sentence each.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
Refuting only dualism	The no-ownership theory is the second target; omitting it loses the structure of the chapter.
"Strawson disproves dualism"	He undercuts its starting point . State the strength exactly.
Presenting the no-ownership theory as obviously silly	Give its motivation - causal dependence without possession - then the self-refutation.
Claiming Strawson solves the mind-body problem	He dissolves it, and the cost of dissolution must be conceded.
Omitting the possessive move	" Had by this body" is the whole refutation.

REVISION NOTES

- Three positions: dualism · no-ownership · person as primitive.
- Dualism fails on **identification/re-identification** and on **interaction**.
- No-ownership self-refutes: "all the experiences **that are had by** this body".
- Verdict: **starting point undercut**, not every dualist thesis disproved.
- Result: **dissolution**, not solution; cost: "primitive" ends analysis without explaining unity.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

TWO RIVALS, ONE ARGUMENT

- > DUALISM: independently identifiable mind + body -> cannot identify or re-identify a soul; interaction unintelligible -> STARTING POINT UNDERCUT
- > NO-OWNERSHIP: experiences causally dependent, not owned
 - > must say 'the experiences HAD BY this body' -> possessive returns
 - > SELF-REFUTATION
- > SURVIVOR: PERSON as logically primitive
- > RESULT: the problem is DISSOLVED, not solved
- > COST: 'primitive' ends analysis; it does not explain the unity.

SESSION 17 - STRAWSON'S BOUNDED EDGE: "ON REFERRING", THE PRESSURE ON EMPIRICIST STARTING POINTS, AND THE STRAWSON LEDGER

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Three further things belong to Strawson without being printed in the syllabus: his famous quarrel with Russell about "The present King of France"; the way his positive doctrines squeeze the empiricist's building materials; and the standard objections to his programme. Each is used *after* the printed material, never instead of it.

Technical definition: In "On Referring" (*Mind*, 1950) Strawson argues that the existence-claim carried by a definite description is **presupposed** by a use of the sentence rather than **asserted** as part of its logical analysis, and that referring is something **speakers do on occasions**, so sentence-meaning must be distinguished from a particular use. His positive doctrines also generate **five bounded connections** with empiricist starting points, and his programme attracts a standard **criticism ledger** whose replies and residuals must be stated for any "critically discuss" directive.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

"On Referring" illustrates Strawson's general method - attending to the actual workings of language in use - which is why it stands to Russell's logical reconstruction as descriptive metaphysics stands to revisionary metaphysics.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **presupposition** against **assertion** · **use** against **sentence-meaning** · **referring is what speakers do**
- **sense-data as the basic particulars** · **the bundle theory of the self** · **logical reconstruction detached from use**
- **the transcendental argument-form in four steps** · "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956) · **descriptive, therefore modest**

Plain-language visual - the King of France, twice

'THE PRESENT KING OF FRANCE IS BALD.' (France has no king.)

RUSSELL, 'On Denoting', 1905

Analyse it as: there is exactly one king of France, and he is bald. The existence condition FAILS, so the whole quantified statement is FALSE.
-> existence is ASSERTED.

STRAWSON, 'On Referring', 1950

A speaker who says this has FAILED TO MAKE a true-or-false assertion at all, because the existence PRESUPPOSITION is not fulfilled.
-> existence is PRESUPPOSED.

THE DEEPER POINT

Russell asks what the SENTENCE means, once and for all.
Strawson asks what a SPEAKER did with it, ON THIS OCCASION.

Two philosophers, one sentence, and a disagreement about what the question even is.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the four-row Russell/Strawson table, the five connections, and the four-step argument-form

'ON DENOTING' 1905 AGAINST 'ON REFERRING' 1950

ISSUE	RUSSELL	STRAWSON
'The present King of France is bald' when France has no king	the quantified analysis is FALSE, because its existence condition fails	the SPEAKER fails to make a true-or-false assertion, because the existence PRESUPPOSITION is not fulfilled
STATUS OF THE EXISTENCE-CLAIM	ASSERTED - part of the logical analysis of the sentence	PRESUPPOSED - a background condition for the sentence to have a truth-value at all
REFERRING	the description is ELIMINATED in logical analysis; scope handled formally	referring is something SPEAKERS DO on occasions; sentence/expression meaning must be distinguished from a particular USE
MEANING	fixed by LOGICAL FORM, once and for all	meaning of a sentence is NOT its use on a particular occasion; use is CONTEXT-DEPENDENT

TRUTH-VALUE CAUTION - DO NOT OVERSTATE

'Neither true nor false' reports Strawson's treatment of the UNSUCCESSFUL USE or ASSERTION. It is NOT the claim that the meaningful sentence-TYPE is meaningless. Later presupposition theories differ over truth-value gaps, falsity and projection; do NOT attribute all later machinery to the 1950 paper.

FIVE BOUNDED CONNECTIONS - STRAWSON AGAINST EMPIRICIST STARTING POINTS

#	EMPIRICIST DOCTRINE	STRAWSON'S ARGUMENT	WHERE
1	SENSE-DATA as the basic particulars (Russell's logical constructions; Carnap's Aufbau; phenomenism)	identification and re-identification need ONE unified spatio-temporal framework; sense-data are PRIVATE, MOMENTARY and NON-SPATIAL	Individuals 1959, Pt I
2	THE BUNDLE THEORY OF THE SELF (Hume; and the no-ownership view traced through Schlick and Wittgenstein-influenced writers)	if experiences were not OWNED the theorist could not state his thesis: he must say 'the experiences HAD BY this body'	Individuals ch. 3
3	LOGICAL RECONSTRUCTION DETACHED FROM USE	referring is performed by speakers on occasions; existence can function as PRESUPPOSITION rather than asserted content	'On Referring' 1950, cross-owned with Russell
4	GLOBAL SCEPTICISM ABOUT INDUCTION	an ORDINARY-CONCEPT DISSOLUTION, not a new inductive proof	Introduction to Logical Theory 1952, optional
5	OBJECTIVITY FROM PRIVATE DATA	objective experience presupposes a unified framework and enduring objects; later he LIMITS transcendental arguments to internal work	The Bounds of Sense 1966 and Skepticism and Naturalism 1985

THE RECURRING ARGUMENT-FORM - STRAWSON'S TRANSCENDENTAL STYLE

- 1 Take an UNDISPUTED FACT about our thought or talk - that we identify and re-identify particulars; that we ascribe experiences to others.

- 2 Ask WHAT MUST BE THE CASE for that fact to be possible.
 - 3 Show that the empiricist's preferred materials - private sense-data, unowned experiences - CANNOT satisfy the condition.
 - 4 THEREFORE something else is basic - material bodies, persons - and it is basic CONCEPTUALLY, not causally or metaphysically.
- This is a Kantian-style argument executed through CONCEPTUAL ANALYSIS. It identifies conditions INTERNAL to our scheme; it must not be inflated into a theory-free proof of reality.

=====

TWO HONEST QUALIFICATIONS EVERY ANSWER SHOULD MAKE

(a) On the ANALYTIC/SYNTHETIC distinction, GRICE AND STRAWSON ('In Defence of a Dogma', 1956) DEFEND an ordinary distinction AGAINST Quine. This prevents the caricature of a united 'Quine-Strawson front'.

(b) Strawson's metaphysics is DESCRIPTIVE, so his conclusions are about OUR CONCEPTUAL SCHEME, not about mind-independent reality. An empiricist can therefore accept the whole of Individuals as good conceptual geography while denying that it settles what exists. THIS IS THE STRONGEST REPLY AVAILABLE TO THE EMPIRICIST, AND CONCEDED IT STRENGTHENS RATHER THAN WEAKENS AN ANSWER.

Caption: the Russell contrast with its truth-value caution, the five bounded connections with their exact locations, the four-step argument-form, and the two qualifications that keep an answer honest.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. ANALYSIS: **Fence "On Referring" before using it.** It is **not** in the printed clause - the syllabus says "Critique of Empiricism; Basic Particulars and Persons". But it illustrates Strawson's method and is frequently combined with Russell, who **is** in the syllabus. One sentence of fencing, then use it.
2. FACT: **Give the four-row contrast**, and note the chronology: "On Referring" (1950) **predates** *Individuals* (1959) by nine years, so it is a precursor rather than an application.
3. ANALYSIS: **Observe the truth-value caution.** "Neither true nor false" reports Strawson's treatment of the unsuccessful **use**, not a claim that the sentence-type is meaningless. Later presupposition theories divide between gap, falsity and pragmatic treatments; the 1950 paper must not stand for all of them.
4. FACT: **Deploy the five connections as a bounded synthesis.** The printed and PYQ-tested division assigns the direct critique of empiricism to Quine; a cross-cutting answer may nevertheless show how Strawson's positive doctrines pressure a private sense-datum starting point. ANALYSIS: This is a **connection**, not a reassignment of the printed limb.
5. FACT: **Run the four-step argument-form.** Undisputed fact -> its conditions -> the empiricist's materials fail -> something else is basic, conceptually. Naming the form shows the two Strawson doctrines are one argument applied twice.
6. ANALYSIS: **Make the two honest qualifications.** They are the difference between an answer that reports Strawson and one that has understood the shape of his commitments.
7. CAUTION: **The Strawson criticism ledger** - five rows, with replies and residuals:

Objection	Reply	Residual
Is "person is primitive" an explanation or a re-labelling ? Calling the concept unanalysable may simply refuse to address the hard problem of consciousness.	ANALYSIS: Strawson's defenders: the demand for analysis into mind plus body already presupposes dualism, so refusing analysis is the solution - dissolving the question rather than answering it.	The dissolution is legitimate for descriptive metaphysics and unsatisfying for anyone who wanted the problem solved.
The basic-particulars argument is anthropocentric : maybe <i>our</i> scheme needs bodies, but a radically alien scheme might not.	ANALYSIS: The conclusion always concerned our scheme, and the auditory-world discussion concedes that an analogue of space , rather than our exact sensory organisation, could perform the individuating role.	Whether "our scheme" can be delimited without circularity remains open.
How does the person really unify the mental and the physical? "Primitive" does not explain the psychophysical nexus.	CAUTION: Genuine limitation. Strawson explains only that our concept of a person is not derivable from separate concepts of mind and body.	The mechanism of unity is untouched, and Strawson does not claim otherwise.

Objection	Reply	Residual
Strawson against Russell: Russell's view is logically cleaner and handles empty descriptions without a separate presupposition mechanism.	ANALYSIS: They partly answer different questions - logical regimentation against ordinary use.	Strawson's original gap treatment is influential, but later theories also model presupposition failure as falsity or through other semantic and pragmatic mechanisms.
Descriptive metaphysics is circular or conservative: it protects the scheme used to state its own conditions.	Strawson accepts an internal task: radical revision and scepticism must begin within some scheme.	Description alone cannot prove the scheme uniquely correct or unrevisable.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: Strawson's positive doctrines put sustained pressure on empiricist starting points without taking over Quine's printed limb. **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959, Part I) rules out sense-data as basic particulars because they are private, momentary and non-spatial; chapter 3 shows that the no-ownership theorist must speak of "the experiences had by this body"; and "On Referring" (1950) replaces Russell's asserted existence-condition with a presupposition carried by a speaker's use. **Analysis:** the same four-step form runs through all three - take an undisputed fact about our thought, ask its conditions, show the empiricist's materials cannot meet them, and conclude that something else is conceptually basic - which is why the doctrines are one argument applied to reference, to the self and to assertion. **Qualification:** these are connections rather than a reassignment of the critique of empiricism, and since the metaphysics is descriptive, an empiricist may accept the entire analysis as conceptual geography while denying that it settles what exists.

EXAM LINK

- **2021 Q3(b)** and **2023 Q4(a)** - the criticism ledger supplies the "critically discuss" and the assessment paragraph.
- **A Russell question in Topic 06** may invite "On Referring" from the other side; here it stays bounded, and the fencing sentence must be written.
- ANALYSIS: None of the nine routed parts asks for "On Referring", induction or the Kant interpretation. They are enrichment.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
"On Referring" is part of the syllabus"	It is not. Fence it in one sentence, then use it as illustration of method.
Attributing all presupposition theory to the 1950 paper	Later theories divide between gap, falsity and pragmatic treatments.
Turning the five connections into a reassignment of the printed limb	The critique of empiricism is Quine's. These are connections.
Reporting objections to Strawson without replies	Every row of the ledger has a reply and a residual.
Importing "Freedom and Resentment"	Bounded and cross-owned; not a printed limb and not PYQ-owned. One clause at most.

REVISION NOTES

- **Russell 1905** (asserted, false) against **Strawson 1950** (presupposed, no true-or-false assertion made).
- **Truth-value caution:** the unsuccessful **use**, not a meaningless sentence-type.
- Five connections: sense-data · bundle self / no-ownership · reconstruction detached from use · induction · objectivity from private data.
- Four-step transcendental form; conclusion **conceptual**, not causal.
- Two honest qualifications: **1956** blocks the united front; **descriptive** limits the reach.
- Five-row criticism ledger with replies and residuals.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

BOUNDED EDGE -> fence it, then use it

- > 'On Referring' 1950: PRESUPPOSED, not ASSERTED; speakers refer, on occasions
- > caution: the unsuccessful USE, not a meaningless sentence-type
- > FIVE CONNECTIONS: sense-data | bundle self | reconstruction | induction | objectivity from private data
- > ONE FORM: undisputed fact -> conditions -> empiricist materials fail -> something else is CONCEPTUALLY basic
- > TWO QUALIFICATIONS: 1956 blocks the 'united front'; descriptive limits reach
- > LEDGER: five objections, five replies, five residuals.

SESSION 18 - SYNTHESIS: QUINE AGAINST STRAWSON, THE DIRECTIVE DECODER, THE GRADED VERDICT BANK AND THE PROVENANCE RAIL

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The last session puts the two halves side by side, tells you exactly what each command word in a question obliges you to do, gives you a closing verdict for every sub-topic at three mark-levels, and lists the dates and attributions that this clause tests more heavily than any other in Paper I.

Technical definition: The **comparison grid** ranges Quine and Strawson against Logical Positivism, Descartes and the later Wittgenstein on six axes; the **direct confrontation** records the 1956 exchange and Quine's implicit reply; the **directive decoder** converts each command word into a structural obligation; the **graded verdict bank** supplies executable closing positions at 10, 15 and 20 marks; and the **provenance rail** fixes dating, attribution and formula-accuracy.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Read together, Quine and Strawson pressure both empiricist confirmation atomism and sense-datum reconstruction **without becoming one school** - and the exact statement of that relation is itself an answer-grabbing line.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **six axes** · **direct confrontation** · **directive decoder** · **graded verdict** · **provenance rail**
- **"the printed critique belongs directly to Quine"** · **"Strawson's printed contribution is positive and transcendental in form"**

Plain-language visual - the one legitimate joint sentence

THE ONLY SENTENCE THAT MAY TREAT THEM AS A PAIR:

'The printed critique belongs directly to Quine: holism replaces sentence-by-sentence reduction. Strawson's printed contribution is positive and transcendental in form: public identification requires basic particulars, and the person is conceptually primitive. Read together, they pressure both empiricist confirmation atomism and sense-datum reconstruction WITHOUT BECOMING ONE SCHOOL.'

Memorise it. It opens or closes any question that names both.

One sentence that credits each man with his own result and refuses the false unity.

VISUAL: VISUAL - the comparison grid and the direct confrontation

SIX AXES ACROSS FIVE POSITIONS

AXIS	QUINE	STRAWSON	LOGICAL POSITIVISM	DESCARTES	LATER WITTGENSTEIN
ANALYTIC / SYNTHETIC	REJECTS the distinction	RETAINS it cautiously (defends it with Grice, 1956)	CENTRAL and unquestioned	--	rules of grammar, not a sharp dichotomy
MEANING	holistic, indeterminate behavioural	ordinary conceptual scheme; context- dependent use	verification -conditions	clear and distinct ideas	use in a form of life
METAPHYSICS	NATURALISED; no special philosophical method	DESCRIPTIVE METAPHYSICS REVIVED	MEANINGLESS	foundation- al enterprise	dissolved via therapy
MIND-BODY	naturalist; no special status for the mental	PERSON = PRIMITIVE (M + P predicates)	--	two substances (dualism)	inner grounded in public criteria
METHOD	science- continuous; no first philosophy	connective analysis of our scheme	logical analysis + verification	methodic doubt	description of language- games
REFERENCE	'to be = to be the value of a bound variable'	referring is what SPEAKERS do (context)	--	ideas represent objects	words refer only within a game

QUINE AGAINST STRAWSON - THE DIRECT CONFRONTATION

GRICE AND STRAWSON, 'In Defence of a Dogma' (1956): the analytic/synthetic distinction is ORDINARILY INTELLIGIBLE - we can classify cases pre-theoretically - even if no reductive analysis of 'analytic' is available. Quine sets the bar too high, demanding a non-circular DEFINITION when what we have is a useful DISTINCTION.

QUINE'S IMPLICIT REPLY: ordinary intelligibility is not theoretical legitimacy. The distinction's philosophical WORK collapses without a principled ground.

THE DISPUTE IS ABOUT STANDARDS OF EXPLICATION. Say so, and take a graded side.

Caption: six axes, five positions and the one documented exchange between the two printed thinkers. The grid is also the fence: every column that is not Quine's or Strawson's belongs to another clause.

NUMBERED TEACHING

1. ANALYSIS: **Use the grid as a fence, not as content.** The Logical Positivism, Descartes and Wittgenstein columns exist to remind you what **not** to expound here. Only demand-specific contrasts belong.
2. FACT: **The directive decoder** - what each command word obliges you to *do* on this clause:

Directive	What it demands	Structural obligation	Fatal error
Critique of empiricism - discuss	Quine's printed burden, with Strawson only as a bounded connective contrast	Quine: two dogmas, holism, empiricism retained; then one sentence that Strawson's positive framework also pressures sense-datum reconstruction	Turning the item into one joint anti-empiricist doctrine
Comment on the quotation (2025 Q4(b))	the conditional clause is the doctrine	Explain via Duhem-Quine: <i>modus tollens</i> condemns only the conjunction, so the choice of what to revise is not evidential. Then the Neptune/Vulcan pair	Quoting the first half and calling it relativism

Directive	What it demands	Structural obligation	Fatal error
Examine the analytic/synthetic distinction (2018, 2019, 2021, 2024)	the failed explications as a chain , then the holistic alternative	Analytic -> meaning -> synonymy -> definition -> interchangeability <i>salva veritate</i> ; then the limitation of semantical rules, Grice-Strawson's reply and Quine's rejoinder	Inferring from one missing definition that no sentence can ever be called analytic
Explain the theory of basic particulars (2021 Q3(b))	show why they are basic - an argument from identification	Re-identification requires a single spatio-temporal framework; sense-data are private, momentary and non-spatial; therefore material bodies	Listing what a basic particular is
Discuss the theory of persons (2023 Q4(a), 2021 Q3(b))	the primitiveness argument, against two rivals	M-predicates and P-predicates; the dual-ascription argument; then Cartesian dualism and the no-ownership theory	Refuting only dualism
Distinguish descriptive from revisionary metaphysics	Strawson's own examples and the point of the distinction	Descriptive: Aristotle, Kant. Revisionary: Descartes, Leibniz, Berkeley. Point: revisionary metaphysics is in the service of descriptive	Two definitions with no examples
Assess indeterminacy of translation	the gavagai* construction, then the behaviourist premise	Rival manuals; the identity-predicate move; then Chomsky's underdetermination objection - and take a side	Asserting "meanings are indeterminate"
Evaluate the role of spatio-temporal thinking (2020 Q3(b))	the function of the framework, tested by removing it	Objective identification -> re-identification -> unified framework -> the auditory-world analogue -> the internal/transcendental limitation	Describing space and time instead of arguing from identification
Do you agree? / Substantiate / Critically	a ruling , then its ground	State the verdict in the first two lines and spend the body earning it; close with the graded verdict from the bank below	Balanced summary with no ruling

3. FACT: The graded verdict bank - executable closing positions:

Sub-topic	10-mark verdict	15-mark verdict	20-mark verdict
Analytic/synthetic	Quine does not show that familiar classifications are unintelligible; he argues that available explications cannot ground the sharp foundational boundary empiricism required.	...Grice and Strawson preserve ordinary contrast-cases but may not supply the theoretical account Quine demands.	The dispute concerns standards of explication . Quine strongly pressures the distinction's foundational use while leaving room for more modest semantic or ordinary classifications.
Holism / Duhem-Quine	Statements face experience as a corporate body, so no single statement is individually confirmable - which by itself destroys the second dogma.	...Duhem confined the thesis to physics and exempted logic and mathematics; Quine's extension to <i>all</i> knowledge is the controversial step, and it is what makes the analytic/synthetic collapse follow.	Holism is right about confirmation and overstated about revisability . Quine's own later work concedes as much: <i>Philosophy of Logic</i> (1970) invokes the maxim of minimum mutilation and argues that to deny a law of logic is to change the subject. The defensible position is Duhem's thesis with Quine's motivation - testing is holistic, choice of revision is pragmatic, and logic is revisable in a sense so attenuated that nothing much follows from it.

Sub-topic	10-mark verdict	15-mark verdict	20-mark verdict
Radical translation / gavagai*	There is no fact of the matter about reference, because no behavioural evidence can fix the apparatus of individuation.	...The argument's force is exactly proportional to its behaviourist premise about evidence, and Quine retains a verificationist criterion of <i>factuality</i> while rejecting verificationism about <i>meaning</i> .	Chomsky's objection identifies the pressure point: if underdetermination does not make physics factless, why does it make translation factless? Quine's asymmetry is a naturalist thesis , not a result of the argument , so the argument establishes its conclusion only for those already persuaded of the naturalism. What survives independently is the negative result that use alone does not fix reference - a result the later Wittgenstein reaches by a wholly different route.
Ontological commitment	"To be is to be the value of a bound variable" audits the commitments of a regimented theory rather than counting its nouns.	...The criterion presupposes choices of theory and regimentation; it does not make those choices automatically.	Ontological relativity adds a separate framework-dependence thesis. Quine and Carnap overlap in rejecting theory-free ontology but differ over analyticity and the status of framework choice.
Basic particulars	Material bodies are basic because identification and re-identification demand a single spatio-temporal framework that private, momentary sense-data cannot provide.	...The argument is transcendental in form - from an undisputed fact about reference to its necessary conditions - which is why <i>Individuals</i> and <i>The Bounds of Sense</i> are one project.	The conclusion is about our conceptual scheme , not about mind-independent reality, and Strawson says so: his metaphysics is descriptive. An empiricist may therefore accept the whole argument as conceptual geography while denying that it settles ontology. Whether descriptive metaphysics can be more than a very good map of how we think is the standing question about Strawson's programme, and the honest answer is that he never claimed more.
Persons	"Person" is a primitive concept: it is not compounded from a mind and a body, because both dualism and the no-ownership theory presuppose it.	...The decisive argument is that P-predicates must be ascribable to others on behavioural grounds and to oneself not on those grounds; a concept with that dual condition cannot be constructed from either half.	Strawson defeats Cartesianism more economically than any argument from interaction: he does not ask how mind and body can interact but shows that the question presupposes a prior unity that neither term can supply. The cost is that "primitive" marks the end of analysis rather than an explanation - a legitimate result for descriptive metaphysics and an unsatisfying one for anybody who wanted the mind-body problem solved rather than dissolved.
Strawson against Russell on referring	On Strawson's account, existence is presupposed by the use; when it fails, the attempted assertion lacks an ordinary true/false evaluation.	...This is a claim about ordinary use, not a knock-down refutation of Russellian logical regimentation.	The approaches partly answer different questions. Later presupposition theories also divide between gap, falsity and pragmatic treatments, so Strawson's 1950 proposal must not stand for all of them.

4. **FACT: The provenance rail** - dating, attribution and formula-accuracy, which this clause tests directly:

Item	Correct provenance	Caution
"Two Dogmas of Empiricism"	<i>The Philosophical Review</i> , January 1951 ; revised in <i>From a Logical Point of View</i> (1953)	ANALYSIS: The web-of-belief / field-of-force passage is Section 6 , "Empiricism without the Dogmas" . Cite the section.

Item	Correct provenance	Caution
"Any statement can be held true come what may..."	"Two Dogmas", Section 6	FACT: Safe verbatim. WRONG: Do not truncate: the conditional clause is the doctrine.
"To be is to be the value of a bound variable"	standard slogan for the criterion developed in " On What There Is " (<i>Review of Metaphysics</i> , 1948)	ANALYSIS: Treat as a canonical summary rather than a guaranteed verbatim sentence; it is not from "Two Dogmas".
<i>Word and Object</i>	1960	Radical translation, <i>gavagai</i> , stimulus meaning, analytical hypotheses - ch. 2 . FACT: The epigraph is Neurath's boat .
"Ontological Relativity"	Dewey Lectures, 1968; in <i>Ontological Relativity and Other Essays</i> (1969) - the same volume as " Epistemology Naturalized "	ANALYSIS: Do not date naturalised epistemology to 1951.
Quantum logic	FACT: Birkhoff and von Neumann , "The Logic of Quantum Mechanics", <i>Annals of Mathematics</i> , 1936 - the formal proposal. FACT: Putnam , "Is Logic Empirical?", 1968 - the claim that logic is empirically revisable.	WRONG: Never write "Putnam/Birkhoff" as a joint proposal, and never merge the dates. CAUTION: Add that Putnam later abandoned the position, and that <i>Philosophy of Logic</i> (1970) resists revision via "change of logic, change of subject" and the maxim of minimum mutilation .
Duhem	<i>La Theorie physique: son objet, sa structure</i> (1906); Eng. <i>The Aim and Structure of Physical Theory</i> , tr. Wiener, 1954	ANALYSIS: Duhem restricted the thesis to physics and exempted logic and mathematics. "Duhem-Quine thesis" is later shorthand for two non-identical claims - say so.
Popper	<i>Logik der Forschung</i> (1934); Eng. 1959	ANALYSIS: Popper accepts the logical point and answers it methodologically; do not present him as denying Duhem-Quine.
<i>Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics</i>	1959	Basic particulars Part I ; persons ch. 3 ; the phrase is in the subtitle - quote the subtitle, it is exact.
"On Referring"	<i>Mind</i> , 1950	ANALYSIS: Predates <i>Individuals</i> by nine years; a precursor, not an application of descriptive metaphysics.
Grice and Strawson, "In Defence of a Dogma"	<i>The Philosophical Review</i> , 1956	ANALYSIS: Co-authored with H. P. Grice - attributing it to Strawson alone is a standard slip. Note the spelling: <i>Defence</i> .
<i>The Bounds of Sense</i>	1966	The " non-sequitur of numbing grossness " charge against Kant's Second Analogy is here. FACT: Safe verbatim; Strawson's own phrase.
<i>Introduction to Logical Theory</i>	1952	The dissolution of the problem of induction, ch. 9 .
Chomsky's objection	"Quine's Empirical Assumptions", in <i>Words and Objections</i> (1969)	FACT: Attribute the underdetermination objection to Chomsky , not to "critics".
Davidson	"Radical Interpretation " (1973)	ANALYSIS: Interpretation , not translation - the change of word marks the change of doctrine.

5. WRONG: **Never write**: that Quine "rejected empiricism" (he calls his own position empiricism without the dogmas); that Strawson "defended empiricism" (he defends a **distinction against Quine**, which is not the same thing); that Duhem and Quine hold the same thesis; or that Quine denied the existence of meaning *tout court*

rather than of **meanings as determinate entities**.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification

Claim: The two halves of the clause converge in target and diverge in doctrine. **Evidence:** Quine's holism replaces sentence-by-sentence reduction, while Strawson's *Individuals* (1959) argues that public identification requires basic particulars and that the person is conceptually primitive; and Grice and Strawson's "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956) shows that the two men disagree about the very distinction the clause's first limb concerns. **Analysis:** read together they pressure both empiricist confirmation atomism and sense-datum reconstruction, so the pairing is a problem-field in which empiricism fails twice - about how theories meet evidence and about how reference is possible at all.

Qualification: they do not thereby become one school, and any answer that treats them as co-authors of a single anti-empiricist doctrine has misdescribed the only documented exchange between them.

EXAM LINK

- Every one of the nine routed parts closes better with a verdict drawn from the bank than with a summary.
- The directive decoder converts the stem's command word into a structure before a single line is written - the single highest-value habit on this clause.

UPSC TRAPS

Trap	Correction
Expounding Logical Positivism, Descartes or Wittgenstein from the grid	The grid is a fence. Use only demand-specific contrasts.
Ending with a summary rather than a ruling	Directives such as "critically", "evaluate" and "do you agree" require a graded verdict .
Getting a date or an attribution wrong	The provenance rail is short and the paper tests it. Learn it as a list.
Writing "the Quine-Strawson front"	Use the one legitimate joint sentence instead.

REVISION NOTES

- Six axes, five positions; the non-owned columns are fences.
- **1956** confrontation; the dispute is about **standards of explication**.
- Nine directive rows; each names the fatal error.
- Seven verdict rows at three mark-levels.
- Sixteen provenance rows; four "never write" items.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW

DECIDE THE OWNER -> DECODE THE DIRECTIVE -> RUN THE SPINE -> CLOSE WITH A VERDICT

- > GRID: six axes; other columns are FENCES
- > CONFRONTATION: Grice and Strawson 1956 vs Quine; standards of EXPLICATION
- > DECODER: nine directives, nine fatal errors
- > VERDICT BANK: seven sub-topics at 10 / 15 / 20 marks
- > PROVENANCE: 1906 · 1948 · 1950 · 1951 · 1953 · 1956 · 1959 · 1960 · 1966
· 1968/69 · 1970 · 1936 vs 1968 · Duhem is not Quine
- > NEVER: 'Quine rejected empiricism' | 'Strawson defended empiricism'
| 'Putnam/Birkhoff' | 'Quine denied meaning tout court'.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed **independently**, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated, and no cycle such as ABCD - or its reverse - can be used to guess. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - *Critique of Empiricism; Theory of Basic Particulars and Persons* - together with the two-project division and the fence around it, the two classes of analytic truth, each of the three failed explications with its own failure, the exact conclusion Quine draws and the exact conclusion he does not, both forms of reductionism and the identification of the two dogmas at root, the unit of empirical significance, the field-of-force structure with its three revision options, both canonical sentences with their qualifiers, the constraints that block arbitrary revision, the *modus tollens* argument, the scope-and-exemption contrast between Duhem and Quine, the Neptune/Vulcan pair, descriptive against revisionary metaphysics with Strawson's own examples, the question basic particulars answer and the five-step argument that answers it, the three defects of sense-data, the purely auditory world and the analogue of space, the two predicate-classes, the dual character of P-predicates, what "primitive" does and does not mean, and the self-refutation of the no-ownership theory. The eight remedial drills attack the errors that cost marks every year on this clause: the provenance of the bound-variable slogan, the two-author two-date structure of the quantum-logic episode, Quine's own later retreat, the "Quine rejects empiricism" misreading, the identity-predicate move in *gavagai*, the four-doctrine taxonomy, the dating of naturalized epistemology, and the ownership fence around Topics 03, 04, 06, 07 and 08.

MCQ 1. How the printed clause divides between its two thinkers

The syllabus prints one heading: *Quine and Strawson : Critique of Empiricism; Theory of Basic Particulars and Persons*. Which statement describes the division of labour that the 2018-2025 papers actually respect?

- A. Both limbs are shared, which is why the two philosophers are printed together rather than separately.
- B. Strawson supplies the critique of empiricism and Quine supplies the theory of basic particulars and persons.
- C. Quine supplies the critique of empiricism and Strawson supplies the theory of basic particulars and persons.
- D. Quine supplies both limbs, and Strawson appears only as a commentator on Quine's conclusions.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: no routed part between 2018 and 2025 asks for a joint doctrine, and the two men publicly disagree about the analytic/synthetic distinction.
- **B:** Incorrect: it reverses the ownership. The two dogmas belong to Quine; *Individuals* belongs to Strawson.
- **C:** Correct: five parts name Quine's material and four name Strawson's, and the division matches the printed limbs exactly.
- **D:** Incorrect: Strawson's basic particulars and persons are printed doctrine in their own right, not commentary.

Examiner trap 1: Writing "the Quine-Strawson critique of empiricism" as though it named one doctrine ignores the only documented exchange between them, which is a disagreement.

MCQ 2. What Quine actually concludes about analyticity

Which statement gives the conclusion of the attack on the first dogma with the precision the paper rewards?

- A. Every sentence traditionally classified as analytic turns out on inspection to be false.
- B. The available explications fail to secure the sharp, non-question-begging boundary that logical empiricism required.
- C. The word "analytic" has no use at all in any language, whether natural or artificially constructed.
- D. Analyticity can be given a precise definition, but only for constructed artificial languages and never for ordinary spoken ones.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Quine never claims that "All bachelors are unmarried" is false; he attacks the explication, not the sentence.
- **B:** Correct: the target is the **foundational** boundary, and the argument is that each candidate explication presupposes a member of the same family.
- **C:** Incorrect: that overstates the result, and Quine concedes that speakers classify cases; his point is that classification is not a principled ground.
- **D:** Incorrect: Carnap's semantical rules do classify sentences in a stipulated language, but Quine's complaint is that this leaves the general notion unexplained.

Examiner trap 2: Inferring from one missing definition that no sentence can ever be called analytic converts a careful negative result into an indefensible claim that the objectors immediately refute.

MCQ 3. The two classes into which analytic truths were said to fall

On the standard account Quine examines, analytic statements fall into two classes. Which pairing is correct?

- A. Truths of arithmetic, and truths established by controlled scientific experiment.
- B. Truths known before experience, and truths known only after sufficient experience.
- C. Truths asserted by explicit definition, and truths asserted by deliberate stipulation in a language manual.
- D. Logical truths, and truths convertible into logical truths by substituting synonyms for synonyms.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: experimental truths are the paradigm of the synthetic; the division concerns kinds of analyticity, not arithmetic against experiment.
- **B:** Incorrect: that is the a priori/a posteriori distinction, which is a further casualty of holism rather than the classification under test.
- **C:** Incorrect: definition and stipulation are candidate **explanations** of the second class, not the classes themselves.
- **D:** Correct: "No unmarried man is married" is logically true; "No bachelor is married" becomes so once synonyms are substituted - and it is the second class that needs synonymy.

Examiner trap 3: Starting the answer at "synonymy is circular" without first dividing the analytic truths into the two classes loses the step that shows *why* synonymy is needed at all.

MCQ 4. Why explaining synonymy by definition fails

Quine rejects the appeal to definition as an account of synonymy. What is his reason?

- A. Except in frankly stipulative cases, a definition reports a synonymy that already obtained in the language.
- B. Definitions are always circular in form, since the definiens repeats the definiendum in different words.
- C. Dictionaries disagree with one another, so no definition can command the assent of all speakers.
- D. Definitions belong to lexicography rather than to philosophy and therefore cannot settle logical questions.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the lexicographer is an empirical scientist recording usage; the definition presupposes the very relation it was called in to explain.
- **B:** Incorrect: definitions are not circular in form; the circularity is in the **explanatory order**, not in the sentence.
- **C:** Incorrect: Quine's argument does not rest on disagreement between dictionaries, and empirical variation would not settle the conceptual point.
- **D:** Incorrect: this dismisses definitions by discipline rather than by argument, and Quine grants that stipulative definitions do create synonymy.

Examiner trap 4: Saying merely that "definitions are circular" misstates the objection; the point is that a definition **records** an antecedent synonymy rather than manufacturing one.

MCQ 5. Why interchangeability *salva veritate* fails

Quine tests the proposal that two terms are synonymous when they are interchangeable *salva veritate*. What does he find?

- A. The test is untestable, since no speaker can survey every context in which two terms might occur.
- B. The test presupposes a prior list of analytic sentences drawn up in advance, and therefore cannot be applied to any ordinary spoken language.
- C. The test succeeds for natural kinds but fails for abstract terms such as "number" and "proposition".
- D. In an extensional language it over-generates, and repairing it by requiring interchange within necessity-contexts presupposes analyticity.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the objection is not practical difficulty but the logical structure of the test and of its proposed repair.
- **B:** Incorrect: the test does not presuppose a list; the presupposition Quine identifies is the intelligibility of **necessity**.
- **C:** Incorrect: the standard counter-case, "creature with a heart" and "creature with a kidney", uses ordinary biological terms rather than abstract ones.
- **D:** Correct: coextensive but non-synonymous terms interchange freely in extensional contexts, and the necessity-operator repair returns to the notion under examination.

Examiner trap 5: Omitting the "creature with a heart / creature with a kidney" illustration leaves the over-generation charge asserted rather than shown, and the illustration costs a single clause.

MCQ 6. What Carnap's semantical rules do and do not deliver

Why does Quine hold that semantical rules for an artificial language L do not explain analyticity?

- A. Carnap's rules are inconsistent, so no sentence can be shown to be analytic-in-L by applying them.
- B. They classify sentences as analytic-in-L, but the general notion of a semantical rule is no clearer than analyticity itself.
- C. Artificial languages cannot be learned by ordinary speakers and so cannot fix meanings for anyone.
- D. The rules apply only to the logical constants of the language, leaving every non-logical vocabulary item entirely unaccounted for.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Quine does not allege inconsistency; he allows that the rules do classify sentences within a stipulated language.
- **B:** Correct: we learn the membership of a list without learning what membership consists in, so the general explanatory notion is untouched.
- **C:** Incorrect: learnability is not the issue, and Quine himself favours regimentation into artificial notation for other purposes.
- **D:** Incorrect: the semantical rules are not restricted to logical constants; the complaint concerns the explanatory status of the device.

Examiner trap 6: Treating "analytic-in-L" as a successful definition of "analytic" concedes the very generality Quine denies, and it is the step Carnap's defenders must argue for rather than assume.

MCQ 7. What the second dogma asserts, and why it bears its name

Which statement identifies reductionism as Quine describes it?

- A. It is the doctrine that all sciences will eventually be reduced to physics and its vocabulary.
- B. It is the doctrine that mental states are nothing over and above states of the physical body.
- C. It is the doctrine that each meaningful statement is individually confirmable by, or translatable into, a range of sense-experience.
- D. It is the doctrine that theoretical terms must always be eliminated in favour of purely observational terms wherever this is possible.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the unity-of-science thesis is a different doctrine and is not what "Two Dogmas" attacks.
- **B:** Incorrect: that is a thesis in philosophy of mind, unrelated to the confirmation-theoretic dogma under examination.
- **C:** Correct: the radical form demands term-by-term translation into experience and the attenuated form assigns each statement its own confirming experiences; the label names the reduction of sentence-meaning to observation sentences.
- **D:** Incorrect: elimination of theoretical terms is one positivist programme among others, and it is not the assumption Quine isolates.

Examiner trap 7: Defining reductionism as "reducing everything to matter" answers a question about metaphysics when the examiner asked about confirmation.

MCQ 8. How Quine relates the two dogmas to each other

What is Quine's own verdict on the relation between the two dogmas?

- A. They are at root identical, since the first requires the sentence-sized confirmation the second supplies.
- B. They are independent assumptions that happen to have been held together by the same philosophers.
- C. The first dogma is a special case of the second, applying only to the sentences of mathematics and formal logic.
- D. The second dogma follows deductively from the first, so refuting the first is sufficient by itself.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: statements "confirmed come what may" need a contrast class of statements individually confirmed, and the second dogma supplies exactly that picture.
- **B:** Incorrect: reporting them as independent items on a list loses the architecture of the paper and the line examiners look for.
- **C:** Incorrect: the first dogma is not restricted to mathematics and logic, and it is not presented as a special case of the second.
- **D:** Incorrect: the dependence runs the other way round in Quine's exposition, and neither is derived from the other by deduction.

Examiner trap 8: Presenting the two dogmas as two unconnected criticisms turns an argument with a structure into a list, which is the difference between the 2024 answer that scores and the one that does not.

MCQ 9. The unit of empirical significance

On Quine's holistic account, what is the unit of empirical significance?

- A. The individual observation sentence, since only observation sentences make direct contact with experience.
- B. The whole of science, since statements face the tribunal of sense experience only as a corporate body.
- C. The single theory under test, together with the instruments used to test it on that occasion.
- D. The individual term, provided it can be given an ostensive definition by a competent speaker.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: observation sentences lie at the periphery, but they are not the unit; the whole system is what meets experience.
- **B:** Correct: this is Quine's formulation, and the corporate-body sentence is the pivot of the paper.
- **C:** Incorrect: the Duhem-Quine point extends beyond the local theory-plus-instrument package to the total system.
- **D:** Incorrect: the term was the unit of the programme that had already failed before "Two Dogmas" was written.

Examiner trap 9: Naming the sentence rather than the whole of science restates the dogma being removed and quietly reverses the doctrine.

MCQ 10. The structure of the web and the options it leaves open

When experience conflicts with a prediction, which set of responses does the web model make available?

- A. Revise a peripheral belief, or abandon the observation entirely, but never touch the interior of the system.
- B. Revise the interior first, since the interior contains the theoretical statements most likely to be responsible for the error.
- C. Revise a peripheral belief, revise a deep interior statement, or plead hallucination and revise the observation statement.
- D. Suspend judgement until further observations settle which particular statement is at fault in the system.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the interior is explicitly revisable - that is what "no statement is immune to revision" asserts.
- **B:** Incorrect: interior statements are the **least** likely to be revised in practice, being the most entrenched.
- **C:** Correct: three options, of which the third is what makes "any statement can be held true come what may" literally true.
- **D:** Incorrect: suspension is not the doctrine; further observation does not identify the guilty statement, since it too meets the system as a whole.

Examiner trap 10: Omitting the option of pleading hallucination removes the very move that guarantees the famous sentence, and the sentence then looks like rhetoric rather than a theorem.

MCQ 11. The exact content of the sentence tested in 2025

The 2025 paper quotes: "We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system, in the face of whatever experience, just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere." What carries the doctrine?

- A. The opening clause, which asserts that truth is whatever the total system chooses to affirm.
- B. The final conditional clause, which names the cost that disciplines every such affirmation.
- C. The reference to "our total system", which shows that truth is relative to a community's practice.
- D. The phrase "in the face of whatever experience", which shows that experience is evidentially inert.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: reading the opening clause alone yields relativism, which the qualifier expressly excludes.
- **B:** Correct: the adjustments elsewhere are the price, and the price is what makes the claim a thesis about holistic confirmation rather than about licence.
- **C:** Incorrect: the phrase locates the claim in a system, but it is the conditional, not the possessive, that carries the doctrine.
- **D:** Incorrect: experience is not inert on Quine's account; it convicts the system and forces revision somewhere.

Examiner trap 11: Quoting the first half of the sentence and calling it relativism is the single commonest way of failing 2025 Q4(b).

MCQ 12. What prevents holism from licensing arbitrary revision

Which combination correctly identifies the constraints Quine places on the choice of revision?

- A. Predictive success, conservatism, simplicity, fecundity and the maxim of minimum mutilation.
- B. The verification principle, together with a rule forbidding the revision of logic under any circumstances.
- C. The analytic/synthetic distinction, retained in an attenuated form for statements of mathematics.
- D. A rule that peripheral statements must always be surrendered before interior statements are touched.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: these are the pragmatic virtues of "Two Dogmas" together with the later maxim of *Philosophy of Logic* (1970).
- **B:** Incorrect: the verification principle is a casualty of the argument, and no absolute prohibition on revising logic is available to Quine.
- **C:** Incorrect: the distinction is what the paper removes; entrenchment replaces it and is not an attenuated version of it.
- **D:** Incorrect: there is no such rule; the whole point is that logic alone does not dictate where revision occurs.

Examiner trap 12: Answering "critically examine" on holism without naming a single constraint leaves the "anything goes" objection unanswered and the verdict unearned.

MCQ 13. What modus tollens delivers in the Duhem-Quine argument

A hypothesis H, with auxiliaries A, entails observation O. Experiment yields not-O. What follows?

- A. H is false, since the auxiliaries were accepted before the test and are therefore not in question.
- B. Not-(H and A): either H is false or some element of A is false, and logic does not say which.
- C. Both H and A are false, since a conjunction whose consequence fails has no true conjuncts.
- D. Nothing at all follows, because an observation report can always be dismissed as unreliable.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: prior acceptance confers no immunity; the Uranus case shows an auxiliary being surrendered instead of the hypothesis.
- **B:** Correct: the negation of a conjunction leaves the distribution of blame open, and that openness is the thesis.
- **C:** Incorrect: the negation of a conjunction does not entail the falsity of each conjunct; this is a straightforward logical error.
- **D:** Incorrect: pleading hallucination is one option among three, not a demonstration that nothing follows.

Examiner trap 13: Asserting that "a failed test refutes the hypothesis" restates precisely the assumption the thesis was constructed to remove.

MCQ 14. How Duhem's thesis differs from Quine's

Which contrast between Duhem and Quine is accurate?

- A. Duhem extended the thesis to all knowledge, while Quine restricted it to theoretical physics alone.
- B. Duhem and Quine hold the same thesis, so the compound label records nothing more than joint discovery.
- C. Duhem applied the thesis to logic and mathematics as well as to physics, while Quine deliberately exempted both from revision.
- D. Duhem restricted it to physics and exempted logic and mathematics; Quine extended it to all knowledge and exempted nothing.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it reverses both scopes; Duhem is the narrower of the two.
- **B:** Incorrect: the shared label is later shorthand for two non-identical claims, and saying so is itself a mark.
- **C:** Incorrect: Duhem does not put logic and mathematics at risk, and Quine exempts nothing.
- **D:** Correct: scope and exemptions are precisely where the two claims part, and Quine's extension is the controversial step.

Examiner trap 14: Writing "the Duhem-Quine thesis" without distinguishing its two halves throws away the most examinable precision available on this sub-topic.

MCQ 15. What the Neptune and Vulcan cases jointly demonstrate

Why does a strong answer deploy Neptune and "Vulcan" together rather than Neptune alone?

- A. Because Neptune was discovered by calculation while Vulcan was discovered by direct observation.
- B. Because both episodes show that Newtonian mechanics survives every anomaly that is put to it.
- C. Because the same strategy of revising an auxiliary was correct for Uranus and wrong for Mercury, so no rule fixes the choice in advance.
- D. Because Le Verrier's method of positing an unseen extra planet was later shown to be invalid, which is the reason Vulcan was never found.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: "Vulcan" was never discovered at all, and the contrast is about which revision was correct, not about method of discovery.
- **B:** Incorrect: Newtonian mechanics did **not** survive the Mercury anomaly; general relativity replaced it in 1915.
- **C:** Correct: identical logical situations, opposite correct responses, and no advance rule - which is the thesis, demonstrated historically.
- **D:** Incorrect: the method that found Neptune in 1846 was sound; what differed was which conjunct actually needed revision.

Examiner trap 15: Citing Neptune alone makes holism look like a recipe for saving theories, when the paired case shows it is a claim about the absence of any recipe.

MCQ 16. Descriptive and revisionary metaphysics, with Strawson's own examples

Which statement gives Strawson's distinction together with the examples he himself uses?

- A. Descriptive metaphysics reconstructs the world out of private sense-data (Russell, Carnap); revisionary metaphysics simply describes our ordinary usage (Austin, Ryle).
- B. Descriptive metaphysics is empirical psychology (Hume, Mill); revisionary metaphysics is formal logic (Frege, Russell).
- C. Descriptive metaphysics is done by scientists and revisionary metaphysics by philosophers, which is why the two rarely meet.
- D. Descriptive metaphysics describes the actual structure of our thought (Aristotle, Kant); revisionary metaphysics proposes a better one (Descartes, Leibniz, Berkeley).

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: reconstruction from sense-data is the revisionary programme Strawson opposes, and the names are misassigned.
- **B:** Incorrect: descriptive metaphysics is expressly **not** empirical psychology; treating it so misreads its transcendental form.
- **C:** Incorrect: the distinction is between two philosophical projects, not between disciplines.
- **D:** Correct: these are Strawson's own affinities and contrasts, and revisionary metaphysics is at its best in the service of the descriptive.

Examiner trap 16: Giving two definitions with no examples is exactly the fatal error the directive decoder records for this sub-topic.

MCQ 17. The question that "basic particulars" answers

What question is Strawson's theory of basic particulars designed to answer?

- A. Which particulars are such that the possibility of identification and reference in general depends on them?
- B. Which particulars are the smallest, and therefore the ultimate constituents of physical reality?
- C. Which particulars can be perceived directly, without inference from any other particular?
- D. Which particulars persist entirely unchanged through time, and therefore possess a genuine substantial identity?

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: basic particulars are basic in the order of identification, so the question is about the conditions of reference.
- **B:** Incorrect: basic particulars are macroscopic bodies and persons, not microphysical simples.
- **C:** Incorrect: direct perceptibility is the empiricist's criterion, and it selects precisely the sense-data Strawson rules out.
- **D:** Incorrect: enduring is necessary for re-identification, but unchanging substantial identity is a different and stronger demand.

Examiner trap 17: Answering "what is a basic particular?" with a list rather than with the identification-question loses the argument the 2021 stem explicitly asks for.

MCQ 18. The argument from identification and re-identification

Which sequence reproduces Strawson's argument for the basic status of material bodies?

- A. Bodies are publicly observable, and whatever is publicly observable must be real; therefore material bodies are the basic constituents of the reality we describe and refer to.
- B. Bodies cause our experiences, causes are prior to effects, therefore bodies are prior to the experiences they cause.
- C. Identification requires re-identification; re-identification requires one unified spatio-temporal framework; enduring public bodies occupy it and anchor identification.
- D. Bodies are named in ordinary language, ordinary language is our best guide to reality, therefore bodies are basic.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the conclusion is about conceptual priority within our scheme, not about what is real.
- **B:** Incorrect: the argument is expressly **not** causal; a causal claim would make it a scientific rather than a conceptual thesis.
- **C:** Correct: three linked conditions, followed by the observation that dependent particulars are identified through their relations to bodies, persons, places and times.
- **D:** Incorrect: appeal to ordinary naming without the identification-condition is the caricature of descriptive metaphysics, not the argument.

Examiner trap 18: Describing the framework as a psychological image built out of bodies converts a transcendental argument into empirical speculation and forfeits the point of the question.

MCQ 19. Why sense-data cannot be the basic particulars

Which set of defects disqualifies sense-data from the basic role, on Strawson's argument?

- A. They are theoretical, unobservable and postulated only to explain the causal origin of perception.
- B. They are private, momentary and non-spatial, so they cannot ground public identification, re-identification or a framework.
- C. They are variable between different observers, and therefore cannot support agreement about the colours and shapes of objects.
- D. They are mind-dependent, and mind-dependent items cannot exist when nobody happens to be perceiving them.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: sense-data were introduced precisely as what is directly observed, not as unobservable posits.
- **B:** Correct: each defect independently disqualifies them, and together they show the failure is structural rather than incidental.
- **C:** Incorrect: inter-observer variation is an epistemological worry; Strawson's objection concerns the conditions of reference.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is Berkeley's problem about continued existence, and it is not the identification-based argument of *Individuals*.

Examiner trap 19: Listing only privacy leaves the empiricist free to propose a longer-lived or spatially ordered datum, so all three defects must be stated.

MCQ 20. What the purely auditory world shows

What conclusion does Strawson draw from the thought-experiment of a world containing only sounds?

- A. Objective reference in such a scheme would require an analogue of space - for instance a continuously available master-sound.
- B. Such a scheme is strictly impossible, which proves that visual and tactile material bodies are necessary in any conceivable scheme.
- C. Such a scheme is entirely unproblematic, which shows that space plays no essential role in objective thought at all.
- D. Sounds are themselves basic particulars, so the auditory world is simply another scheme with different basics.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the experiment isolates the individuating role a framework must perform rather than privileging our sensory organisation.
- **B:** Incorrect: Strawson's discussion does not simply prove the auditory scheme impossible, and reading it so invites the anthropocentrism charge.
- **C:** Incorrect: pitch and succession alone do not yet support robust objective re-identification, which is the experiment's finding.
- **D:** Incorrect: sounds are dependent particulars in our scheme, identified through their relations to bodies, places and times.

Examiner trap 20: Writing "a sound-only world is simply impossible" both misreports the text and hands the examiner the anthropocentrism objection that the passage exists to answer.

MCQ 21. The two classes of predicate ascribed to a person

Which statement correctly describes M-predicates and P-predicates?

- A. M-predicates are ascribed to bodies and P-predicates to minds, so a person is a body joined to a mind.
- B. Both are ascribed to a single subject: M-predicates are also true of mere bodies, P-predicates ascribe states of consciousness.
- C. M-predicates are measurable and P-predicates are not, which is why psychology cannot be a quantitative science.
- D. P-predicates are ascribed first and M-predicates only derivatively, since consciousness is given to us long before the body is known.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: splitting the ascriptions between two subjects restores exactly the dualism the doctrine rejects.
- **B:** Correct: "weighs 70 kg" and "is in pain" are both true of the same thing, and that single subject is the person.
- **C:** Incorrect: measurability is not the criterion; the criterion is whether the predicate is also applicable to a mere body.
- **D:** Incorrect: no priority of that kind is claimed, and the Cartesian ordering it presupposes is what Strawson denies.

Examiner trap 21: Attaching the two predicate-classes to two subjects produces a paraphrase of dualism under Strawson's vocabulary, which the examiner will read as a failure to grasp the thesis.

MCQ 22. The dual character of P-predicates

What feature of P-predicates carries the argument for the primitiveness of the person concept?

- A. They are ascribed to others by analogy with one's own case, which is what explains our ordinary knowledge of other minds.
- B. They are incorrigible when self-ascribed, so first-person reports about them cannot be mistaken.
- C. They are other-ascribed on publicly available criteria yet self-ascribed without observation of one's own behaviour.
- D. They are ascribed only to human beings, which is what distinguishes persons from animals and machines.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Strawson rejects the argument from analogy; other-ascription proceeds on public criteria, not on inference to a hidden mind.
- **B:** Incorrect: incorrigibility is a different and stronger claim, and the argument needs only ascription without observation.
- **C:** Correct: a predicate with that dual condition cannot be built from a pure consciousness or from a pure body, so its subject must already be both.
- **D:** Incorrect: the restriction to human beings is not the argument, and it would make the thesis a classification rather than a conceptual claim.

Examiner trap 22: Dropping "without observation" from the self-ascription condition destroys the asymmetry, and without the asymmetry the conclusion simply does not follow.

MCQ 23. What "primitive" means in "the concept of a person is primitive"

Which reading of "primitive" is Strawson's?

- A. Conceptual priority: the concept cannot be constructed from an independently identifiable body plus an independently identifiable consciousness.
- B. Ontological simplicity: persons are metaphysical simples possessing no parts whatever, no internal structure and no constituent elements of any kind.
- C. Epistemic immediacy: we know persons directly, without inference, in a way we do not know material bodies.
- D. Historical primacy: the concept of a person was acquired by human beings before the concept of a body.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: primitiveness is a claim about the order of concepts within our scheme, not about substances, evidence or history.
- **B:** Incorrect: persons plainly have parts; the thesis concerns the analysis of a concept, not the mereology of an entity.
- **C:** Incorrect: no claim of privileged epistemic access is being made, and Strawson's argument turns on public criteria.
- **D:** Incorrect: developmental or historical order is irrelevant to a claim about logical priority.

Examiner trap 23: Treating "primitive" as the postulation of a third substance turns the anti-Cartesian argument into a version of the Cartesianism it was written to displace.

MCQ 24. How the no-ownership theory refutes itself

On Strawson's analysis, why can the no-ownership theorist not state his own thesis?

- A. Because he must deny that he himself has any experiences, which makes his assertion self-contradictory.
- B. Because experiences are self-intimating, so anyone who has one thereby knows that he owns it.
- C. Because causal dependence on a particular body is an empirical scientific claim, and scientific claims cannot settle conceptual questions.
- D. Because to specify which experiences he means he must say "the experiences that are had by this body", and "had by" is possessive.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the theorist does not deny that experiences occur; he denies that they are owned by a subject.
- **B:** Incorrect: self-intimation is a Cartesian thesis about access, not the argument from the statement of the theory.
- **C:** Incorrect: Strawson does not object to causal dependence as such; he objects that dependence cannot do the individuating work ownership does.
- **D:** Correct: the contingent causal relation cannot single out these experiences, so the personal framework is reintroduced in the very statement of the denial.

Examiner trap 24: Refuting only Cartesian dualism on a persons question leaves the second rival standing, and it is the second rival on which Strawson's chapter turns.

MCQ 25. Remedial drill - where the bound-variable slogan comes from

"To be is to be the value of a bound variable" summarises a criterion developed in which work?

- A. "On What There Is" (*Review of Metaphysics*, 1948).
- B. "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (*The Philosophical Review*, 1951).
- C. *Word and Object* (1960), in the chapter on radical translation.
- D. "Ontological Relativity" (Dewey Lectures, 1968; volume 1969).

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the criterion of ontological commitment is developed there, and the slogan is the standard summary of it.
- **B:** Incorrect: "Two Dogmas" is about analyticity, reductionism and holism; the slogan does not belong to it.
- **C:** Incorrect: *Word and Object* ch. 2 supplies radical translation and *gavagai*, not the commitment criterion.
- **D:** Incorrect: the 1968/69 material states ontological **relativity**, which is a different and later thesis.

Examiner trap 25: Sourcing the slogan to "Two Dogmas" is a datable error that an examiner can check in seconds, and it undermines confidence in every other date in the script.

MCQ 26. Remedial drill - the two halves of the quantum-logic episode

Which attribution is correct?

- A. Putnam and Birkhoff jointly proposed quantum logic in 1936 and defended it again in 1968.
- B. Von Neumann argued in 1968 that the distributive law must be revised on empirical grounds.
- C. Birkhoff and von Neumann proposed a non-distributive lattice in 1936; Putnam argued in 1968 that logic is empirically revisable.
- D. Quine proposed the revision of the distributive law in 1951, and Putnam later defended Quine's proposal against its many critics.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it merges two authors, two dates and two different kinds of claim into one non-existent joint proposal.
- **B:** Incorrect: von Neumann's contribution is the 1936 formalism, not the later philosophical thesis.
- **C:** Correct: a formal proposal in 1936 and a philosophical claim in 1968, which Putnam himself later abandoned.
- **D:** Incorrect: Quine resisted the revision of logic, notably in *Philosophy of Logic* (1970).

Examiner trap 26: Writing "Putnam/Birkhoff" as a joint proposal, or merging the dates, converts a researched illustration into a demonstrable factual error.

MCQ 27. Remedial drill - Quine's own later position on revising logic

What position does Quine take in *Philosophy of Logic* (1970)?

- A. That logic was revised in 1936 and that the revision has been accepted by working physicists since.
- B. That logic is analytic after all, which repairs the analytic/synthetic distinction he had earlier attacked.
- C. That logic is revisable only within constructed artificial languages, and never in the language of everyday scientific practice.
- D. That anyone who "denies" a law of logic has changed the subject, and that revision should observe minimum mutilation.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the proposal was contested rather than accepted, and Putnam himself later withdrew from it.
- **B:** Incorrect: Quine never restores analyticity; entrenchment remains his account of logic's stability.
- **C:** Incorrect: no such restriction to artificial languages is offered, and it would sit badly with his naturalism.
- **D:** Correct: "change of logic, change of subject" together with the maxim of minimum mutilation is the later, conservative Quine.

Examiner trap 27: Using the early Quine's boldest slogan without the later retreat produces an answer that a well-read examiner can immediately qualify, which is a mark forfeited voluntarily.

MCQ 28. Remedial drill - what "empiricism without the dogmas" retains

Which statement describes Quine's own position after both dogmas are removed?

- A. Sensory evidence and scientific naturalism are retained; sentence-by-sentence reduction and the foundational analytic/synthetic boundary are not.
- B. Empiricism is abandoned in favour of a rationalism that grounds the whole of science in first principles known independently of any experience at all.
- C. Empiricism is replaced by scepticism, since without a foundation no belief can be rationally preferred to any other.
- D. Empiricism survives unchanged, since Quine's criticisms concern only the artificial languages constructed by Carnap.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the title of Section 6 is "Empiricism without the Dogmas", and subtraction rather than replacement is exactly what it describes.
- **B:** Incorrect: Quine denies any first-philosophy standpoint, which rules out the rationalist foundation this option supposes.
- **C:** Incorrect: pragmatic virtues and predictive success discriminate between revisions, so scepticism does not follow.
- **D:** Incorrect: the criticism is aimed at the empiricist tradition generally, and Carnap's constructed languages are only one target.

Examiner trap 28: Opening with "Quine rejects empiricism" contradicts the section title of the very paper being discussed and misdescribes his self-understanding.

MCQ 29. Remedial drill - why the linguist cannot simply ask

In the *gavagai* argument, why can the field linguist not settle the reference of the term by asking whether this gavagai is the same as that one?

- A. Because the native speakers may be unwilling to cooperate with a stranger's persistent questioning.
- B. Because reference is a theoretical notion and cannot be investigated by any empirical method at all.
- C. Because assent and dissent are unreliable indicators of belief, so no verbal response whatever could count as evidence for anything at all.
- D. Because the question presupposes a translated identity predicate and the whole apparatus of individuation, which is what is in dispute.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: cooperation is stipulated in the thought-experiment; the obstacle is logical, not social.
- **B:** Incorrect: Quine's approach to reference is thoroughly empirical; the argument shows that the empirical evidence underdetermines the answer.
- **C:** Incorrect: assent and dissent are the whole evidential base Quine allows, and he treats them as reliable.
- **D:** Correct: identity, articles, plurals and quantifiers must already be translated for the question to be asked, and their translation is precisely what is undetermined.

Examiner trap 29: Asserting "meanings are indeterminate" without the identity-predicate move states a conclusion whose only support has been omitted.

MCQ 30. Remedial drill - four doctrines, four units

Which pairing of doctrine and unit is correct?

- A. Indeterminacy of translation concerns sub-sentential terms, while inscrutability of reference concerns entire translation manuals and theories.
- B. Radical translation and ontological relativity are two names for the same thesis about background theories.
- C. Inscrutability concerns sub-sentential terms; indeterminacy concerns rival manuals; ontological relativity concerns background theories.
- D. Ontological relativity concerns the bound variables of a regimented theory, exactly as the 1948 criterion does.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it swaps the two units; indeterminacy is the manual-level thesis and inscrutability the term-level one.
- **B:** Incorrect: radical translation is the method or situation; ontological relativity is a thesis about how reference is fixed.
- **C:** Correct: four doctrines, four distinct units, and keeping them apart prevents the commonest confusion in this material.
- **D:** Incorrect: the 1948 criterion audits what a regimented theory quantifies over; relativity concerns how reference is fixed at all.

Examiner trap 30: Using "indeterminacy" and "inscrutability" interchangeably signals that the doctrines have been remembered as a story rather than understood as distinct theses.

MCQ 31. Remedial drill - dating naturalized epistemology and its governing image

Which statement about naturalized epistemology is correct?

- A. It is stated in "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951), whose closing section already proposes a naturalistic psychology of belief-formation.
- B. It is stated in *Individuals* (1959), where Strawson endorses it as a form of descriptive metaphysics.
- C. It is stated in *Word and Object* (1960), whose epigraph from Popper supplies its governing image.
- D. It is stated in "Epistemology Naturalized" in the 1969 volume; the governing image is Neurath's boat, the epigraph of *Word and Object*.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the 1951 paper argues for holism; the naturalisation of epistemology comes nearly two decades later.
- **B:** Incorrect: *Individuals* is Strawson's, and descriptive metaphysics is not a naturalised epistemology.
- **C:** Incorrect: the epigraph of *Word and Object* is **Neurath's** boat, not Popper's, and the essay is not in that book.
- **D:** Correct: the Dewey Lectures were delivered in 1968 and the volume appeared in 1969, containing both "Ontological Relativity" and "Epistemology Naturalized".

Examiner trap 31: Dating naturalized epistemology to 1951 compresses eighteen years of Quine's development and misrepresents "Two Dogmas" as a programme it never announces.

MCQ 32. Remedial drill - the ownership fence around this clause

Which item belongs to **another** syllabus clause and must not be expounded as doctrine here?

- A. The argument that identification requires a single unified spatio-temporal framework of material bodies.
- B. The verification principle and its formulation by Ayer and the Vienna Circle, expounded as a doctrine.
- C. The claim that no statement is immune to revision, together with the field-of-force model of belief.
- D. The argument that P-predicates must be ascribable both to others and to oneself, on different grounds.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is Strawson's printed doctrine and the core of 2020 Q3(b) and 2021 Q3(b).
- **B:** Correct: Logical Positivism is Topic 07; the verification principle appears here only as the position Quine dismantles.
- **C:** Incorrect: holism and the web are Quine's printed doctrine and the core of 2025 Q4(b).
- **D:** Incorrect: the dual-ascription argument is Strawson's printed doctrine and the core of 2018 Q1(e) and 2023 Q4(a).

Examiner trap 32: Spending a third of a Quine answer expounding the Vienna Circle's verification principle answers a Topic 07 question that was not asked, and the same fence applies to Hume, Kant, Russell's descriptions and Wittgenstein's language-games.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline - read once, applies to every solution below

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is **never** an official UPSC key; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answers for Philosophy Paper I. Question wording is reproduced exactly as printed in the official papers, including the typographic quotation marks the repository ledger records and the printed hyphenation of "synthetic-analytic" in 2019. The 2018 to 2025 Paper I texts are held locally, and the English wording of every part below follows the repository's verified Western Philosophy PYQ ledger. Provenance is treated as examinable: "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" is cited to *The Philosophical Review*, **January 1951**, with its web-of-belief passage at **Section 6**; the bound-variable slogan is credited to the criterion of **"On What There Is" (1948)** and never to "Two Dogmas"; *Individuals* (1959) is cited by **Part I** for basic particulars and **chapter 3** for persons; and "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956) is attributed to **Grice and Strawson** jointly. Interpretive disputes - whether the failure of explication defeats the ordinary distinction, whether logic is revisable in any interesting sense, whether descriptive metaphysics can be more than a map, and whether "primitive" explains or merely ends the analysis - are flagged as contested rather than settled.

Answer-length convention used throughout this package. UPSC Philosophy Paper I parts are written longer than General Studies answers. The working bands used here are **10 marks - about 150 to 220 words**, **15 marks - about 250 to 330 words**, and **20 marks - about 330 to 400 words**. Every solution below sits inside its declared band, and the demand decoding, the verdict heading and the "why this earns marks" notes are teaching apparatus that sit **outside** the timed word count.

Coverage. ANALYSIS: Corpus signal: this clause owns **9 of 112** Western Philosophy question-parts in the 2018-2025 corpus, with **two each in 2018 and 2021**, one each in **2019, 2020, 2023, 2024 and 2025**, and **none in 2022**. All nine are solved in full below, followed by **six original solved Mains models**, two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks. The internal distribution is worth knowing before the exam: **Quine** carries five parts (2018 Q2(c), 2019 Q1(e), 2021 Q3(c), 2024 Q4(c), 2025 Q4(b)) and **Strawson** four (2018 Q1(e), 2020 Q3(b), 2021 Q3(b), 2023 Q4(a)); the single 20-marker is Strawson's, and the Strawson parts escalate from a 10-marker on the person concept in 2018 to that 20-marker in 2023. One part - **2025 Q4(b)** - is a **statement question**, and for it the first move is to preserve the conditional clause of the quotation; one part - **2018 Q2(c)** - embeds a **framing phrase**, "a metaphysical article of faith", which is the paper's wording rather than a verified verbatim Quine quotation, and every solution below says so.

Solved PYQ 1 · 2018 · Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: How does Strawson explain the concept of person in his philosophy? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does he explain " - an argument is required, not a definition
Core issue	That "person" is logically primitive, and why that follows from the way P-predicates work
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the predicate matrix, the argument, both rivals in one sentence each
Ideal thesis	A person is a single subject of two predicate-classes, and the concept cannot be assembled from either half
Non-negotiables	M- and P-predicates with examples; "without observation"; both dualism and no-ownership named

Independent model answer

Thesis. Strawson explains the person not as a compound of mind and body but as a **logically primitive** concept - the concept of a single subject to which both bodily and mental predicates are ascribed, presupposed by rather than assembled from the concepts of mind and body (*Individuals*, 1959, ch. 3).

The predicate matrix. FACT: A person is that to which we ascribe both **M-predicates**, also true of mere bodies - "weighs 70 kg", "is in the kitchen" - and **P-predicates**, ascribing states of consciousness - "is in pain", "is thinking of Vienna". Both classes belong to **one** thing.

The argument. I can self-ascribe P-predicates only if the same predicates are ascribable to **others**; others are identified as **embodied subjects** on publicly available behavioural criteria; yet the same predicates are self-ascribed **without observation** of my own behaviour. ANALYSIS: A predicate with that **dual character** cannot be built from a pure consciousness, which never reaches public criteria, or from a pure body, which never reaches unobserved self-ascription. Its subject must already be both.

The two rivals. This undercuts **Cartesian dualism**, which cannot re-identify an immaterial soul in the framework identification requires, and destroys the **no-ownership theory**, which must say "the experiences **had by** this body" and so restores the possession it denied.

Qualification. ANALYSIS: "Primitive" means conceptual priority within our scheme, not a third substance.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the directive is "how does he explain", so the six-step argument, not the definition, is the answer.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis one line; matrix two; argument four; rivals two; qualification one.

- **Structure:** thesis -> matrix -> argument -> two rivals -> qualification.
- **Doctrine:** primitiveness; the dual character of P-predicates.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) ch. 3; four predicate examples; the possessive "had by".
- **Distinction:** conceptual priority against substance-postulation.
- **Criticism:** implicit in the qualification, which blocks both the dualist and the materialist misreading.

Solved PYQ 2 · 2018 · Q2(c) · 15 marks

Question: How does Quine show that the notion of a priori knowledge as discussed by Kant is 'a metaphysical article of faith'? Give reasons for your answer.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does he show " plus "give reasons" - a mechanism, then its grounds
Core issue	That the phrase is the paper's framing and that Quine's case is three connected moves
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: three moves, one Kantian reply, one graded verdict; not a Kant exposition
Ideal thesis	Explication failure, holism and naturalism jointly leave the a priori asserted rather than shown
Non-negotiables	The framing flagged; the 1951 dating; "no statement is immune to revision"; the Kantian reply

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: "A metaphysical article of faith" is the **question's framing**, not a verified verbatim Quine formula; what Quine supplies is a three-step case that a Kantian a priori is asserted rather than established.

Move one - the explication fails. Kant's synthetic a priori presupposes a workable analytic/synthetic boundary. In "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (*The Philosophical Review*, 1951) Quine shows that analyticity can be explained only through **synonymy**, and synonymy only through **definition**, which records an antecedent synonymy; or **interchangeability salva veritate***, which over-generates extensionally and requires a necessity-operator whose intelligibility rests on analyticity; or Carnap's **semantical rules**, which yield "analytic-in-L" without explaining the general notion. Every route returns to its starting point.

Move two - holism. Because statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body", **any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere**, and **no statement is immune to revision**. Apparent apriority is therefore greater **centrality** in the web - a difference of degree, not of kind.

Move three - naturalism. Philosophy is continuous with science and there is no first-philosophy standpoint from which a priori knowledge could be certified. To assert it is to take on trust what cannot be shown.

Objection and reply. CAUTION: Kant may answer that transcendental conditions of experience are not empirical hypotheses inside the web, so revisability does not reach them - a reply Strawson's descriptive reading of Kant supports. Quine's rejoinder is that this reasserts precisely the privileged non-empirical status in dispute.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Quine defeats a **sharp** a priori/a posteriori boundary; what survives is a gradient of entrenchment, and whether some framework role escapes the web remains open.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the question is about **Quine's** argument; Kant appears as its target and as one reply, never as an exposition.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; move one six; move two four; move three two; objection two; verdict two.

- **Structure:** framing flagged -> three moves -> reply -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** circle of explication; holism; naturalism.
- **Evidence:** "Two Dogmas" (1951); both canonical sentences; the three failed routes.
- **Distinction:** degree of entrenchment against difference in kind.
- **Criticism:** the transcendental-conditions reply, reported as unsettled.

Solved PYQ 3 · 2019 · Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: Explain Quine's arguments against synthetic-analytic distinction.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain ... arguments" - plural, so the chain must be reproduced
Core issue	The circularity of every candidate explication, and the exact conclusion drawn
Scope boundary	Ten marks: two classes, three routes, conclusion, one objection
Ideal thesis	No non-circular explication is available, so the distinction cannot bear foundational weight
Non-negotiables	The heart/kidney case; the necessity regress; "analytic-in-L"; Grice and Strawson

Independent model answer

Thesis. Quine argues that the distinction admits no principled, **non-circular** criterion: every proposed explanation of "analytic" presupposes a notion from the same family.

The two classes. FACT: Analytic truths were said to be either **logically true** - "No unmarried man is married" - or convertible into logical truths by substituting **synonyms** - "No bachelor is married". The second class needs synonymy, and that is where the trouble begins.

Three routes, three failures. **Definition** merely *records* a synonymy already present in the language, except where frankly stipulative. **Interchangeability salva veritate*** over-generates in an extensional language - "creature with a heart" and "creature with a kidney" interchange without being synonymous - and repairing it by demanding interchange within "necessarily" presupposes a **necessity** intelligible for Quine only through analyticity. **Semantical rules** deliver "analytic-in-L" by stipulation, leaving the general notion no clearer than what it was to explain.

The conclusion, stated exactly. ANALYSIS: Not that "All bachelors are unmarried" is false, but that the available explications fail to secure the **sharp foundational boundary** logical empiricism required. What replaces it is **degrees of entrenchment** in the web of belief.

Objection and reply. CAUTION: Grice and Strawson ("In Defence of a Dogma", 1956) reply that a distinction with agreed application is not discredited by the absence of a reductive analysis. Quine's rejoinder: agreed sorting is not the principled ground the positivist meaning-criterion needed.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the marks are in the **circle**, so each route must be shown returning to synonymy or necessity.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis one line; classes two; routes five; conclusion two; objection two.

- **Structure:** thesis -> two classes -> three routes -> exact conclusion -> objection.
- **Doctrine:** synonymy, definition, *salva veritate*, semantical rules.
- **Evidence:** the heart/kidney counter-case; "analytic-in-L"; the 1956 reply.
- **Distinction:** failure of explication against falsity of the sentences.
- **Criticism:** Grice and Strawson, with the rejoinder rather than a bare mention.

Solved PYQ 4 · 2020 · Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: Evaluate the role of spatio-temporal thinking in objective thinking with reference to Strawson's theory of basic particulars.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	" Evaluate the role" - a function must be identified, then assessed
Core issue	That a single spatio-temporal framework is the condition of objective identification
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the argument, the auditory test, the limitation
Ideal thesis	Spatio-temporal thinking supplies the individuating framework without which re-identification, and so objectivity, is impossible
Non-negotiables	Identification -> re-identification -> framework; the three defects; the analogue of space

Independent model answer

Thesis. Spatio-temporal thinking is not one feature of objective thought among others: it supplies the **single framework** without which particulars cannot be re-identified, and without re-identification there is no objective reference at all.

The argument. FACT: In *Individuals* (1959, Part I) Strawson argues that to identify a particular I must distinguish it from others and **re-identify** it across time; re-identification requires **one unified spatio-temporal framework** in which every particular has a location; and **material bodies**, as enduring and publicly observable occupants of that framework, are the standard anchors of demonstrative identification. Experiences, events and sounds are **dependent** particulars, identified through their relations to persons, bodies, places and times.

Why the empiricist alternative fails. Sense-data cannot supply a framework: they are **private**, so they cannot ground public identification; **momentary**, so they cannot be re-identified; and **non-spatial**, so they cannot constitute a framework at all. Material bodies are therefore basic as a **condition of the possibility of reference**, not as a metaphysical preference.

The evaluative test. ANALYSIS: Strawson removes space to see what it was doing. A purely auditory world of pitch and succession cannot distinguish the same particular re-encountered from a new one exactly resembling it; objective reference there would require an **analogue of space**, reconstructed through a continuously available **master-sound**. The experiment therefore isolates the **individuating role** rather than privileging our sensory organisation.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The result is transcendental in form and internal in reach: it establishes what **our conceptual scheme** requires, not that reality independently contains bodies. CAUTION: An empiricist may accept the analysis as conceptual geography while denying that it settles ontology - and conceding this strengthens the answer.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "evaluate the role" is answered by removing the thing whose role is in question; the auditory world is therefore the centre, not an ornament.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; argument five; failure three; test four; verdict three.

- **Structure:** thesis -> argument -> why sense-data fail -> the removal test -> limitation.
- **Doctrine:** identification, re-identification, unified framework, dependent particulars.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) Part I; the three defects; the master-sound.
- **Distinction:** individuating **role** against our particular sensory equipment.
- **Criticism:** the internal, scheme-relative reach of the conclusion.

Solved PYQ 5 · 2021 · Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: What according to Strawson are basic particulars? What reasons does Strawson offer to believe that 'material bodies' and 'persons' are basic particulars? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Definition, then reasons , then "critically discuss" - three obligations
Core issue	Two kinds of basic particular, each with its own argument
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: both arguments compressed, then two objections with replies
Ideal thesis	Bodies are basic by the identification argument, persons by the dual-ascription argument
Non-negotiables	Both kinds answered; the three defects; M/P predicates; anthropocentrism and the "primitive" objection

Independent model answer

Thesis. Basic particulars are those on which the possibility of **identification and reference in general** depends; Strawson argues that **material bodies** and **persons** occupy that role in our conceptual scheme, each by a distinct argument.

Bodies. FACT: Identification requires **re-identification**; re-identification requires a **single unified spatio-temporal framework**; and material bodies are its enduring, publicly observable occupants, anchoring demonstrative identification (*Individuals*, 1959, Part I). Sense-data cannot take the role: they are **private, momentary and non-spatial**. Experiences, events and sounds are identified only through their relations to bodies, persons, places and times.

Persons. FACT: A person is a single subject bearing both **M-predicates** - "weighs 70 kg" - and **P-predicates** - "is in pain" (ch. 3). Self-ascription of P-predicates is possible only if they are **other-ascribable** on public criteria, while remaining **self-ascribable without observation**. A predicate with that dual character cannot be constructed from a pure body or a pure consciousness, so the concept of a person is **logically primitive** - the second kind of basic particular.

Critical assessment. CAUTION: First, the argument is charged with **anthropocentrism**: another scheme might not need bodies. Strawson's conclusion always concerned **our** scheme, and the purely auditory discussion concedes that an **analogue of space** could perform the individuating role - a measured reply rather than a refutation. CAUTION: Second, calling the person concept "primitive" may **end** analysis rather than explain the psychophysical unity. Strawson's defenders answer that the demand for analysis into mind plus body already presupposes dualism, so refusal is the point; but the mechanism of unity is genuinely untouched.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The reasons succeed as **descriptive metaphysics**: they establish what our scheme requires, not what exists independently of it.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the stem names **two** kinds of basic particular, so an answer that argues only for bodies has answered half the question.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; bodies four; persons four; assessment five; verdict one.

- **Structure:** definition -> bodies -> persons -> two objections with replies -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** identification/re-identification; the dual character of P-predicates.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) Part I and ch. 3; the three defects; the master-sound concession.
- **Distinction:** two different arguments for two kinds of basic particular.
- **Criticism:** anthropocentrism and the explanatory limits of "primitive".

Solved PYQ 6 · 2021 · Q3(c) · 15 marks

Question: Critically examine Quine's postulate of empiricism without the dogmas with reference to his 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	" Critically examine " - assessment must occupy a substantial share
Core issue	What empiricism retains once both dogmas are removed
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: both dogmas compressed, holism, then the objections
Ideal thesis	The dogmas are removed and empiricism survives, reformed rather than refuted
Non-negotiables	Both dogmas; "at root identical"; the pragmatic virtues; Grice-Strawson; the arbitrariness objection

Independent model answer

Thesis. Quine's postulate is **subtraction, not replacement**: two assumptions are removed and what survives - sensory evidence and scientific naturalism - is still empiricism, now holistic and thoroughly revisable.

The two dogmas. FACT: The first is the belief in a principled analytic/synthetic boundary; it fails because **definition, interchangeability salva veritate*** and **semantical rules** each presuppose synonymy, necessity or analyticity. The second is **reductionism**: the assumption that each statement has its own confirming experiences, whether by translation into a sense-datum language or by individual confirmation. ANALYSIS: Quine's own verdict is that the two are **at root identical**, since statements "confirmed come what may" need a contrast class of individually confirmed statements.

What replaces them. Statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a **corporate body**"; the unit of empirical significance is **the whole of science**; and revision, forced somewhere by a recalcitrant experience, is located by **simplicity, conservatism and fecundity** rather than by logic.

What survives. FACT: Experience remains the check on the system, science remains the best account of what there is, and there is **no first philosophy** outside it. The line between speculative metaphysics and natural science becomes one of **degree**.

Critical assessment. CAUTION: Grice and Strawson ("In Defence of a Dogma", 1956) object that a distinction with agreed application needs no reductive definition; Quine replies that ordinary intelligibility is not theoretical legitimacy, and the dispute is really about **standards of explication**. CAUTION: The arbitrariness charge - if everything is revisable, nothing constrains belief - is met by pragmatic conservatism and, in *Philosophy of Logic* (1970), by the **maxim of minimum mutilation**.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Holism is right about **confirmation** and overstated about **revisability**; the postulate stands in its reformed, not its most radical, version.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "critically examine" requires the assessment to be a section, not a closing sentence.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; dogmas five; replacement three; survival two; assessment four; verdict one.

- **Structure:** thesis -> both dogmas -> holism -> what survives -> objections -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the circle; reductionism in two forms; the corporate body; entrenchment.
- **Evidence:** "Two Dogmas" (1951); "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956); *Philosophy of Logic* (1970).
- **Distinction:** subtraction against rejection of empiricism.
- **Criticism:** standards of explication; the arbitrariness charge and its constraints.

Solved PYQ 7 · 2023 · Q4(a) · 20 marks

Question: Why does Strawson consider person to be a primitive concept? What implication does it have for the mind-body dualism? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	A why , then an implication - two questions, both answered explicitly
Core issue	That both rival accounts presuppose the concept they try to construct or eliminate
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the frame, the argument, both rivals, a graded verdict
Ideal thesis	Person is prior to mind and body, so the dualist question is dissolved rather than answered
Non-negotiables	Descriptive frame; M/P predicates; the dual character; dualism and no-ownership; the cost

Independent model answer

Thesis. Strawson holds the concept of a person to be **logically primitive** because both rival accounts of the mind-body relation presuppose it; the implication for dualism is not refutation of a thesis but **dissolution of its starting point**.

The frame. FACT: *Individuals* (1959) is **descriptive metaphysics**: it describes the actual structure of our thought rather than proposing a better one. The question is therefore what our scheme of ascribing predicates to persons requires.

Why primitive. FACT: In our scheme a person is a single entity bearing both **M-predicates**, also true of mere bodies - "weighs 70 kg", "is in the kitchen" - and **P-predicates**, ascribing states of consciousness - "is in pain", "intends to leave". The decisive feature is the **dual character** of P-predicates: they are ascribed to **others** on publicly available behavioural and situational criteria, and to **oneself without observation** of one's own behaviour. ANALYSIS: From a pure consciousness one never reaches public criteria, so other-ascription is impossible; from a pure body one never reaches unobserved self-ascription. Only a subject that is already **both** satisfies both conditions, and the concept of that subject is therefore **prior** to the concepts of mind and body - "logically prior to that of an individual consciousness".

The implication for dualism. FACT: Cartesian dualism treats an independently identifiable mind and body as conceptually prior; but an immaterial soul cannot be located in the single spatio-temporal framework in which identification and **re-identification** occur, and once the two substances are separated their interaction becomes unintelligible. Strawson does not answer the interaction question - he shows that it presupposes a prior unity neither term can supply. ANALYSIS: The **no-ownership theory** fares no better: to say which experiences are in question the theorist must say "the experiences **had by** this body", and the possessive restores the ownership he denied.

Assessment. CAUTION: The strength is economy: the problem is **dissolved** because the decomposition generating it is illicit. The cost is that "primitive" marks the **end of analysis** rather than an explanation of psychophysical unity - legitimate for descriptive metaphysics, unsatisfying for anyone who wanted the problem solved. ANALYSIS: And the conclusion is scheme-relative: dualism's **starting point** is undercut, not every dualist thesis disproved.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the second question is the marked one; the exposition must be arranged so that the implication is earned rather than announced.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: thesis one line; frame two; why primitive eight; implication seven; assessment four.

- **Structure:** thesis -> descriptive frame -> the argument -> dualism -> no-ownership -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** primitiveness; predicate duality; dissolution rather than solution.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) ch. 3; four predicate examples; the possessive "had by".
- **Distinction:** undercutting a **starting point** against refuting every dualist thesis.
- **Criticism:** the end-of-analysis cost, conceded and correctly located.

Solved PYQ 8 · 2024 · Q4(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the nature of the two dogmas that Quine refers to in his paper 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain the nature " - what each dogma is, and what makes each a dogma
Core issue	Both dogmas defined, both refuted, and the relation between them stated
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: definitions, the refutations, the identification, one criticism
Ideal thesis	Two unargued assumptions, structurally the same, both removed by holism
Non-negotiables	Both forms of reductionism; the label explained; "at root identical"

Independent model answer

Thesis. The two dogmas are unargued assumptions of logical empiricism - a principled analytic/synthetic boundary and sentence-by-sentence confirmation - and Quine's case is that they are **at root identical**.

The first dogma. FACT: It is the belief that there is a non-arbitrary line between statements true **by virtue of meaning** and statements true **by virtue of fact**. It is a dogma because the line cannot be drawn non-circularly: analyticity requires **synonymy**; synonymy is explained by **definition**, which merely records an antecedent synonymy, or by **interchangeability salva veritate***, which over-generates extensionally ("creature with a heart" / "creature with a kidney") and requires a necessity-operator that presupposes analyticity, or by Carnap's **semantical rules**, which give "analytic-in-L" without explaining the general notion.

The second dogma. FACT: **Reductionism** is the belief that each meaningful statement is translatable into, or individually confirmable by, a range of sense-experience. Its **radical** form demands term-by-term translation into a sense-datum language; its **attenuated** form abandons translation but keeps individual confirmation. ANALYSIS: The label names the operation: it *reduces* sentence-meaning to observation sentences.

Why both fall together. Statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a **corporate body**", so the unit of empirical significance is **the whole of science**. ANALYSIS: Once no statement has its own evidential stock, the class of statements "confirmed come what may" has no contrast class - which is why Quine calls the two dogmas at root identical.

Assessment. CAUTION: Grice and Strawson (1956) object that the first distinction is intelligible in ordinary use without a reductive analysis; Quine replies that ordinary intelligibility is not the principled ground the positivist meaning-criterion required.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: What replaces both is **empiricism without the dogmas**: holistic, revisable and still empiricist.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "nature" asks what each dogma **is** and why it deserves the name; the identification of the two is what turns a list into an argument.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis one line; first dogma five; second dogma four; identification three; assessment two; verdict one.

- **Structure:** thesis -> dogma one -> dogma two -> why they fall together -> objection -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the circle; radical and attenuated reductionism; the corporate body.
- **Evidence:** the heart/kidney case; "analytic-in-L"; the unit of empirical significance.
- **Distinction:** the two forms of reductionism, and the explanation of the label.
- **Criticism:** the 1956 reply with Quine's rejoinder.

Solved PYQ 9 · 2025 · Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: "We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system, in the face of whatever experience, just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere." Discuss this statement in the light of Quine's 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	A statement question : locate the sentence in the system, then unpack it
Core issue	That the conditional clause is the doctrine, and that it is a claim about confirmation
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the mechanism, the historical illustration, the constraints, the verdict
Ideal thesis	The sentence states holistic confirmation, not licence: the cost is what disciplines the choice
Non-negotiables	<i>Modus tollens</i> ; the three revision options; Neptune and "Vulcan"; minimum mutilation

Independent model answer

Thesis. The sentence is a claim about **where blame for a failed prediction may be assigned**, not a licence to believe anything: the clause "just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere" names the price, and the price is the doctrine.

Where it sits. FACT: It belongs to Section 6 of "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951), after both dogmas have been removed. Statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a **corporate body**", so the unit of empirical significance is the whole of science.

The mechanism. FACT: A hypothesis entails an observation only with **auxiliaries**: the testable claim is $(H \ \& \ A) \rightarrow O$. When experience yields not-O, **modus tollens*** delivers only not- $(H \ \& \ A)$ - H is false **or** some element of A is false - and logic never names the guilty conjunct. Three responses are therefore available: revise a peripheral belief, revise a deep interior statement, or **plead hallucination** and revise the observation itself. The third is what makes the quoted sentence literally true.

The historical illustration. FACT: Anomalies in Uranus's orbit were met by revising the auxiliary assumption about the number of planets, and **Neptune** was found (1846). The identical strategy applied to Mercury produced the hypothesised planet "**Vulcan**", which does not exist; there the correct revision was the deep one - **general relativity** (1915). ANALYSIS: Same logical situation, opposite correct responses, no advance rule.

What blocks relativism. ANALYSIS: Revision is chosen on grounds of **simplicity, conservatism and fecundity**, and in *Philosophy of Logic* (1970) Quine adds the **maxim of minimum mutilation** and warns that "change of logic" is change of subject. No statement is revisable **by nature**; only by choice, and choice has costs.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The statement is right about confirmation and easily misread as relativism; truncating it at "come what may" is what produces the misreading.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: a statement question is failed by paraphrase; the answer must supply the mechanism the sentence compresses.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; location two; mechanism five; illustration four; constraints two; verdict one.

- **Structure:** thesis -> location in Section 6 -> *modus tollens* -> Neptune/Vulcan -> constraints -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** holistic confirmation; the three revision options.
- **Evidence:** "Two Dogmas" (1951) Section 6; Neptune 1846; "Vulcan" and general relativity 1915; *Philosophy of Logic* (1970).
- **Distinction:** re-allocating blame against indifference to evidence.
- **Criticism:** the relativist misreading identified and diagnosed.

Six original questions in the style of the paper - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks - covering the parts of the course the 2018-2025 corpus has not yet examined directly: the Duhem-Quine mechanism on its own, descriptive against revisionary metaphysics, the revisability of logic, the no-ownership theory, the indeterminacy of translation, and the two-project comparison. Every model answer is independent learner practice.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain why, for Quine, no single scientific hypothesis can be tested in isolation.

Independent model answer

Thesis. A hypothesis makes no prediction by itself, so experience never convicts it alone; what is tested is always a **conjunction**.

The mechanism. FACT: The testable claim is $(H \ \& \ A) \rightarrow O$, where A gathers background theory, instrument theory and initial conditions. Observation yields **not-O**, and **modus tollens*** delivers only **not-(H & A)**: H is false or some element of A is false. Logic does not say which.

The consequence. ANALYSIS: A reductionist criterion assigning each statement its own confirming experiences therefore has no application - which is precisely Quine's second dogma. And symmetrically, "any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system".

The evidence. FACT: Anomalies in Uranus's orbit were resolved by revising an auxiliary, and **Neptune** was found in **1846**; the same move applied to Mercury produced "**Vulcan**", which does not exist, and the correct revision proved to be **general relativity (1915)**. Identical logical situations, opposite correct responses.

Qualification. ANALYSIS: **Duhem (1906)** confined the thesis to physics and exempted logic and mathematics; the extension to all knowledge is Quine's own step. Nor does the thesis make revision arbitrary: simplicity, conservatism and minimum mutilation still discriminate.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the logical form is the answer; the history is what proves it is not a mere possibility.

- **Structure:** thesis $\rightarrow$ *modus tollens* $\rightarrow$ consequence for dogma two $\rightarrow$ paired historical case $\rightarrow$ qualification.
- **Doctrine:** the conjunction under test; holistic confirmation.
- **Evidence:** Neptune 1846; "Vulcan"; general relativity 1915; Duhem 1906.
- **Distinction:** Duhem's restricted thesis against Quine's extension.
- **Criticism:** the arbitrariness worry, answered by pragmatic constraints.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish descriptive from revisionary metaphysics, and explain why Strawson describes his own project as descriptive.

Independent model answer

Thesis. Descriptive metaphysics describes the actual structure of our thought about the world; revisionary metaphysics proposes a better structure - and Strawson's project is descriptive because its conclusions are claims about the conditions of a scheme we already use.

The distinction. FACT: In *Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics (1959)* the descriptive metaphysician maps how our concepts hang together; the revisionary metaphysician recommends replacing them. Strawson's own examples are **Aristotle** and **Kant** on the descriptive side, and **Descartes**, **Leibniz** and **Berkeley** on the revisionary side.

The relation. ANALYSIS: The two are not simply opposed: revisionary metaphysics is at its most valuable **in the service of** the descriptive, because dismantling part of the actual scheme reveals what it was doing.

Why Strawson's project is descriptive. FACT: His method is **connective analysis**: concepts are exhibited in their dependence on one another, not reduced to a privileged base of simples. His arguments are **transcendental in form** - from an undisputed fact about identification or ascription to its conditions - and their conclusions are therefore about

our scheme.

Qualification. CAUTION: The programme is charged with being circular or conservative, since it protects the scheme in which its conditions are stated. Strawson accepts an **internal** task: even radical revision must begin inside some functioning scheme of identification and reference. The cost is that description alone cannot show the scheme uniquely correct.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the fatal error here is two definitions with no examples; Strawson's own names are the cheapest marks available.

- **Structure:** thesis -> distinction with examples -> relation -> why descriptive -> objection and cost.
- **Doctrine:** connective analysis; transcendental form.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) and its subtitle; Aristotle and Kant; Descartes, Leibniz and Berkeley.
- **Distinction:** describing against replacing a conceptual scheme.
- **Criticism:** the conservatism charge, answered by the internality of the task.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "No statement is immune to revision." How far can this claim be sustained in the case of logic?

Independent model answer

Thesis. The claim can be sustained **in principle** and only weakly in practice: logic is protected by entrenchment and by the cost of revision rather than by any certificate of analyticity.

The claim and its source. FACT: It stands in Section 6 of "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951) as the converse of "any statement can be held true come what may". The early essay extends revisability even to a law of logic, mentioning the proposed revision of the law of excluded middle as a means of simplifying quantum mechanics.

The strongest candidate. FACT: **Birkhoff and von Neumann**, "The Logic of Quantum Mechanics" (*Annals of Mathematics*, 1936), proposed a **non-distributive lattice** of quantum propositions - a formal proposal. ANALYSIS: The distinct philosophical claim that logic is therefore **empirically revisable**, and specifically that the **distributive law** should be given up, is **Putnam's**, in "Is Logic Empirical?" (1968). WRONG: The two must never be merged into "Putnam/Birkhoff". CAUTION: Putnam later abandoned the position.

The resistance, from Quine himself. ANALYSIS: In *Philosophy of Logic* (1970) Quine argues that anyone who "denies" a law of logic has merely **changed the subject**, and he invokes the **maxim of minimum mutilation**. The later Quine is therefore a poor witness for the earlier Quine's boldest claim.

Assessment. CAUTION: The objection that unrestricted revisability leaves science without a fixed point is met by the formula that no statement is revisable **by nature**, only by **choice** - and choice is disciplined by conservatism, simplicity and predictive success. But the concession is substantial: if revising logic normally costs more than any theory can pay, "revisable" does little work.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Holism is right about **confirmation** and overstated about **revisability**. The defensible position is Duhem's thesis with Quine's motivation: testing is holistic, the choice of revision is pragmatic, and logic is revisable in a sense so attenuated that little follows from it.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "how far" demands a graded ruling, and the grading must be earned by the 1936/1968/1970 sequence rather than asserted.

- **Structure:** thesis -> source of the claim -> the candidate case -> Quine's own retreat -> assessment -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** revisability by choice rather than by nature; minimum mutilation.
- **Evidence:** Birkhoff and von Neumann 1936; Putnam 1968 and his later withdrawal; *Philosophy of Logic* 1970.
- **Distinction:** a formal proposal against a philosophical claim about it.
- **Criticism:** the attenuation objection, conceded and priced.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Examine Strawson's criticism of the no-ownership theory of the self.

Independent model answer

Thesis. Strawson's criticism is that the no-ownership theory cannot be **stated** without reinstating the ownership it denies, so it refutes itself in the act of formulation.

The theory, fairly stated. FACT: The no-ownership or **no-subject** theory - which Strawson reconstructs and criticises, tracing it through Schlick and Wittgenstein-influenced writers - holds that experiences are **causally dependent** on a particular body but are not literally **possessed** by any subject. Its motive is respectable: it avoids the Cartesian ego while acknowledging the evident dependence of experience on a body.

The criticism. FACT: To state the thesis the theorist must say **which** experiences he is discussing, and he can only say "all the experiences **that are had by** this body". "Had by" is a **possessive** relation. Contingent causal dependence cannot replace it, because dependence does not single out **these** experiences as one person's rather than another's. The framework of personal ownership therefore returns inside the denial.

The positive alternative. FACT: The reason ownership cannot be removed is that **P-predicates** - "is in pain", "believes it will rain" - must be ascribable to **others** on publicly available criteria and to **oneself without observation**. A predicate with that dual condition presupposes a single subject bearing both **M-** and **P-predicates**; the concept of that subject, the **person**, is therefore **logically primitive** (*Individuals*, 1959, ch. 3).

Assessment. CAUTION: The argument is powerful against the theory as formulated, but it is a **conceptual** result: it shows that our scheme of ascription requires an owner, not that a metaphysically ownerless psychology is incoherent in every possible description. ANALYSIS: And "primitive" ends the analysis rather than explaining how one subject bears both predicate-classes.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The no-ownership theory is destroyed on its own terms; the deeper question of psychophysical unity is dissolved rather than answered.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: state the target theory sympathetically before demolishing it; the demolition is worthless against a straw man.

- **Structure:** thesis -> the theory and its motive -> the possessive move -> the positive alternative -> assessment.
- **Doctrine:** ownership; P-predicate duality; primitiveness.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) ch. 3; the formula "the experiences had by this body".
- **Distinction:** causal dependence against possession.
- **Criticism:** the scheme-relative reach of the result.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Critically examine Quine's thesis of the indeterminacy of translation. Does it establish that there are no determinate meanings?

Independent model answer

Thesis. The thesis follows validly from Quine's premises but establishes its conclusion **only for those who already accept his naturalism**; what survives independently is the negative result that observable use does not fix reference.

The construction. FACT: In *Word and Object* (1960, ch. 2) a field linguist must build a manual for an unknown language from **assent and dissent under stimulation**. A rabbit runs past; the native says "**Gavagai**"; the linguist writes "Rabbit". But the same **stimulus meaning** fits "**undetached rabbit-parts**", "**a temporal stage of a rabbit**", "**rabbithood**", and the feature-placing "it's rabbiting". ANALYSIS: He cannot simply ask whether this gavagai is the same as that one: the question presupposes a translated **identity predicate** and the whole **apparatus of individuation**, which is exactly what is in dispute.

The two results. FACT: Compensating adjustments preserve every behavioural prediction, so behavioural evidence does not determine reference - **inscrutability of reference**. Extending upward, rival **analytical hypotheses** yield manuals agreeing on all **observation sentences** while translating theoretical sentences into non-equivalent English - **indeterminacy of translation**. ANALYSIS: There are then no determinate **meanings** as entities, so synonymy loses

its anchor and the first dogma's key notion loses its foundation.

The premises where objections enter. ANALYSIS: **P1**: behaviourism about the *evidence* - in linguistics, Quine says, one has no choice, since language is learned wholly from public behaviour. **P2**: the move from behavioural equivalence to "no further fact" is a substantive commitment. **P3**: naturalism denies any standpoint from which meanings could be certified.

The objections. CAUTION: **Chomsky** ("Quine's Empirical Assumptions", 1969): indeterminacy is merely the ordinary **underdetermination of theory by evidence**; if that does not make physics factless, why does it make translation factless? Quine replies that in physics there is a fact our theories imperfectly track, while in translation nothing beyond dispositions could make a manual right - an **asymmetry** that is a naturalist thesis rather than a result of the argument. CAUTION: **Searle and Evans**: applied reflexively it entails that I do not determinately know what I mean; Quine accepts a version - we **acquiesce in our mother tongue**. ANALYSIS: **Davidson** ("Radical Interpretation", 1973) accepts indeterminacy but confines it to something like a choice of measurement scale - real but harmless.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The thesis does **not** establish that there are no meanings *tout court*; it establishes that there are no determinate meanings **as entities** fixed by behavioural evidence. The durable result is that use alone does not fix reference - a conclusion the later Wittgenstein reaches by another route.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the question contains a second, narrower question; the verdict must answer it in the terms in which it was asked.

- **Structure:** thesis -> the construction -> the two results -> the premises -> three objections -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** stimulus meaning; analytical hypotheses; inscrutability against indeterminacy.
- **Evidence:** *Word and Object* (1960) ch. 2; the four rival readings; Chomsky 1969; Davidson 1973.
- **Distinction:** meanings as entities against the intelligibility of meaningful use.
- **Criticism:** the behaviourist premise identified as the load-bearing one.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: "Quine and Strawson criticise empiricism, but they do not criticise it together." Discuss.

Independent model answer

Thesis. The statement is correct: the two attack empiricism at different levels with different tools, and the only documented exchange between them is a **disagreement**.

Quine's level - confirmation. FACT: "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951) removes two assumptions. The **analytic/synthetic** boundary fails because definition merely records synonymy, interchangeability *salva veritate* over-generates extensionally and requires a necessity that presupposes analyticity, and semantical rules give only "analytic-in-L". **Reductionism** fails because statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a **corporate body**". What replaces both is **confirmation holism**, and what survives is **empiricism without the dogmas** - sensory evidence and naturalism retained.

Strawson's level - reference. FACT: *Individuals* (1959) argues that identification requires **re-identification**, that re-identification requires a **single unified spatio-temporal framework**, and that **material bodies** are its enduring, publicly observable occupants. Sense-data cannot occupy the role: they are **private, momentary** and **non-spatial**. And since **P-predicates** must be other-ascribed on public criteria yet self-ascribed **without observation**, the concept of a **person** is **logically primitive**, destroying the **no-ownership** alternative as well as the Cartesian one.

Why this is not a joint critique. ANALYSIS: The methods are opposed. Quine is a **naturalist** who regiments science into canonical notation and denies any first philosophy; Strawson practises **connective analysis** and offers arguments that are **transcendental in form**. Their conclusions differ correspondingly: Quine ends with a revisable web in which no statement is immune; Strawson ends with conditions internal to a conceptual scheme that his method is not designed to revise. FACT: And the decisive evidence is textual: **Grice and Strawson**, "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956), defend the very distinction Quine attacked, arguing that a distinction with agreed application needs no reductive analysis. Quine's rejoinder - that ordinary intelligibility is not theoretical legitimacy - leaves a live dispute about **standards of explication**, not a shared programme.

What may legitimately be said jointly. ANALYSIS: Empiricism failed twice over: about how theories are **confirmed** and about how we so much as **refer**. That is a problem-field, not a thesis.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Read together they pressure both empiricist confirmation atomism and sense-datum reconstruction **without becoming one school**; and an answer that treats them as co-authors of a single anti-empiricist doctrine misdescribes the only exchange the record contains.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the quoted claim must be **tested**, not illustrated; the 1956 paper is the evidence that decides it.

- **Structure:** thesis -> Quine's level -> Strawson's level -> why not joint -> the legitimate joint sentence -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** holism; identification and re-identification; primitiveness.
- **Evidence:** "Two Dogmas" (1951); *Individuals* (1959); "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956).
- **Distinction:** naturalism and regimentation against connective, transcendental analysis.
- **Criticism:** the standards-of-explication dispute, reported as unsettled.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Prerequisite check before using this block

ANALYSIS: Nothing below is needed to write a complete answer to any of the **nine** routed 2018-2025 question-parts. Use it only after the Basic block is secure: Quine's two dogmas with the full chain of failed explications, confirmation holism with both canonical sentences and their qualifiers, the Duhem-Quine mechanism, empiricism without the dogmas, Strawson's descriptive metaphysics, the identification argument for basic particulars, and the person as a primitive concept with both rivals refuted. In a **15-marker** use **one** module; in a **20-marker**, at most **two**. Each module below is a **second-order** question - a question about the standing of a doctrine already taught - and the mark it earns comes from the interpretive control it displays, not from the extra information it adds.

A1. Is indeterminacy of translation a distinct thesis, or ordinary underdetermination applied to semantics? ANALYSIS:

The issue. Given the Basic block's account of radical translation, is the indeterminacy of translation a *distinct* metaphysical thesis about the absence of meaning-facts, or is it merely the familiar **underdetermination of theory by evidence** transposed into semantics?

Competing interpretations.

- **Strong anti-meaning reading:** there simply are no intensional meaning-entities, and translation manuals answer to nothing beyond behaviour.
- **Moderate underdetermination reading:** translation is underdetermined exactly as physics is, and no special semantic nihilism follows.
- **Naturalistic reading:** translation and ontology are **theory-relative practices** rather than domains of nihilism; reference is fixed relative to a background theory and that is the whole of the result.

Extra objection and counter-reply. **Objection:** the thesis goes too far and appears to dissolve meaning altogether, which would make Quine's own writing unintelligible by his own lights. **Counter-reply:** Quine's target is intensional "meaning" as an **explanatory primitive**, not successful language-use; use survives inside theory and behaviour. The residue is **ontological relativity** - reference fixed only relative to a background theory.

Who presses what. **Chomsky** presses the underdetermination collapse; **Davidson** accepts indeterminacy but confines it, comparing it to a choice of measurement scale.

Safe 15/20 use. ANALYSIS: One line only, and only after the Basic block's *gavagai* steps have been stated. The line to write: "*whether indeterminacy is a distinct thesis or ordinary underdetermination turns on Quine's asymmetry between physics and translation, which is a naturalist commitment rather than a result of the argument.*"

What not to over-study. ANALYSIS: Do not make the whole of *Word and Object* compulsory for an ordinary two-dogmas answer.

Promotion status. Bounded enrichment. Promote to marks-essential core **only if** a future PYQ directly asks about radical translation, reference or ontological relativity.

A2. Is descriptive metaphysics conservative, transcendental, or merely methodological?

CAUTION:

The issue. Is Strawson merely **conservative** about ordinary thought, or is he offering a **transcendental defence** of the conceptual scheme within which all revision must begin?

Competing interpretations.

- **Conservative common-sense mapping:** descriptive metaphysics records how we happen to think and confers no authority on it.
- **Transcendental-argument reading:** it identifies **necessary conditions** of any thought that is recognisably about objective particulars, which is why *Individuals* (1959) and *The Bounds of Sense* (1966) form one project.
- **Modest methodological reading:** it is a disciplined way of exhibiting conceptual dependence, claiming neither necessity nor mere description.

Extra objection and counter-reply. **Objection:** descriptive metaphysics can **freeze current common sense** and resist philosophical innovation. **Counter-reply:** Strawson's claim is weaker than the objection assumes - even radical revision must **start** from some functioning scheme of identification, predication and reference, so the programme constrains where revision begins rather than forbidding it.

Safe 15/20 use. ANALYSIS: Best used to frame **why basic particulars matter**; it is not needed in every persons answer.

What not to over-study. ANALYSIS: Do not convert this into a general survey of twentieth-century metaphysics.

Promotion trigger. Promote to core **if** a future PYQ explicitly asks what descriptive metaphysics is, or how it differs from revisionary metaphysics.

A3. Is the concept of a person really primitive? CAUTION:

The issue. Must persons be **conceptually basic**, or can they be reduced to bodies plus psychological predicates, or to continuity theories of the self?

Competing interpretations.

- **Strawson's primitive-person thesis:** the concept cannot be constructed from either half, because P-predicates carry a dual ascription-condition.
- **Material-body-first reductions:** persons are bodies of a certain complexity, and P-predicates are further predicates of those bodies.
- **Neo-Lockean psychological reductions:** the person is constituted by relations of psychological continuity, so personhood is analysable after all.

Extra objection and counter-reply. **Objection:** calling "person" primitive can sound **stipulative** - a refusal to analyse dressed as a discovery. **Counter-reply:** Strawson's argument is conceptual, not mystical: our scheme of ascribing **both** M-predicates and P-predicates presupposes the person as a unified bearer, and neither reduction can generate a predicate that is other-ascribed on public criteria and self-ascribed without observation.

Safe 15/20 use. ANALYSIS: Useful as **one evaluative paragraph** in a persons or mind-body answer, after the owner's standard doctrine is complete.

What not to over-study. ANALYSIS: Do not import the whole modern personal-identity literature into this clause; personal identity over time belongs to Paper II and to Topic 03.

Promotion trigger. Promote to core **if** a future PYQ directly asks whether Strawson successfully proves the primitiveness of personhood, or compares him with reductionist theories.

A4. What the promotion record shows ANALYSIS:

The **2 September 2026** semantic review left all three modules in bounded status and recorded one specific finding: radical translation, the *gavagai* construction, indeterminacy, inscrutability and ontological relativity remain **fully available** in the owner file and are taught in full in the Basic block, but they are **not independently printed or PYQ-owned** in 2018-2025 and must be used only after the two-dogmas and holism burden is discharged. No module in this clause has been promoted to marks-essential core. That is itself examinable information: it tells you where the marks are, and where they are not.

Conceptual links - not current-affairs items

ANALYSIS: A live search of the window **2026-02-19 to 2026-08-19** found **no sufficiently direct, verified institutional or major academic development** to anchor this clause, and none is invented here. The topic's exam relevance is **static and syllabus-driven**. Where a present-day illustration is useful it is offered as **analysis**, carries no sourced factual claim, and is never presented as a current-affairs anchor: theory-choice under anomaly in any mature science illustrates the Duhem-Quine situation; machine translation between distant languages illustrates why behavioural fit underdetermines reference; and disputes about legal and moral personhood illustrate why a concept can be indispensable to a practice without being analysable into simpler parts.

Source trail for this block

Quine, "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951), *Word and Object* (1960), "Ontological Relativity" and "Epistemology Naturalized" (1968/69), *Philosophy of Logic* (1970); Strawson, "On Referring" (1950), *Individuals* (1959), *The Bounds of Sense* (1966); Grice and Strawson, "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956); Chomsky, "Quine's Empirical Assumptions" (1969); Davidson, "Radical Interpretation" (1973); Roger Gibson on Quine's system; Christopher Hookway; Gareth Evans; Paul Snowdon on Strawson and persons.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Compressed revision notes for the whole clause, in eighteen parts (A-R) matching the eighteen teaching sessions. These are recall notes, not a second telling of the teaching: definitions, exact formulations, dates, arguments in skeleton, comparisons, traps and answer routes. Read them last, and read them fast.

A. The clause, its two thinkers and what is not owned

- **Printed, verbatim:** *Quine and Strawson : Critique of Empiricism; Theory of Basic Particulars and Persons*. **Two limbs, one owner each.**
- **Quine (1908-2000)** owns the critique of empiricism. **Strawson (1919-2006)** owns basic particulars and persons. **WRONG:** There is no "Quine-Strawson doctrine".
- **The clash:** **Grice and Strawson, "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956)** - co-authored, British spelling *Defence*.
- **Corpus:** **9 of 112** parts, 2018-2025. **Quine 5** (2018 Q2(c), 2019 Q1(e), 2021 Q3(c), 2024 Q4(c), 2025 Q4(b)); **Strawson 4** (2018 Q1(e), 2020 Q3(b), 2021 Q3(b), 2023 Q4(a)). **Two each in 2018 and 2021; none in 2022.** Only 20-marker: **2023**, Strawson.
- **Fenced out:** verification principle/Vienna Circle **as doctrine** (Topic 07) · Hume, bundle self, induction (Topic 03) · Kant's synthetic a priori and transcendental deduction (Topic 04) · Russell's theory of descriptions (Topic 06) · meaning as use and the private-language argument (Topic 08) · **Strawson on freedom, resentment and reactive attitudes** (bounded, cross-owned, **no PYQ**) · personal identity, soul, immortality (Paper II).
- **The one legitimate joint sentence:** empiricism failed twice - about **confirmation** (Quine) and about **reference** (Strawson) - a **problem-field**, not a thesis.

B. Provenance and chronology - examiner-checked

- **1905** Russell "On Denoting" · **1906** Duhem *La Theorie physique* (Eng. tr. Wiener **1954**) · **1928** Carnap *Aufbau* · **1934** Popper *Logik der Forschung* (Eng. **1959**).
- **1936** Birkhoff and von Neumann, "The Logic of Quantum Mechanics", *Annals of Mathematics* - the **formal** non-distributive lattice.
- **1948** Quine "On What There Is" - the **criterion of ontological commitment**; source of the bound-variable slogan. WRONG: Not "Two Dogmas".
- **1950** Strawson "On Referring", *Mind* - **nine years before** *Individuals*; a **precursor**.
- **1951** Quine "Two Dogmas of Empiricism", *The Philosophical Review*, **January**; web passage at **Section 6**, "**Empiricism without the Dogmas**". Revised in *From a Logical Point of View* (**1953**).
- **1952** Strawson *Introduction to Logical Theory* - induction, **ch. 9** · **1956** Grice and Strawson "In Defence of a Dogma".
- **1959** Strawson *Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics* - basic particulars **Part I**, persons **ch. 3**; the phrase is in the **subtitle**.
- **1960** Quine *Word and Object* - radical translation, *gavagai*, stimulus meaning, analytical hypotheses, **ch. 2**; epigraph **Neurath's boat**.
- **1962** Strawson "Freedom and Resentment" - **not** a printed limb · **1966** *The Bounds of Sense* - "non-sequitur of numbing grossness".
- **1968** Putnam "Is Logic Empirical?" - the **claim** logic is empirically revisable; **later abandoned** · **1968** Quine Dewey Lectures, **1969** volume with "Epistemology Naturalized" · **1969** Chomsky "Quine's Empirical Assumptions".
- **1970** Quine *Philosophy of Logic* - "**change of logic, change of subject**"; **maxim of minimum mutilation** · **1973** Davidson "Radical **Interpretation**" · **1985** Strawson *Skepticism and Naturalism*.

C. Quine, dogma one: the circle of explication

- **Two classes** of analytic truth: **logical truths** ("No unmarried man is married") · truths reducible to them by **synonym-substitution** ("No bachelor is married"). Class 2 needs **synonymy**.
- **Route 1 definition** -> merely **records** an antecedent synonymy (except frankly stipulative cases) -> circular.
- **Route 2 interchangeability salva veritate*** -> in an **extensional** language over-generates ("**creature with a heart**" / "**creature with a kidney**"); repair by **necessity** -> necessity is intelligible for Quine only via analyticity -> circular.
- **Route 3 semantical rules (Carnap)** -> yields "**analytic-in-L**" by list; the general notion "semantical rule" is **no clearer** than analyticity.
- **Conclusion, exactly:** available explications fail to secure the **sharp foundational boundary**. WRONG: Not "analytic sentences are false"; WRONG: not "the word has no use".
- **Replacement: degrees of entrenchment.** ANALYSIS: Centrality is **not** a new definition of "analytic".
- **Objection:** Grice-Strawson 1956 -> **reply:** ordinary intelligibility ≠ theoretical legitimacy.

D. Quine, dogma two: reductionism, and the identity of the two dogmas

- **Radical form:** term-by-term translation into a sense-datum language (*Aufbau* 1928 as target). **Attenuated form:** each statement has its **own** confirming/disconfirming experiences.
- **Why the label:** it **reduces** sentence-meaning to a set of observation sentences.
- **FACT:** "*Our statements about the external world face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body.*"
- **Unit of empirical significance = the whole of science.** Not the term (already failed); not the sentence (the dogma being removed).
- **ANALYSIS: The two dogmas are at root identical:** "confirmed come what may" needs a contrast class of individually confirmed statements. Remove dogma 2 -> dogma 1 has nothing to contrast with.
- **WRONG:** Not "experience does not test belief" - only **atomistic** testing is denied.

E. Quine: confirmation holism and the web of belief

- **Field of force, boundary conditions = experience; periphery = observation sentences;** interior = physics -> mathematics -> **logic**.
- **Three options** on conflict: revise a **peripheral** belief · revise a **deep interior** statement · **plead hallucination**.
- **FACT:** "Any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system." - the conditional **is** the doctrine. **WRONG:** Never truncate.
- **FACT:** "Conversely, by the same token, no statement is immune to revision." - early essay includes **logic in principle**.
- **Governing virtues: simplicity, conservatism, fecundity;** later **minimum mutilation**.
- **Four consequences:** no sharp analytic/synthetic line · no sharp a priori/a posteriori line · **pragmatic** theory-choice · sentence-by-sentence meaning-criterion loses application (**ANALYSIS:** holistic verificationism is a further question).

F. Quine: the Duhem-Quine mechanism

- **(H & A) -> O;** observe **not-O;** **modus tollens*** gives only **not-(H & A)**. **Logic never names the conjunct.** Step 4: evidence and method still discriminate.
- **Duhem 1906: physics only; logic and mathematics exempt;** corollary - no automatic **experimentum crucis***; motive - philosophy of physics.
- **Quine 1951: all knowledge; nothing exempt;** corollary - confirmation holism plus underdetermination pressure; motive - the demolition of **dogma two**.
- **ANALYSIS:** The label is later shorthand for **two non-identical claims**. Say so.
- **The pair: Uranus** -> revise the auxiliary -> **Neptune**, Le Verrier and Adams, **1846** (shallow revision correct). **Mercury** -> same move -> "**Vulcan**" does not exist; correct revision was **general relativity, 1915** (deep revision correct). **No advance rule**.
- **Popper:** accepts the logic, answers **methodologically** (conventions about basic statements; no testability-reducing *ad hoc* rescues). **Lakatos: hard core + protective belt** -> a criterion of progress. **WRONG:** Popper does not deny Duhem-Quine.

G. Quine: the revisability of logic

- **1936 Birkhoff and von Neumann** - the **formal proposal** (non-distributive lattice). **1968 Putnam**, "Is Logic Empirical?" - the **claim** that the **distributive law** should be revised empirically; **Putnam later abandoned it**.
- **WRONG:** Never "Putnam/Birkhoff"; never merge dates.
- **1970 Quine, Philosophy of Logic** - "**change of logic, change of subject**" + **maxim of minimum mutilation**. The **later** Quine is a poor witness for the **earlier** Quine's boldest claim.
- **Formula:** no statement is revisable **by nature**, only **by choice**.
- **Verdict line:** holism is **right about confirmation and overstated about revisability**.

H. Quine: empiricism without the dogmas, and the 1956 clash

- **Kept:** sensory evidence · scientific naturalism · **no first philosophy**. **Dropped:** sentence-by-sentence reduction · the foundational analytic/synthetic boundary.
- Metaphysics against natural science -> a difference of **degree**; ontology settled by the same **pragmatic virtues** as theory-choice.
- **Grice-Strawson 1956:** the distinction is **ordinarily intelligible**; a usable distinction needs no **reductive analysis**; Quine sets the bar too high. **Reply:** usability ≠ theoretical legitimacy; the distinction's **philosophical work** collapses without a principled ground.
- **ANALYSIS:** The quarrel is about **standards of explication**. Name it; take a graded side.
- **2018 framing:** "a metaphysical article of faith" is **the paper's wording**, **WRONG:** not a verified verbatim Quine quotation. Three moves: **explication failure -> holism -> naturalism**. Kantian reply: transcendental conditions are not hypotheses in the web; Quine's rejoinder: that reasserts the privileged status in dispute.

I. Quine: ontological commitment

- **"On What There Is" (1948)**. Steps: **regiment** into quantificational form -> read what the **bound variables** must range over for the theory to be **true** -> those are the commitments.
- **Slogan**: "to be is to be the value of a bound variable" - a **canonical summary**, WRONG: not from "Two Dogmas".
- **Four cautions**: a criterion of **commitment**, not a rule of theory-choice · **paraphrase**, not word-counting (names can be paraphrased away; name-free quantification can carry commitment) · **"taste for desert landscapes"** = **parsimony**, not nominalism at any cost · the **indispensability argument** is associated with **Quine and Putnam**, not with the slogan alone.
- **Objection conceded**: rival **regimentations** display different commitments; the criterion is applied **after** theory and regimentation are chosen.

J. Quine: radical translation and gavagai

- **Terms**: **stimulus meaning** (assent-class + dissent-class) · **occasion** vs **standing** sentence · **observation sentence** (stimulus meaning **constant across speakers**) · **analytical hypotheses** (not determined by any evidence).
- **Rival readings of "gavagai"**: rabbit · **undetached rabbit-parts** · a **temporal stage** of a rabbit · **rabbithood** · feature-placing "it's rabbiting".
- **ANALYSIS**: **Cannot simply ask**: the identity question presupposes a translated **identity predicate**, articles, plurals, quantifiers - the **apparatus of individuation**, which is what is in dispute.
- **Two results**: **inscrutability of reference** (sub-sentential terms) -> **indeterminacy of translation** (rival manuals).
 - no determinate **meanings as entities**; **synonymy** loses its anchor; **dogma one** loses its key notion.
- **Premises**: **P1** behaviourism about the *evidence* ("in linguistics one has no choice") · **P2** total behavioural equivalence -> "no further fact" is a **substantive commitment** · **P3** naturalism.
- **Objections**: **Chomsky 1969** (ordinary underdetermination; the **asymmetry** presupposes naturalism) · **Searle/Evans** (reflexive application; Quine: **acquiesce in the mother tongue**) · innateness (restricts candidates, creates no fact) · **Davidson 1973** radical **interpretation** (indeterminacy confined, like a **measurement scale**).
- **Durable result**: use alone does not fix reference.

K. Quine: ontological relativity and naturalized epistemology

- **1968 lectures, 1969 volume**. WRONG: Never date naturalized epistemology to 1951.
- **Ontological relativity**: reference is fixed only **relative to a background theory**; regress of manuals; practical stop = **acquiescence in the mother tongue**. **ANALYSIS**: Distinct from the **1948 criterion**.
- **Naturalized epistemology**: epistemology becomes the scientific study of how **meagre input** yields **torrential output**; motive = the failure of **rational reconstruction**; image = **Neurath's boat**, epigraph of *Word and Object* (1960).
- **Normativity objection** -> **engineering reply** (method-selection studied from within science) -> **residual conceded**: continuity with science blocks first philosophy but does not **derive** norms from causal facts.

L. Quine: the criticism ledger and the Wittgenstein comparison

- **Seven rows** - objection -> reply -> **residual**: Grice-Strawson · analyticity "seems real" · revising logic · holism too extreme · normativity · regimentation-dependence · Chomsky's underdetermination. **Write the third column**.
- **Convergence with later Wittgenstein**: target - **museum myth / Augustinian picture** · holism - whole of science / the **practice** · anti-foundationalism - **Neurath's boat** / **"my spade is turned"** (*PI* Section 217) · rejection of the private - indeterminacy / the private-language argument.
- **Divergence, decisive**: Quine **reforms** language by **regimentation**; Wittgenstein **describes** it and holds ordinary language "is in order as it is" (*PI* Section 98). **ANALYSIS**: Different aims; no shared positive theory.
- **Quine's own label**: **empiricism without the dogmas**. WRONG: Never "Quine rejected empiricism"; WRONG: never "Quine is a logical positivist".

M. Strawson: descriptive against revisionary metaphysics

- **Descriptive** = describe the **actual structure** of our thought about the world. **Revisionary** = produce a **better** structure. Revisionary is at its best **in the service of** descriptive.
- **His own examples:** descriptive - **Aristotle, Kant**; revisionary - **Descartes, Leibniz, Berkeley**. WRONG: Two definitions with no examples is the recorded fatal error.
- **Method: connective analysis** - exhibit how concepts depend on one another; **not** reduction to a privileged base.
- **Three commitments:** conclusions about **our scheme** · arguments **transcendental in form** · an empiricist may accept the geography while denying the ontology. FACT: **Conceding this strengthens an answer**.
- **Objection:** circular/conservative -> **reply:** the task is **internal**; revision must begin inside some functioning scheme -> **cost:** description cannot prove the scheme uniquely correct.

N. Strawson: basic particulars and the identification argument

- **The question:** which particulars are such that the possibility of **identification and reference in general** depends on them?
- **Five steps:** identify -> requires **re-identify** -> requires **one unified spatio-temporal framework** -> **material bodies** are its **enduring, publicly observable** occupants anchoring **demonstrative** identification -> **dependent particulars** (experiences, events, sounds) are identified through relations to persons, bodies, places, times -> **bodies are basic**.
- ANALYSIS: The framework is a **condition of the scheme**, WRONG: not a psychological image built out of bodies.
- **Sense-data fail on three counts:** **private** (no public identification) · **momentary** (no re-identification) · **non-spatial** (no framework at all). □ bodies are basic as a **condition of the possibility of reference**.
- **Argument type:** WRONG: not Moore's proof of the external world; WRONG: not a causal claim; FACT: **transcendental in form**, conclusion about **our conceptual scheme**.
- **Support:** basic particulars are basic **objects of reference**; **feature-placing** ("It is raining here") need not identify a particular but does **not replace** the framework.
- ANALYSIS: **Two** kinds of basic particular: **material bodies and persons** - 2021 names both.

O. Strawson: the purely auditory world

- **Set-up:** only **pitch, timbre, loudness, temporal succession**; no space, no bodies.
- **Problem:** distinguishing **the same particular re-encountered** from a **new exactly-similar one**; qualitative resemblance cannot do it.
- **Result, exactly:** WRONG: **not** "such a world is impossible"; FACT: objective reference would require an **analogue of space**, often reconstructed through a continuously available **master-sound**.
- **Supports:** the need for a framework performing the **individuating role** space performs in our scheme. WRONG: Does not prove every scheme must contain bodies like ours.
- **Function in an answer:** the reply to the **anthropocentrism** objection; the evaluative core of **2020 Q3(b)**.

P. Strawson: persons, and the two classes of predicate

- **Person = one subject** bearing **M-predicates** (also true of mere bodies: "weighs 70 kg", "is in the kitchen", "has brown hair") and **P-predicates** (states of consciousness: "is in pain", "is thinking of Vienna", "believes it will rain", "intends to leave").
- FACT: *"The concept of a person is logically prior to that of an individual consciousness."*
- **Six steps:** self-ascribe P-predicates -> requires **other-ascription** of the same general kinds -> others identified as **embodied subjects** on **publicly available behavioural and situational criteria** (WRONG: not inference to a hidden Cartesian mind) -> P-predicates also **self-ascribable without observation** -> **dual character** -> the concept is **logically primitive**.
- **Two-way impossibility:** pure consciousness never reaches public criteria; pure body never reaches unobserved self-ascription. Only a subject already **both** satisfies both.

- **"Primitive" = conceptual priority.** WRONG: Not a third substance · WRONG: not unanalysable in every respect · WRONG: not materialism (which loses the P-predicates).

Q. Strawson: dualism, no-ownership and the mind-body implication

- **Cartesian dualism** fails twice: an **immaterial soul** cannot be identified or **re-identified** in the single framework identification requires; and **interaction** becomes unintelligible once the substances are separated.
- **No-ownership / no-subject theory** (reconstructed and criticised; traced through **Schlick** and Wittgenstein-influenced writers): experiences **causally dependent** on a body but not **possessed**. **Self-refutation:** to say which experiences, the theorist must say **"all the experiences that are had by this body"** - **"had by"** is possessive; causal dependence cannot single out **these** experiences.
- **Exact verdicts:** dualism's **starting point is undercut**, WRONG: not every dualist thesis disproved. No-ownership **reconstructs the personal framework it tried to avoid**.
- **Result:** the mind-body problem is **dissolved**, not solved - the decomposition generating it is **illicit**.
- **Cost, conceded:** "primitive" marks the **end of analysis**, not an explanation of the psychophysical nexus. Defenders: the demand for analysis into mind + body **already presupposes dualism**.

R. Strawson's bounded edge, the ledger and exam craft

- **"On Referring" (1950)** against Russell's **"On Denoting" (1905)**: existence **presupposed** by a use, not **asserted** in the analysis; the speaker **fails to make** a true-or-false assertion; **referring is what speakers do on occasions**; sentence-meaning ≠ use. ANALYSIS: **Truth-value caution:** this reports the unsuccessful **use**, WRONG: not a meaningless sentence-type; later presupposition theories divide between gap, falsity and pragmatic treatments. ANALYSIS: Not printed in the clause - fence it in one sentence.
- **Five bounded connections:** sense-data as basics (*Individuals* Pt I) · bundle self / no-ownership (ch. 3) · reconstruction detached from use ("On Referring", cross-owned) · induction (*Introduction to Logical Theory* 1952, optional) · objectivity from private data (*Bounds of Sense* 1966; *Skepticism and Naturalism* 1985, optional).
- **The recurring form:** undisputed fact -> its conditions -> the empiricist's materials **cannot** satisfy them -> something else is basic, **conceptually** not causally.
- **Two honest qualifications:** 1956 blocks the "united front"; **descriptive** metaphysics limits the conclusion to our scheme.
- **Strawson ledger (objection -> reply -> residual):** "primitive" as re-labelling · anthropocentrism · the unexplained psychophysical nexus · Russell's cleaner logic · circularity/conservatism.
- **Directive fidelity:** **"explain the theory of basic particulars"** -> an **argument from identification**, not a list · **"discuss the theory of persons"** -> refute **two** rivals · **"evaluate the role of spatio-temporal thinking"** -> remove space and see what fails · statement questions -> preserve the **conditional clause** · "critically/evaluate/do you agree" -> a **graded verdict**.
- **Four cheap marks:** cite "Two Dogmas" to **Section 6**; date the slogan to **1948**; name **Grice** alongside Strawson; quote the **subtitle** of *Individuals*.
- WRONG: **Never:** "Quine rejected empiricism" · "Strawson defended empiricism" · "Duhem and Quine hold the same thesis" · "Quine denied meaning *tout court*" · "Putnam/Birkhoff" · "basic particulars are atoms" · "person is primitive = dualism".

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

The data-complete, terminal-friendly master flow. The text below is byte-identical to the standalone artifact at notes\Final-Learning-Packages\Philosophy Optional\Philosophy Paper I - Western Philosophy\11-Quine-and-Strawson\04-ASCII-Master-Flowchart\ASCII-Master-Flowchart.txt.

=====

READ TOP TO BOTTOM. 42 PANELS. PURE ASCII. EVERY DATE, SECTION NUMBER, TECHNICAL TERM AND ATTRIBUTION IS EXAMINABLE AS PRINTED.

=====

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/42: THE PRINTED CLAUSE AND ITS TWO LIMBS

SYLLABUS, VERBATIM

'Quine and Strawson : Critique of Empiricism; Theory of Basic Particulars and Persons.'

NOTE: the paper prints a space before the colon. Preserve it ONLY inside a verbatim quotation of the syllabus.

|

THE TWO LIMBS DIVIDE CLEANLY - ONE OWNER EACH

LIMB 1 CRITIQUE OF EMPIRICISM QUINE 1908-2000

two dogmas, failed explications of analyticity, reductionism, confirmation holism, revisability, and empiricism without the dogmas

LIMB 2 THEORY OF BASIC PARTICULARS

AND PERSONS STRAWSON 1919-2006

descriptive metaphysics, identification and re-identification, the public spatio-temporal framework, material bodies, and the person as a primitive concept

|

THE ONE MOVE THE CLAUSE MAKES

CLASSICAL AND LOGICAL EMPIRICISM MADE TWO PROMISES:

- (i) every meaningful sentence can be sorted into TRUE BY MEANING and TRUE BY FACT, and checked against experience ONE AT A TIME
- (ii) the world can be rebuilt out of PRIVATE SENSORY GIVENS

QUINE breaks (i) FROM INSIDE EMPIRICISM.

STRAWSON shows (ii) CANNOT EVEN GET STARTED.

FATAL OPENING: 'The Quine-Strawson critique of empiricism holds that ...'

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/42: THE TWO-PROJECT WARNING - SAY THIS FIRST

THEY ARE NOT ALLIES. THE ONLY DOCUMENTED EXCHANGE IS A DISAGREEMENT.

GRICE AND STRAWSON, 'IN DEFENCE OF A DOGMA',

The Philosophical Review, 1956.

CO-AUTHORED with H. P. GRICE. British spelling: DEFENCE.

They defend the ANALYTIC/SYNTHETIC DISTINCTION that Quine attacked in 1951.

|

THE TWO PROJECTS, SIDE BY SIDE

QUINE		STRAWSON	
LEVEL	the THEORY OF CONFIRMATION	LEVEL	the STARTING POINT
MOVE	both dogmas fail; sentences face experience only as a CORPORATE BODY	MOVE	identification needs re-identification, which needs ONE public spatio-temporal framework
TOOL	logic + naturalism + behavioural evidence	TOOL	connective conceptual analysis, TRANSCENDENTAL IN FORM
RESULT	EMPIRICISM WITHOUT THE DOGMAS - he STAYS an empiricist	RESULT	MATERIAL BODIES and PERSONS are BASIC in our conceptual scheme

|

THE ONLY LEGITIMATE JOINT SENTENCE

Empiricism failed TWICE OVER: about how theories are CONFIRMED (Quine) and about how we so much as REFER (Strawson).

That is a PROBLEM-FIELD, not a shared thesis.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/42: OWNERSHIP AND THE CORPUS SIGNAL 2018-2025

9 PRIMARY-OWNED QUESTION-PARTS OUT OF 112.

QUINE - FIVE PARTS

2018 Q2(c) 15m a priori as 'article of

STRAWSON - FOUR PARTS

2018 Q1(e) 10m concept of person
 2020 Q3(b) 15m spatio-temporal

2019 Q1(e) 10m	faith' against the synthetic- analytic distinction			thinking and basic particulars
2021 Q3(c) 15m	empiricism without the dogmas		2021 Q3(b) 15m	material bodies AND persons as basic particulars
2024 Q4(c) 15m	nature of the two dogmas		2023 Q4(a) 20m	person as primitive; implication for mind-body dualism
2025 Q4(b) 15m	'affirm the truth of any sentence ...'			
				THE ONLY 20-MARKER IN THE CLAUSE IS STRAWSON'S, IN 2023.

YEAR DISTRIBUTION

2018 TWO | 2019 one | 2020 one | 2021 TWO | 2022 NONE
2023 one | 2024 one | 2025 one

CONSEQUENCE: frequent but NOT guaranteed. Prepare it to ANSWER, not to recognise. DECIDE THE OWNER FROM THE STEM BEFORE WRITING A LINE.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/42: THE OWNERSHIP FENCE - WHAT IS NOT OWNED HERE

VERIFICATION PRINCIPLE, AYER, CARNAP'S AUFBAU,
THE VIENNA CIRCLE as DOCTRINE Topic 07 Logical Positivism
(here ONLY as the position Quine dismantles)
HUME'S IMPRESSIONS AND IDEAS, THE BUNDLE
SELF, THE PROBLEM OF INDUCTION as DOCTRINE Topic 03 Empiricism
KANT'S SYNTHETIC A PRIORI, THE TRANSCENDENTAL
DEDUCTION, THE ANTI-NOMIES as DOCTRINE Topic 04 Kant
(here ONLY through the 2018 framing and Strawson's affinity)
RUSSELL'S THEORY OF DESCRIPTIONS as DOCTRINE Topic 06 Moore-Russell-
Early Wittgenstein
(here ONLY as the rival 'On Referring' answers)
MEANING AS USE, LANGUAGE-GAMES, THE PRIVATE
LANGUAGE ARGUMENT as DOCTRINE Topic 08 Later Wittgenstein
(here ONLY as a bounded comparison)
STRAWSON ON FREEDOM, RESENTMENT AND THE
REACTIVE ATTITUDES ('Freedom and
Resentment', 1962) BOUNDED / CROSS-OWNED.
NOT a printed limb. NOT PYQ-OWNED 2018-2025. One clause maximum.
STRAWSON ON INDUCTION (1952) AND ON KANT
(1966) bounded enrichment only
PERSONAL IDENTITY OVER TIME, THE SOUL,
IMMORTALITY Paper II
BOUNDED QUINE ENRICHMENT - TAUGHT IN FULL, USED AFTER THE PRINTED BURDEN
ontological commitment | radical translation and gavagai |
inscrutability | indeterminacy | ontological relativity |
naturalized epistemology
NOT independently printed and NOT PYQ-owned in 2018-2025.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/42: PROVENANCE RAIL, PART ONE - 1905 TO 1953

1905 RUSSELL, 'On Denoting'. The theory of descriptions.
Topic 06's property; the position 'On Referring' answers.
1906 DUHEM, La Theorie physique: son objet, sa structure.
Eng. The Aim and Structure of Physical Theory, tr. Wiener, 1954.
PHYSICS ONLY. LOGIC AND MATHEMATICS EXEMPT.
1928 CARNAP, Der logische Aufbau der Welt. The construction of the
world from private experience. Topic 07's property; the
programme Strawson's basic-particulars argument makes unworkable.
1934 POPPER, Logik der Forschung. Eng. 1959. ACCEPTS the logical
point of Duhem-Quine and answers it METHODOLOGICALLY.
1936 BIRKHOFF AND VON NEUMANN, 'The Logic of Quantum Mechanics',
Annals of Mathematics. The FORMAL proposal: a NON-DISTRIBUTIVE
LATTICE. NOT yet the claim that logic is empirical.
1948 QUINE, 'On What There Is', Review of Metaphysics.
THE CRITERION OF ONTOLOGICAL COMMITMENT IS DEVELOPED HERE.
'To be is to be the value of a bound variable' is the standard
slogan for it. IT IS NOT FROM 'TWO DOGMAS'.
1950 STRAWSON, 'On Referring', Mind. PRESUPPOSITION against
Russell's ASSERTED existence-claim. PREDATES Individuals by
NINE YEARS - a PRECURSOR, not an application of descriptive
metaphysics.
1951 QUINE, 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism', The Philosophical Review,

JANUARY 1951. The web-of-belief / field-of-force passage is
SECTION 6, 'Empiricism without the Dogmas'. CITE THE SECTION.
1953 From a Logical Point of View - 'Two Dogmas' REVISED and
reprinted. Both dates are correct for different versions.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/42: PROVENANCE RAIL, PART TWO - 1956 TO 1985

1952 STRAWSON, Introduction to Logical Theory. The dissolution of
the problem of induction, CH. 9. Optional.
1956 GRICE AND STRAWSON, 'In Defence of a Dogma',
The Philosophical Review. CO-AUTHORED. Spelling: DEFENCE.
1959 STRAWSON, Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics.
BASIC PARTICULARS: PART I. PERSONS: CH. 3.
The phrase is in the SUBTITLE - quote the subtitle, it is exact.
1960 QUINE, Word and Object. Radical translation, gavagai, stimulus
meaning, analytical hypotheses: CH. 2.
EPIGRAPH: NEURATH'S BOAT.
1962 STRAWSON, 'Freedom and Resentment'. NOT a printed limb.
1966 STRAWSON, The Bounds of Sense. The 'non-sequitur of numbing
grossness' charge against Kant's Second Analogy. Safe verbatim;
Strawson's own phrase. Belongs mainly to Topic 04.
1968 PUTNAM, 'Is Logic Empirical?' THE CLAIM that the DISTRIBUTIVE
LAW should be revised on EMPIRICAL grounds. Reprinted 1976.
PUTNAM LATER ABANDONED THE POSITION.
1968 QUINE, Dewey Lectures, 'Ontological Relativity'.
1969 Published in Ontological Relativity and Other Essays - the SAME
volume as 'EPISTEMOLOGY NATURALIZED'.
DO NOT DATE NATURALIZED EPISTEMOLOGY TO 1951.
1969 CHOMSKY, 'Quine's Empirical Assumptions', in Words and
Objections. ATTRIBUTE the underdetermination objection to
CHOMSKY, not to 'critics'.
1970 QUINE, Philosophy of Logic. 'CHANGE OF LOGIC, CHANGE OF
SUBJECT' and the MAXIM OF MINIMUM MUTILATION.
1973 DAVIDSON, 'Radical INTERPRETATION'. Interpretation, NOT
translation - the change of word marks the change of doctrine.
1985 STRAWSON, Skepticism and Naturalism. Transcendental arguments
limited to internal, descriptive work. Optional.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/42: DOGMA ONE - THE CLAIM UNDER TEST

THE DOGMA
There is a PRINCIPLED, NON-ARBITRARY line between
ANALYTIC = true by virtue of MEANING alone
SYNTHETIC = true by virtue of extra-linguistic FACT
WHY QUINE CALLS IT A DOGMA: the line cannot be drawn NON-CIRCULARLY.
|
THE TWO CLASSES OF ANALYTIC TRUTH - START HERE, NOT AT 'CIRCULARITY'
CLASS 1 LOGICALLY TRUE
'No unmarried man is married.'
True under EVERY reinterpretation of the non-logical words.
Quine GRANTS this class; it is not where the trouble lies.
CLASS 2 TRUE BY SUBSTITUTING SYNONYMS FOR SYNONYMS
'No bachelor is married.' Put 'unmarried man' for
'bachelor' and it BECOMES a Class 1 truth.
THIS class is the one that needs SYNONYMY.
|
THE QUESTION THAT DRIVES THE WHOLE PAPER
WHAT IS SYNONYMY? Three routes are available. Each returns to the
platform it left. PANELS 8, 9 AND 10 TAKE THEM IN ORDER.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/42: DOGMA ONE, ROUTE ONE - DEFINITION

THE PROPOSAL
'Two terms are synonymous when one is DEFINED as the other.'
The lexicographer defines bachelor as unmarried man.'
|
THE FAILURE
EXCEPT for FRANKLY STIPULATIVE definitions, a definition REPORTS a
synonymy that ALREADY OBTAINED in the language. The lexicographer
is an empirical scientist recording usage.
|
WHY THIS IS CIRCULAR - STATE IT PRECISELY
The circularity is in the EXPLANATORY ORDER, not in the sentence.

Definitions are not circular IN FORM. The objection is that a definition PRESUPPOSES the relation it was called in to explain.

|

WHAT QUINE CONCEDES

Stipulative definition DOES create synonymy - by fiat, in a new notation. It cannot ground the general notion for a language already in use.

TRAP: writing 'definitions are circular' misstates the objection.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/42: DOGMA ONE, ROUTE TWO - SALVA VERITATE

THE PROPOSAL

'Two terms are synonymous when they are INTERCHANGEABLE SALVA VERITATE - swapping them never changes a truth-value.'

|

FAILURE (a) - OVER-GENERATION IN AN EXTENSIONAL LANGUAGE

'CREATURE WITH A HEART' and 'CREATURE WITH A KIDNEY' are COEXTENSIVE, so they interchange freely - YET THEY ARE NOT SYNONYMOUS. The test admits pairs it should exclude.

|

THE PROPOSED REPAIR

'Then demand interchange inside NECESSARILY (...).'

|

FAILURE (b) - THE REPAIR PRESUPPOSES THE TARGET

The language must already contain a NECESSITY operator whose intelligibility, for Quine, rests on ANALYTICITY. So the repair presupposes exactly what was to be explained.

|

SHAPE OF THE ARGUMENT

WEAK TEST -> lets in too much. STRONG TEST -> assumes the answer. There is no setting of the dial that works.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/42: DOGMA ONE, ROUTE THREE - SEMANTICAL RULES

THE PROPOSAL (CARNAP)

'Analyticity is DEFINED for an artificial language L by explicit SEMANTICAL RULES. A sentence is analytic-in-L if the rules say so.'

|

WHAT IT DELIVERS

A LIST. We learn which sentences are analytic-IN-L.

|

WHAT IT DOES NOT DELIVER

The GENERAL explanatory notion. 'Semantical rule' is no clearer than 'analytic'. We learn the MEMBERSHIP of a set; we do not learn what MEMBERSHIP CONSISTS IN.

|

THE STRUCTURAL POINT

Relativising to L moves the problem, it does not solve it. The question 'what makes THESE the semantical rules?' is the original question in new clothing.

TRAP: treating 'analytic-in-L' as a successful definition of 'analytic' concedes the very generality Quine denies.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/42: DOGMA ONE - THE EXACT CONCLUSION

WHAT QUINE CONCLUDES

The AVAILABLE EXPLICATIONS FAIL to provide the clear, NON-QUESTION-BEGGING boundary that logical empiricism required.

|

WHAT QUINE DOES NOT CONCLUDE

NOT 'All bachelors are unmarried' is FALSE.
NOT the word 'analytic' has NO USE in any language.
NOT from ONE missing dictionary definition that EVERY use of 'analytic' is unintelligible.

|

WHAT REPLACES THE DISTINCTION

HOLISTIC REVISABILITY replaces categorical immunity with DEGREES OF PRACTICAL ENTRENCHMENT. Central statements are revised rarely; peripheral ones easily.

|

CENTRALITY CAUTION - THE MOST MISSED CONTROL ON THIS SUB-TOPIC

Practical entrenchment EXPLAINS why logic and mathematics are normally protected. IT IS NOT A REPLACEMENT DEFINITION OF

'ANALYTIC'. Presenting it as one converts a strength into an error.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/42: DOGMA ONE - THE OBJECTION AND THE REJOINDER

GRICE AND STRAWSON, 'IN DEFENCE OF A DOGMA', 1956

- 1 The distinction is ORDINARILY INTELLIGIBLE: competent speakers agree on cases WITHOUT theory.
- 2 A distinction in good working order is not discredited merely because no REDUCTIVE ANALYSIS of it is available.
- 3 Quine sets the bar TOO HIGH - he demands a non-circular DEFINITION where what we have is a usable DISTINCTION.

|

QUINE'S REJOINDER

ORDINARY INTELLIGIBILITY IS NOT THEORETICAL LEGITIMACY.
Agreement in classification does not supply the principled ground on which the POSITIVIST MEANING-CRITERION and the LINGUISTIC THEORY OF NECESSITY were resting.
Compare: speakers once agreed in applying 'witch' / 'non-witch'.

|

THE STANDING DISPUTE - NAME IT, THEN TAKE A GRADED SIDE

The quarrel is about STANDARDS OF EXPLICATION.
DEFENSIBLE VERDICT: Quine strongly pressures the distinction's FOUNDATIONAL use while leaving room for more modest semantic or ordinary classifications.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 13/42: DOGMA TWO - REDUCTIONISM IN TWO FORMS

THE DOGMA

Each meaningful statement has its OWN private stock of confirming or disconfirming experiences, so statements can be checked ONE AT A TIME.

|

RADICAL FORM

Every meaningful statement is TRANSLATABLE into a language of immediate experience, TERM BY TERM.
Historical exemplar: CARNAP'S AUFBAU, 1928.

|

ATTENUATED FORM

Give up translation. RETAIN the claim that each statement, taken alone, has its own range of confirming and disconfirming experiences.

|

WHY THE LABEL 'REDUCTIONISM' FITS - A CHEAP MARK MOST SCRIPTS MISS

The doctrine REDUCES the meaning of each sentence to a SET OF OBSERVATION SENTENCES. The name states the operation.

|

ONE OBJECTION DEFEATS BOTH FORMS

Both assume a SENTENCE-SIZED PARCEL OF EVIDENCE. Remove that and both collapse together.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 14/42: DOGMA TWO - THE CORPORATE BODY

THE CANONICAL SENTENCE - QUOTE IT EXACTLY

'Our statements about the external world face the tribunal of sense experience NOT INDIVIDUALLY BUT ONLY AS A CORPORATE BODY.'

|

THE UNIT OF EMPIRICAL SIGNIFICANCE

NOT the TERM that programme had already collapsed
NOT the SENTENCE that is the dogma being removed
BUT THE WHOLE OF SCIENCE

|

WHAT IS AND IS NOT DENIED

DENIED that experience bears on beliefs ONE AT A TIME
RETAINED that experience bears on belief AT ALL
THIS IS WHY THE RESULTING POSITION IS STILL CALLED EMPIRICISM.
TRAP: 'Quine denies that experience tests belief.' The tribunal still sits. It hears the SYSTEM.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 15/42: THE TWO DOGMAS ARE AT ROOT IDENTICAL

QUINE'S OWN ARCHITECTURAL JUDGEMENT

The two dogmas are AT ROOT IDENTICAL.

|

THE ARGUMENT

DOGMA 1 survives only if SOME statements are confirmed
INDEPENDENTLY OF EXPERIENCE - 'confirmed come what may'.

|

That contrast needs a CONTRAST CLASS: statements confirmed
INDIVIDUALLY by their own experiences.

|

DOGMA 2 supplies exactly that picture.

|

REMOVE DOGMA 2 -> DOGMA 1 HAS NOTHING TO BE A CONTRAST TO.

|

WHY THIS EARNS MARKS

It converts a LIST of two criticisms into an ARGUMENT with a
structure. It is the closing line of any 2024 Q4(c) answer.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 16/42: THE WEB OF BELIEF - THE STRUCTURE

SOURCE: 'Two Dogmas', SECTION 6, 'Empiricism without the Dogmas'.
THE MODEL: a WEB, or a FIELD OF FORCE, whose BOUNDARY CONDITIONS are
EXPERIENCE.

(o)	(o)	(o)	(o)	(o)	PERIPHERY: OBSERVATION
\	\		/	/	SENTENCES, in direct contact
\	\		/	/	with experience
[physics, chemistry, biology]					revised comparatively easily
[mathematics]					revised rarely
[LOGIC]					revised last; NEVER immune

WHAT THE PICTURE ASSERTS

Only the EDGE touches experience. The interior is connected to it
by inferential threads. A collision at the edge produces
RE-ADJUSTMENT INSIDE; the interior is not directly hit.

CAUTION: the periphery is OBSERVATION SENTENCES, NOT private
SENSE-DATA. Quine is REJECTING the sense-datum programme here, not
restating it.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 17/42: THE WEB - THE THREE REVISION OPTIONS

A CONFLICT ARRIVES AT THE EDGE. SOMETHING MUST GIVE. THREE THINGS
MAY BE DONE, AND EXPERIENCE DOES NOT CHOOSE BETWEEN THEM.

|

OPTION 1	REVISE A NEARBY PERIPHERAL BELIEF	easiest
OPTION 2	REVISE A DEEP INTERIOR STATEMENT	costly but
		open in
		principle
OPTION 3	PLEAD HALLUCINATION - revise the OBSERVATION	
	STATEMENT ITSELF	always
		available

|

WHY OPTION 3 MATTERS

It is what makes 'ANY statement can be held true come what may'
LITERALLY TRUE rather than rhetorical. Omit it and the famous
sentence looks like an exaggeration.

|

WHAT THE THREE OPTIONS ESTABLISH

Experience says 'SOMETHING HERE IS WRONG'.
Experience NEVER says 'THAT SENTENCE IS WRONG'.
The gap between those two sentences is the whole doctrine.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 18/42: THE TWO CANONICAL SENTENCES

SENTENCE ONE - THE 2025 Q4(b) QUOTATION

'ANY STATEMENT CAN BE HELD TRUE COME WHAT MAY, IF WE MAKE DRASTIC
ENOUGH ADJUSTMENTS ELSEWHERE IN THE SYSTEM.'

THE CONDITIONAL CLAUSE IS THE DOCTRINE.

It names the COST, and the cost is what DISCIPLINES the choice.
TRUNCATING IT AT 'COME WHAT MAY' PRODUCES RELATIVISM, WHICH IS
NOT THE DOCTRINE. This is the commonest way to fail 2025 Q4(b).

|

SENTENCE TWO - THE CONVERSE

'CONVERSELY, BY THE SAME TOKEN, NO STATEMENT IS IMMUNE TO
REVISION.'

The EARLY essay extends this IN PRINCIPLE even to a LAW OF LOGIC, mentioning the proposed revision of the law of EXCLUDED MIDDLE as a means of simplifying quantum mechanics.
IT DOES NOT FOLLOW that every revision is equally rational, or that logic is casually abandoned.

|
THE 2025 PAPER'S WORDING, FOR REFERENCE
'We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system, in the face of whatever experience, just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere.'

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 19/42: THE FOUR CONSEQUENCES OF HOLISM

-
- 1 NO SHARP ANALYTIC/SYNTHETIC LINE
Central logic and mathematics are highly entrenched and normally protected, but CENTRALITY MUST NOT BE EQUATED with a new definition of analyticity.
 - 2 NO SHARP A PRIORI / A POSTERIORI LINE
All beliefs are revisable in the light of experience, even those remote from the periphery.
 - 3 PRAGMATISM ABOUT THEORY-CHOICE
When revision is needed we choose on grounds of SIMPLICITY, CONSERVATISM and FECUNDITY - pragmatic virtues, NOT algorithmic rules.
 - 4 PRESSURE ON POSITIVIST MEANING-CRITERIA
SENTENCE-BY-SENTENCE reductionist verification is undermined.
WHETHER A HOLISTIC VERIFICATIONISM SURVIVES IS A FURTHER QUESTION - the paper does not settle it.

|
STATE CONSEQUENCE 4 CAREFULLY. Saying 'holism refutes verificationism' overstates the result and invites correction.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 20/42: WHAT BLOCKS ARBITRARY REVISION

THE OBJECTION
'If EVERYTHING is revisable, science has no fixed point at all, and rational belief has no constraint. Is holism even coherent?'

|
THE CONSTRAINTS - NAME THEM, OR THE OBJECTION STANDS
PREDICTIVE SUCCESS revisions must keep the system predicting
CONSERVATISM change as little as possible
SIMPLICITY prefer the economical system
FECUNDITY prefer the system that generates results
MINIMUM MUTILATION Philosophy of Logic, 1970

|
THE EXACT FORMULA
NO STATEMENT IS REVISABLE BY NATURE, ONLY BY CHOICE - and choice has COSTS.

|
WHAT HOLISM DOES AND DOES NOT LICENSE
LICENSES the RE-ALLOCATION OF BLAME across the system
DOES NOT indifference to evidence, or the claim that all
LICENSE revisions are equally warranted

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 21/42: THE DUHEM-QUINE ARGUMENT, NUMBERED

-
- 1 The testable claim is (H & A) -> 0
H = the hypothesis under test
A = the auxiliaries: background theory, INSTRUMENT THEORY, initial conditions
 - 2 Observation reports NOT-0
 - 3 By MODUS TOLLENS all that follows is NOT (H & A)
i.e. H is false OR some element of A is false
 - 4 LOGIC DOES NOT SAY WHICH CONJUNCT TO REJECT. Evidence, background knowledge and methodological virtues can still make some revisions far more reasonable than others.
 - 5 THEREFORE refutation is never conclusive against a SINGLE statement - and, symmetrically, 'any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system'.
 - 6 THEREFORE a reductionist criterion assigning each statement its own confirming experiences HAS NO APPLICATION. This attacks DOGMA 2 directly; it PRESSURES, but does not by itself refute,

every possible holistic verificationism.

|

PRESUPPOSITIONS - WHERE EVERY OBJECTION ENTERS

- P1 hypotheses generate predictions ONLY with auxiliaries
- P2 no fixed decomposition uniquely assigns every recalcitrant experience to ONE sentence
- P3 theory-choice employs PRAGMATIC VIRTUES alongside evidence

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 22/42: DUHEM AGAINST QUINE - TWO NON-IDENTICAL CLAIMS

	DUHEM (1906)	QUINE (1951)
SCOPE	PHYSICS ONLY. Physiology and certain other sciences CAN test hypotheses more nearly in isolation.	ALL OF KNOWLEDGE. 'The unit of empirical significance is THE WHOLE OF SCIENCE.'
LOGIC AND MATHEMATICS	EXEMPT. Duhem does not put them at risk.	INCLUDED. 'No statement is immune to revision', not even a law of logic.
CHIEF COROLLARY	There is no automatic EXPERIMENTUM CRUCIS against an isolated hypothesis, since auxiliaries are also in play.	Confirmation holism and underdetermination pressure. The stronger claim of rival total theories equivalent under ALL possible evidence needs FURTHER argument.
MOTIVE	Philosophy of physics; the practice of physicists.	The demolition of the SECOND DOGMA, reductionism.

=====

THE LABEL 'DUHEM-QUINE THESIS' IS LATER SHORTHAND FOR TWO NON-IDENTICAL CLAIMS. SAYING SO IS ITSELF A MARK.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 23/42: NEPTUNE AND VULCAN - DEPLOY BOTH

CASE ONE - URANUS

- Orbit conflicts with Newtonian prediction.
- > astronomers DO NOT abandon Newton's laws
- > they revise the AUXILIARY 'we know all the planets'
- > NEPTUNE IS FOUND. Le Verrier and Adams, 1846.
- > THE SHALLOW REVISION WAS CORRECT.

|

CASE TWO - MERCURY

- Perihelion conflicts with Newtonian prediction.
- > the SAME strategy posits the planet 'VULCAN'
- > VULCAN DOES NOT EXIST
- > the correct revision was the DEEP one: GENERAL RELATIVITY, 1915.
- > THE DEEP REVISION WAS CORRECT.

|

WHAT THE PAIR PROVES

- SAME LOGICAL SITUATION. OPPOSITE CORRECT RESPONSES.
- NO RULE SAYS IN ADVANCE WHICH TO CHOOSE.
- That is the thesis, HISTORICALLY DEMONSTRATED.

TRAP: citing NEPTUNE ALONE makes holism look like a recipe for saving theories. The PAIR shows it is a claim about the ABSENCE of a recipe.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 24/42: POPPER AND LAKATOS - THE REPLY THAT CONCEDES

POPPER - Logik der Forschung 1934; Eng. 1959

- ACCEPTS THE LOGICAL POINT ENTIRELY and denies its SCEPTICAL USE.
- Falsification is not an automatic logical process but a METHODOLOGICAL DECISION.
- Scientists agree BY CONVENTION to treat certain BASIC STATEMENTS as unproblematic for the purposes of a test.
- They FORBID AD HOC RESCUES that reduce a theory's TESTABILITY.
- RATIONALITY IS PRESERVED BY RULES OF METHOD, NOT BY LOGIC ALONE.

|

LAKATOS

- Develops this into RESEARCH PROGRAMMES with

a protected HARD CORE - not surrendered
a revisable PROTECTIVE BELT - where revision is taken
Duhem-Quine turned into a CRITERION OF PROGRESS.

|

TRAP TO AVOID

'Popper refutes Duhem-Quine.' HE DOES NOT. He grants the logic
and answers it with method. Misreporting this is a factual error
an examiner can check.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 25/42: THE REVISABILITY OF LOGIC - 1936 / 1968 / 1970

THE EARLY CLAIM (1951)

'No statement is immune to revision', applied even to the law of
EXCLUDED MIDDLE.

|

THE STRONGEST CANDIDATE - TWO ACTS, THIRTY-TWO YEARS APART

1936 BIRKHOFF AND VON NEUMANN, 'The Logic of Quantum Mechanics',
Annals of Mathematics. A NON-DISTRIBUTIVE LATTICE of
propositions. THIS IS A MATHEMATICAL PROPOSAL.

1968 PUTNAM, 'Is Logic Empirical?' THE CLAIM that LOGIC IS
EMPIRICAL - that the DISTRIBUTIVE LAW should be revised on
EMPIRICAL grounds. Reprinted 1976.

THIS IS A PHILOSOPHICAL CLAIM ABOUT THE FIRST.

NEVER WRITE 'PUTNAM/BIRKHOFF'. NEVER MERGE THE DATES.

PUTNAM LATER ABANDONED THE POSITION.

|

THE RESISTANCE - FROM QUINE HIMSELF

1970 Philosophy of Logic. 'CHANGE OF LOGIC, CHANGE OF SUBJECT':
anyone who 'denies' a law of logic has merely changed the
meaning of the connectives, so no genuine disagreement has
occurred. Plus the MAXIM OF MINIMUM MUTILATION.

|

THE HONEST VERDICT

HOLISM IS RIGHT ABOUT CONFIRMATION AND OVERSTATED ABOUT
REVISABILITY. The defensible position is DUHEM'S THESIS WITH
QUINE'S MOTIVATION. The LATER Quine is a poor witness for the
EARLIER Quine's most radical claim.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 26/42: EMPIRICISM WITHOUT THE DOGMAS

WHAT IS THROWN AWAY		WHAT IS KEPT
the analytic/synthetic		SENSORY EVIDENCE as the check on
boundary as a FOUNDATION		the system
confirmation of sentences		NATURALISM: philosophy is
ONE AT A TIME		continuous with science
a privileged class of truths		the demand that ontology be
IMMUNE to experience		answerable to the best theory

|

WHAT CHANGES

The boundary between SPECULATIVE METAPHYSICS and NATURAL SCIENCE
becomes a matter of DEGREE.

Ontological questions are decided, like scientific ones, by the
PRAGMATIC VIRTUES of the total system.

There is NO FIRST PHILOSOPHY standing outside science to certify
its foundations.

|

THE LABEL, AND WHY IT MATTERS

The section title is 'EMPIRICISM WITHOUT THE DOGMAS'. The word
'without' does all the work: SUBTRACTION, NOT REPLACEMENT.

CALLING THIS AN INTERNAL REFORM IS SAFER THAN CALLING QUINE EITHER
A LOGICAL POSITIVIST OR THE UNIQUELY PURIFIED EMPIRICIST.

NEVER WRITE: 'Quine rejected empiricism.'

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 27/42: THE 2018 FRAMING AND THE THREE MOVES

THE PHRASE

'A METAPHYSICAL ARTICLE OF FAITH' is the 2018 QUESTION'S FRAMING.

IT IS NOT A VERIFIED VERBATIM QUINE QUOTATION.

DO NOT PLACE IT IN QUOTATION MARKS AS QUINE'S OWN FORMULA.

|

WHAT QUINE DOES SUPPLY - THREE CONNECTED MOVES

MOVE 1 THE EXPLICATION FAILS. Kant's synthetic a priori
presupposes a workable analytic/synthetic boundary; the

circle of synonymy shows none is available.

MOVE 2 HOLISM. Statements face experience as a corporate body,
so NO BELIEF IS A PRIORI BY NATURE. Apparent apriority is
greater CENTRALITY in the web - a difference of DEGREE.

MOVE 3 NATURALISM. There is no first-philosophy standpoint from
which a priori knowledge could be certified. To assert it
is to take on trust what cannot be shown.

|

THE KANTIAN REPLY, AND THE REJOINDER

REPLY transcendental conditions of experience are not
empirical hypotheses inside the web, so revisability does
not reach them. Strawson's descriptive reading of Kant
gives this some support.

REJOINDER that reasserts precisely the privileged non-empirical
status in question.

VERDICT: Quine defeats a SHARP a priori/a posteriori boundary; a
gradient of entrenchment survives; the framework question stays open.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 28/42: ONTOLOGICAL COMMITMENT - BOUNDED ENRICHMENT

SOURCE: 'ON WHAT THERE IS', Review of Metaphysics, 1948.
NOT 'TWO DOGMAS'.

|

THE CRITERION, STEP BY STEP

- 1 REGIMENT the accepted theory into perspicuous QUANTIFICATIONAL
FORM.
- 2 READ OFF the entities that must lie in the RANGES OF THE BOUND
VARIABLES for the theory to be TRUE.
- 3 THOSE are the theory's ONTOLOGICAL COMMITMENTS.
- 4 'TO BE IS TO BE THE VALUE OF A BOUND VARIABLE' is the standard
SLOGAN. Treat it as a canonical summary, not as a guaranteed
verbatim sentence.

|

FOUR CAUTIONS - EACH IS A MARK

- 1 A criterion of COMMITMENT, not a rule for CHOOSING an ontology.
- 2 NOT surface word-counting: names can be PARAPHRASED AWAY, and
apparently name-free quantification can carry commitment.
- 3 'TASTE FOR DESERT LANDSCAPES' = PARSIMONY, not nominalism at any
cost. Quine accepts abstract entities where the best regimented
science INDISPENSABLY quantifies over them.
- 4 The INDISPENSABILITY ARGUMENT is associated with QUINE AND
PUTNAM together, not with the slogan alone.

|

THE OBJECTION, CONCEDED BY DESIGN

Rival PARAPHRASES display different commitments -> the criterion is
applied AFTER theory and regimentation are chosen. It AUDITS; it
does not CHOOSE.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 29/42: RADICAL TRANSLATION - THE EVIDENCE AND THE TERMS

SOURCE: WORD AND OBJECT, 1960, CH. 2. Epigraph: NEURATH'S BOAT.
THE SITUATION: a field linguist enters a community whose language has
no known relation to any other. NO dictionary. NO bilingual
informant. NO shared script. The only evidence is WHAT SPEAKERS ARE
EXPOSED TO and WHAT THEY ASSENT TO OR DISSENT FROM.

|

THE EXACT PRINTED SUBTERMS - EACH IS A DISTINCT DEVICE

STIMULUS MEANING	the class of stimulations that would prompt ASSENT to a sentence, paired with the class that would prompt DISSENT
OCCASION SENTENCE	assent commanded only when FRESHLY PROMPTED ('Gavagai', 'It's raining')
STANDING SENTENCE	assent PERSISTS without prompting ('Copper conducts electricity')
OBSERVATION SENTENCE	an occasion sentence whose stimulus meaning is CONSTANT ACROSS SPEAKERS of the community - THE ONLY PLACE TRANSLATION IS SECURE
ANALYTICAL HYPOTHESES	the linguist's posited segmentation of native sentences into words and grammatical apparatus, projected BEYOND the observational base. THESE ARE NOT DETERMINED BY ANY EVIDENCE.

|

STATUS: BOUNDED ENRICHMENT. Taught in full; used only AFTER the

two-dogmas and holism burden is discharged.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 30/42: GAVAGAI - THE NINE-STEP ARGUMENT

- 1 A rabbit runs past; the native utters 'GAVAGAI'. The linguist notes assent under rabbit-stimulation and records 'RABBIT'.
- 2 The SAME stimulus meaning is equally compatible with 'UNDETACHED RABBIT-PARTS' - wherever a rabbit is, they are 'A TEMPORAL STAGE OF A RABBIT' - likewise co-extensive 'RABBITHOOD' - an instantiation of the universal 'IT'S RABBITING' - a feature-placing sentence with NO OBJECT
- 3 Could he simply ASK, 'is this gavagai the same as that one?' NO. That question requires him to have ALREADY TRANSLATED the IDENTITY PREDICATE, the articles, plurals and quantifiers - the entire APPARATUS OF INDIVIDUATION, which differs across languages and is EXACTLY WHAT IS IN DISPUTE.
- 4 Any evidence he collects can be ACCOMMODATED by COMPENSATING ADJUSTMENTS: a different translation of 'gavagai' offset by a different translation of 'same'. The two manuals predict IDENTICAL behaviour throughout.
- 5 THEREFORE INSCRUTABILITY OF REFERENCE: behavioural evidence does not uniquely determine whether a term refers to rabbits, undetached rabbit parts or rabbit stages.
- 6 Extending upward from TERMS to SENTENCES, rival ANALYTICAL HYPOTHESES generate manuals that agree on ALL observation sentences yet translate theoretical and non-observational sentences into NON-EQUIVALENT English.
- 7 THEREFORE INDETERMINACY OF TRANSLATION: incompatible manuals can fit the total behavioural evidence without a further meaning-fact selecting one.
- 8 THEREFORE there are no determinate MEANINGS as entities; SYNONYMY has no behavioural anchor; and DOGMA ONE'S KEY NOTION IS LEFT WITHOUT FOUNDATION. Gavagai is the CONSTRUCTIVE COMPLETION of 'Two Dogmas'.
- 9 ONTOLOGICAL RELATIVITY is the broader thesis that reference is specified RELATIVE TO A BACKGROUND THEORY. Keep it distinct from the 1948 criterion of commitment.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 31/42: TAXONOMY CONTROL - FOUR DOCTRINES, FOUR UNITS

DOCTRINE	UNIT AT ISSUE	CLAIM
RADICAL TRANSLATION	method/situation	translation built from publicly available evidence with no prior dictionary
INDETERMINACY OF TRANSLATION	sentences / MANUALS	incompatible manuals can preserve the TOTAL evidence
INSCRUTABILITY OF REFERENCE	SUB-SENTENTIAL TERMS	reference can vary under compensating changes in the individuation apparatus
ONTOLOGICAL RELATIVITY	FRAMEWORKS	reference is fixed only RELATIVE TO a background theory

KEEP THE 1948 CRITERION OUT OF THIS TABLE. It asks what a REGIMENTED THEORY QUANTIFIES OVER. Relativity asks RELATIVE TO WHAT reference itself is fixed. Two questions, two dates, two jobs.
TRAP: using 'indeterminacy' and 'inscrutability' interchangeably.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 32/42: OBJECTIONS TO INDETERMINACY, AND THE PREMISES

- THE PREMISES - STATE THEM; EVERY OBJECTION ENTERS HERE
- P1 BEHAVIOURISM ABOUT THE EVIDENCE. Quine's own formulation: in psychology one may or may not be a behaviourist, but IN LINGUISTICS ONE HAS NO CHOICE, since language is learned wholly from publicly observable behaviour.
 - P2 THE EVIDENTIAL STEP. The move from total behavioural

equivalence to 'NO FURTHER FACT' is a SUBSTANTIVE QUINEAN COMMITMENT, not a neutral consequence every holist accepts.
P3 NATURALISM. There is no first-philosophy standpoint from which to certify meanings; physics fixes what facts there are.

OBJECTION -> REPLY -> RESIDUAL

CHOMSKY 1969 indeterminacy is merely ORDINARY UNDERDETERMINATION; if that does not make physics factless, why translation?
REPLY: in physics there IS a fact our theories imperfectly track; in translation there is NOTHING BEYOND DISPOSITIONS to verbal behaviour for a manual to be right about.
RESIDUAL: whether the ASYMMETRY can be defended without begging the question is THE central dispute. NAME IT AND TAKE A SIDE.
SEARLE; EVANS applied reflexively it entails that I DO NOT DETERMINATELY KNOW WHAT I MEAN by my own words.
REPLY: Quine accepts a version - at home we ACQUIESCE IN OUR MOTHER TONGUE; the first-person case has no privileged status, only a DEFAULT one. RESIDUAL: many find the bullet too large.
CHOMSKY, INNATENESS universal grammar would cut down the space of admissible manuals.
REPLY: the residual manuals would still be behaviourally equivalent; innateness RESTRICTS CANDIDATES, it does not CREATE A FACT OF THE MATTER. RESIDUAL: genuinely open.
DAVIDSON 1973 radical INTERPRETATION shows more determinacy once CHARITY and a TRUTH-THEORY are built in.
REPLY/POSITION: Davidson ACCEPTS indeterminacy but confines it to something like a choice of MEASUREMENT SCALE - Fahrenheit against Celsius - real but harmless. THE MOST INFLUENTIAL SOFTENING.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 33/42: ONTOLOGICAL RELATIVITY AND NATURALIZED EPISTEMOLOGY

DATES FIRST: DEWEY LECTURES 1968; VOLUME 1969, WHICH ALSO CONTAINS 'EPISTEMOLOGY NATURALIZED'. NEVER DATE EITHER TO 1951.

ONTOLOGICAL RELATIVITY

THESIS what a term refers to is settled only RELATIVE TO a background theory or translation manual.
ROUTE inscrutability generalised: to specify the reference of a term you must use ANOTHER language, whose reference is fixed only relative to a further background - a REGRESS.
STOPPING in practice we ACQUIESCE IN OUR MOTHER TONGUE and take its POINT reference at face value. A DEFAULT, not a privilege.

NATURALIZED EPISTEMOLOGY

THESIS epistemology becomes a chapter of empirical psychology: the scientific study of how MEAGRE SENSORY INPUT yields TORRENTIAL THEORETICAL OUTPUT.
MOTIVE the collapse of the Cartesian and Carnapian foundational projects. If the world cannot be RATIONALLY RECONSTRUCTED from experience, the remaining question is HOW THE CONSTRUCTION IS IN FACT ACHIEVED.
IMAGE NEURATH'S BOAT - we are sailors who must rebuild the ship ON THE OPEN SEA; there is NO DRY DOCK.
The epigraph of Word and Object, 1960.

THE NORMATIVITY OBJECTION

A causal story about how belief is ACQUIRED appears to replace 'What OUGHT one to believe?' with 'How is belief PRODUCED?'

QUINE'S REPLY

Prediction, truth-seeking and method-selection can be studied and improved FROM WITHIN science - a naturalized normative ENGINEERING of inquiry.

THE RESIDUAL - CONCEDE IT

Continuity with science BLOCKS FIRST PHILOSOPHY but does not by itself DERIVE epistemic norms from causal facts.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 34/42: THE QUINE CRITICISM LEDGER - WRITE THE THIRD COLUMN

OBJECTION	REPLY	RESIDUAL
GRICE AND STRAWSON 1956: pre-theoretically clear; we CAN sort cases	the PHILOSOPHICAL WORK done by the distinction collapses without a principled	a live debate about STANDARDS OF EXPLICATION

	ground	
ANALYTICITY SEEMS REAL: 'bachelors are unmarried' differs in KIND from 'all swans are white'	he challenges its foundational EXPLICATION	web-centrality is not a full semantic REPLACEMENT theory
REVISING LOGIC IS EXTREME: has anyone ever done it?	quantum logic: 1936 formal proposal; 1968 empirical claim	the LATER Quine (1970) is a poor witness for the EARLIER Quine
HOLISM IS TOO EXTREME: if EVERYTHING is revisable, science has no fixed point	logic and mathematics revisable IN PRINCIPLE, held fixed in practice by conservatism	no statement is revisable BY NATURE, only by CHOICE
NATURALIZATION LOSES NORMATIVITY	method-selection and prediction ENGINEERED from within science	are truth-conducive norms EXPLAINED or merely ASSUMED?
COMMITMENT DEPENDS ON REGIMENTATION	correct - applied AFTER theory and regimentation chosen	the criterion AUDITS; it does not CHOOSE
INDETERMINACY COLLAPSES INTO ORDINARY UNDERDETERMINATION (CHOMSKY)	translation differs: nothing beyond behavioural dispositions	the asymmetry PRESUPPOSES the naturalism it is meant to support

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 35/42: QUINE AND LATER WITTGENSTEIN - BOUNDED COMPARISON

TWO TRADITIONS, NO DIRECT INFLUENCE, A STRIKING CONVERGENCE.		
AXIS	QUINE	LATER WITTGENSTEIN
TARGET	the MUSEUM MYTH of meaning - words as labels on determinate mental objects	the AUGUSTINIAN PICTURE - words as names of objects
POSITIVE ACCOUNT	STIMULUS MEANING for suitable occasion sentences; theoretical language is HOLISTIC	meaning is USE within a language-game and a form of life
HOLISM	the unit is THE WHOLE OF SCIENCE	a word has meaning only within the PRACTICE
ANTI-FOUNDATION- ALISM	NEURATH'S BOAT - rebuild at sea, no dry dock	bedrock where 'MY SPADE IS TURNED' (PI 217)
REJECTION OF THE PRIVATE	indeterminacy permits nothing beyond public behaviour to fix meaning	the private-language argument shows nothing private CAN fix meaning
METHOD	epistemology NATURALISED	philosophy as THERAPY - description, not theory
WHERE THEY PART - DECISIVELY	Quine REFORMS language - a SCIENTIFIC account and REGIMENTATION into canonical notation	Wittgenstein DESCRIBES it and forbids theory: ordinary language 'IS IN ORDER AS IT IS' (PI 98)

=====

USE CAUTIOUSLY. The overlap pressures PRIVATE or MENTALISTIC fixers of meaning. IT DOES NOT ESTABLISH ONE SHARED POSITIVE THEORY. Wittgenstein's own doctrines belong to TOPIC 08.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 36/42: STRAWSON - DESCRIPTIVE AGAINST REVISIONARY METAPHYSICS

DESCRIPTIVE	REVISIONARY
describes the ACTUAL structure of our thought about the world	proposes a BETTER structure to replace the actual one

METHOD: CONNECTIVE ANALYSIS -		METHOD: RECONSTRUCTION from a
show how concepts hang together;		preferred set of simples
no concept analysed away into a		
privileged base		
STRAWSON'S OWN EXAMPLES:		STRAWSON'S OWN EXAMPLES:
ARISTOTLE, KANT		DESCARTES, LEIBNIZ, BERKELEY

THE RELATION - NOT MERE OPPOSITION

REVISIONARY METAPHYSICS IS IN THE SERVICE OF THE DESCRIPTIVE. It is instructive precisely because it shows WHAT IS LOST when a feature of the actual scheme is dropped.

WHAT THE PROGRAMME COMMITS STRAWSON TO

- (a) conclusions concern OUR CONCEPTUAL SCHEME, not a theory-free proof of mind-independent reality
- (b) the arguments are TRANSCENDENTAL IN FORM
- (c) an empiricist may ACCEPT the whole of Individuals as excellent CONCEPTUAL GEOGRAPHY while DENYING that it settles what exists. THIS IS THE STRONGEST REPLY AVAILABLE TO THE EMPIRICIST, AND CONCEDING IT STRENGTHENS AN ANSWER.

OBJECTION -> REPLY -> COST

CIRCULAR OR CONSERVATIVE: it protects the scheme used to state its own conditions -> the task is avowedly INTERNAL; radical revision and scepticism must BEGIN within some functioning scheme -> DESCRIPTION ALONE CANNOT PROVE THE SCHEME UNIQUELY CORRECT.

SOURCE: Individuals, 1959. The phrase is in the SUBTITLE.

FATAL ERROR: two definitions with NO EXAMPLES.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 37/42: STRAWSON - BASIC PARTICULARS, THE FIVE-STEP ARGUMENT

THE QUESTION - ASK IT PROPERLY FIRST

Of all the PARTICULARS we can identify and refer to - tables, persons, events, sounds, sense-data, numbers - which are ONTOLOGICALLY BASIC IN OUR CONCEPTUAL SCHEME, i.e. which are the items on which THE POSSIBILITY OF IDENTIFICATION AND REFERENCE IN GENERAL depends?

THE ARGUMENT (Individuals, 1959, PART I)

- 1 To IDENTIFY a particular we must DISTINGUISH it from other particulars and RE-IDENTIFY it across time.
- 2 Re-identification requires a SINGLE, UNIFIED SPATIO-TEMPORAL FRAMEWORK - one space and one time in which all particulars have locations.
- 3 MATERIAL BODIES are ENDURING, PUBLICLY OBSERVABLE occupants of that framework and provide the standard anchors for DEMONSTRATIVE identification and re-identification. CAUTION: the framework is NOT a psychological image BUILT OUT OF bodies. It is a CONDITION of our scheme.
- 4 Many DEPENDENT particulars - experiences, events, sounds - are identified THROUGH their relations to PERSONS, BODIES, PLACES and TIMES.
- 5 THEREFORE MATERIAL BODIES ARE BASIC: presupposed by the identification of everything else, and not themselves identifiable only by reference to something more basic.

SUPPORTING - REFERENCE AND PREDICATION

Basic particulars are basic OBJECTS OF REFERENCE. The subject-predicate structure of ordinary discourse depends on IDENTIFYING something and then PREDICATING something of it. FEATURE-PLACING expressions such as 'It is raining here' need not identify a particular in full subject-predicate form, but they DO NOT REPLACE the framework through which particular-reference becomes possible.

TRAP: 'basic particulars = atoms or ultimate simples'. They are MACROSCOPIC bodies and PERSONS. NOT microphysical.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 38/42: WHY SENSE-DATA FAIL, AND THE PURELY AUDITORY WORLD

THE EMPIRICIST'S CANDIDATE: SENSE-DATA AS THE BASIC PARTICULARS

(Russell's logical constructions; Carnap's Aufbau; phenomenalism)

THREE DEFECTS, EACH INDEPENDENTLY FATAL

- DEFECT 1 PRIVATE -> cannot ground PUBLIC identification
- DEFECT 2 MOMENTARY -> cannot be RE-IDENTIFIED

DEFECT 3 NON-SPATIAL -> lack the spatial relations needed to
CONSTITUTE a framework at all
THEREFORE material bodies are BASIC - NOT as a metaphysical
preference but as A CONDITION OF THE POSSIBILITY OF REFERENCE.

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THE PURELY AUDITORY WORLD - THE REMOVAL TEST

SET-UP a scheme containing ONLY sounds: pitch, timbre, loudness
and TEMPORAL SUCCESSION. No space. No bodies.
PROBLEM objective re-identification needs to distinguish 'the
SAME particular encountered again' from 'a NEW particular
exactly resembling the first'. Qualitative similarity
alone cannot do this.
RESULT a world of pitch and succession alone does NOT YET
support robust objective re-identification.
STRAWSON'S DISCUSSION DOES NOT SIMPLY PROVE AN AUDITORY
SCHEME IMPOSSIBLE. Objective reference would require an
ANALOGUE OF SPACE - often reconstructed through a
continuously available MASTER-SOUND - that can organise
sounds into a public-like framework.
SUPPORTS the need for a framework performing the INDIVIDUATING
ROLE that space performs in OUR scheme.
DOES NOT that every conceivable scheme must contain visual and
PROVE tactile material bodies EXACTLY LIKE OURS.

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WHAT KIND OF ARGUMENT THIS IS

NOT a proof of the external world (contrast Moore).
NOT a causal or scientific claim about perception.
TRANSCENDENTAL IN FORM, in a Kantian spirit: from our PRACTICE of
objective identification to the CONDITIONS of that practice.
CONCLUSION about the STRUCTURE OF OUR CONCEPTUAL SCHEME.
THIS PANEL IS THE EVALUATIVE CORE OF 2020 Q3(b).

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 39/42: STRAWSON - PERSONS AS A PRIMITIVE CONCEPT

THE THREE POSITIONS ON THE TABLE (Individuals, 1959, CH. 3)

CARTESIAN DUALISM	two substances; experiences belong to an IMMATERIAL SOUL
NO-OWNERSHIP /	experiences are CAUSALLY DEPENDENT on a body
NO-SUBJECT THEORY	but are NOT literally POSSESSED by a person
PERSON AS PRIMITIVE	the concept is LOGICALLY PRIMITIVE - not analysable into body plus mind

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THE PREDICATE MATRIX - BOTH CLASSES ON ONE SUBJECT

M-PREDICATES (material) also applicable to MERE BODIES
'weighs 70 kg' | 'is in the kitchen' | 'has brown hair'
P-PREDICATES (personal) ascribing STATES OF CONSCIOUSNESS
'is in pain' | 'is thinking of Vienna' | 'believes it will rain'
| 'intends to leave'
A PERSON IS NOT A BODY TO WHICH A MIND IS ATTACHED. It is a single
concept of an entity that is EQUALLY the subject of both.
'THE CONCEPT OF A PERSON IS LOGICALLY PRIOR TO THAT OF AN
INDIVIDUAL CONSCIOUSNESS.'

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THE ARGUMENT - SELF-ASCRPTION REQUIRES OTHER-ASCRPTION

- 1 I ascribe experiences to MYSELF: 'I am in pain.'
- 2 A NECESSARY CONDITION is that I can ascribe predicates of the
same general kinds to OTHERS.
- 3 Others are identified as EMBODIED SUBJECTS, and psychological
predicates are other-ascribed on PUBLICLY AVAILABLE BEHAVIOURAL
AND SITUATIONAL CRITERIA. NOT a simple inference from bodily
movements to a hidden Cartesian mind.
- 4 But P-predicates must ALSO be self-ascribable WITHOUT
OBSERVATION.
- 5 This DUAL CHARACTER belongs to PREDICATES OF PERSONS.
- 6 THEREFORE the concept of a person is LOGICALLY PRIMITIVE. This
is CONCEPTUAL PRIORITY, not the postulation of a third Cartesian
substance.

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THE TWO-WAY IMPOSSIBILITY - WHY IT IS AN ARGUMENT, NOT A STIPULATION
From a PURE CONSCIOUSNESS you never reach public criteria.
From a PURE BODY you never reach ascription without observation.
ONLY A SUBJECT THAT IS ALREADY BOTH SATISFIES BOTH CONDITIONS.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 40/42: THE TWO RIVALS DESTROYED, AND THE EXACT VERDICT

CARTESIAN DUALISM - TWO FAILURES

IDENTIFICATION how do we ever IDENTIFY or RE-IDENTIFY an immaterial soul? We cannot locate it in space, and identification requires ONE framework.

INTERACTION once the substances are separated, their commerce becomes unintelligible.

STRAWSON'S MOVE he does NOT ask how mind and body interact; he shows that THE QUESTION PRESUPPOSES A PRIOR UNITY THAT NEITHER TERM CAN SUPPLY.

NO-OWNERSHIP - SELF-REFUTATION IN ONE MOVE

To state the thesis the theorist must specify WHICH experiences. He says: 'ALL THE EXPERIENCES THAT ARE HAD BY THIS BODY'. 'HAD BY' IS A POSSESSIVE RELATION. Contingent causal dependence cannot replace it, because dependence does not single out THESE experiences rather than any others.

HE THEREFORE RECONSTRUCTS THE PERSONAL FRAMEWORK HE SET OUT TO AVOID. (The view is traced through SCHLICK and Wittgenstein-influenced writers, and RECONSTRUCTED AND CRITICISED by Strawson.)

THE EXACT VERDICT - WRITE THIS, NOT MORE

DUALISM treats independently identifiable mind and body as conceptually prior. Strawson's analysis UNDERCUTS THAT STARTING POINT; it does NOT by itself prove every metaphysical dualist thesis false.

NO-OWNERSHIP eliminates the person while relying on a UNIQUELY RELEVANT BODY and a class of experiences; it RECONSTRUCTS the framework it tried to avoid.

OVERALL the mind-body problem is DISSOLVED rather than SOLVED: the decomposition that generates it is ILLICIT.

THE COST 'PRIMITIVE' MARKS THE END OF ANALYSIS RATHER THAN AN EXPLANATION of the psychophysical unity - legitimate for descriptive metaphysics, unsatisfying for anybody who wanted the problem SOLVED.

TRAP: refuting ONLY dualism. The chapter turns on the SECOND rival.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 41/42: THE ANSWER-WRITING SPINE, PART ONE

STEP 1 DECIDE THE OWNER FROM THE STEM

two dogmas | analytic | synthetic | reductionism | web of belief | affirm any sentence | a priori as article of faith | empiricism without the dogmas QUINE

basic particulars | material bodies | spatio-temporal | person | primitive concept | mind-body dualism | descriptive metaphysics STRAWSON

'critique of empiricism' with no further signal QUINE LEADS;

Strawson enters as ONE bounded paragraph, never as co-author.

STEP 2 DECODE THE DIRECTIVE - AND AVOID ITS FATAL ERROR

EXPLAIN THE THEORY OF BASIC PARTICULARS -> an ARGUMENT FROM IDENTIFICATION. FATAL: listing what a basic particular is.

DISCUSS THE THEORY OF PERSONS -> the PRIMITIVENESS argument against TWO rivals. FATAL: refuting only dualism.

EVALUATE THE ROLE OF SPATIO-TEMPORAL THINKING -> REMOVE space and see what fails. FATAL: describing space and time.

COMMENT ON THE QUOTATION -> the CONDITIONAL CLAUSE is the doctrine; modus tollens, then Neptune/Vulcan. FATAL: quoting the first half and calling it relativism.

EXAMINE THE ANALYTIC/SYNTHETIC DISTINCTION -> the failed explications as a CHAIN. FATAL: inferring from one missing definition that nothing can be called analytic.

DISTINGUISH DESCRIPTIVE FROM REVISIONARY -> give STRAWSON'S OWN EXAMPLES. FATAL: two definitions with no examples.

CRITICALLY / EVALUATE / DO YOU AGREE -> a GRADED VERDICT.

FATAL: a balanced summary with no ruling.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 42/42: THE ANSWER-WRITING SPINE, PART TWO

STEP 3 RUN THE SPINE

QUINE dogma 1 (circle) -> dogma 2 (reductionism) -> holism (web + both quotations) -> Duhem-Quine (modus tollens,

Neptune/Vulcan) -> limits (minimum mutilation, 1970) ->
verdict (empiricism reformed, not abandoned)
STRAWSON descriptive vs revisionary -> identification needs
re-identification needs ONE framework -> sense-data are
private, momentary, non-spatial -> MATERIAL BODIES BASIC
-> persons: M + P predicates on ONE thing ->
self-ascription requires other-ascription -> dualism AND
no-ownership both presuppose what they deny -> verdict

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STEP 4 CLOSE WITH THE QUALIFICATION THAT LIFTS THE ANSWER

QUINE the result is the FAILURE OF AN EXPLICATION, not the
claim that 'all bachelors are unmarried' is false.

STRAWSON the result is about OUR CONCEPTUAL SCHEME; an empiricist
can accept the whole of Individuals as conceptual
geography while denying that it settles what exists.
CONCEDING THIS STRENGTHENS THE ANSWER.

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FOUR CHEAP MARKS

cite 'Two Dogmas' to SECTION 6 | date the bound-variable slogan to
1948 | name GRICE alongside Strawson | quote the SUBTITLE of
Individuals

NEVER WRITE

'Quine rejected empiricism' | 'Strawson defended empiricism' |
'Duhem and Quine hold the same thesis' | 'Quine denied meaning
tout court' | 'Putnam/Birkhoff' | 'basic particulars are atoms' |
'person is primitive = dualism'

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END OF ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM - 42 PANELS
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